# Dear Glimmer

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40160721.

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General Audiences

**Archive Warning:**
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Multi

**Fandom:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

**Relationship:**
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

**Character:**
Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra)

**Additional Tags:**
Inspired by To All The Boys I've Loved Before, Fake/Pretend Relationship, Slow Burn, Confessions, Love Letters, Drama & Romance, eventual polyamory, Alternate Universe - High School, Alternate Universe - No Powers, Human Catra (She-Ra)

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# Dear Glimmer

by GlitraHasConsumedMe


Summary

Glimmer has fallen in love a few times in her life, each one documented in love letters she swore would never be mailed out to the objects of her attention. But when those letters get sent out by catastrophic accident, what happens when the letters- and her feelings- reach those she'd kept locked away in ink and paper?

Or: The "To All the Boys I've Loved Before" inspired AU no one asked for


Notes

I swore I'd never make an AU of a Netflix movie but after reading this fic called "scorpio rising" (Amphibia fans please check it out you won't regret it) I was tempted to give it a go myself after seeing how well the author has pulled it off so far (props to @hereforthehurts here on Ao3 how does it feel to have written one of the like 10 fics I cannot stop myself from thinking about no matter what I do)

Hope you enjoy my first real attempt at a slowburn romance story, kudos and comments appreciated!<3

- Inspired by scorpio rising by hereforthehurts

# Prologue

Glimmer Moonbright had lived next door to Bow Fletcher for as long as she could remember, summers spent running through sprinklers until they were soaked to the bone and winters of snowball fights and snow angels dating back as some of her earliest memories spent in her family's modest brick home. She and Bow had spent countless nights in Glimmer's room, telling scary stories and watching cheesy movies and playing any dumb slumber party game they could imagine before falling asleep in piles on the floor, sleeping bags abandoned in trade for one of the girl's larger blankets to sleep on.

But those days were over now, as well as the life Glimmer had always known and loved.

Bow managed to graduate a year early, which meant these final summer days would be her last chance to see her best friend before he was whisked away to some grand college campus full of people intellectually compatible with him. A place he would totally fit in and find better friends than average-grade Glimmer.

"Hey , don't look so down," He said during what would surely be their last sleepover for months, possibly a year. "Where's the super cool, super awesome Glimmer I know and love?" He smiled at her , offering a handkerchief (a handkerchief! what teenager still carried around handkerchiefs in this day and age? where would she find someone as dorky and adorable as Bow ever again?) to dry her ever-flowing tears.

"I'm sor- sorry ."She sobbed, only crying harder when the boy pulled her into his chest for comfort.

"It's gonna be okay , Glim. I'll only be a plane ride away! I'll text you every day, and we'll call every Saturday after dinner just like we planned."He said softly , not wanting to be too loud and risk Glimmer's parents waking up to the sounds of her crying or his reassurances.

"But you won't- Y ou won't be *here*, Bow."She struggled to say around the lump in her throat. "I *need* you."

Bow sighed, kissing the top of her head like they were kids again and she'd scraped her knee. "I know . I'll visit as often as I can, I promise."He said, holding her even tighter as she gripped his shirt weakly. "Y ou're my *best* friend, Glimmer. You can't get rid of me this easily, it's gonna take more than a country-wide distance and grueling college courses to keep me from finding time for my favorite person."

She smiled softly at that, using the cloth to wipe her tears and snot (gross) before clearing her throat as she pulled herself back a bit. "Y ou *promise* we'll call on Saturdays? Even with the time difference?"

He laughed quietly , a look of relief on his kind face. "I already figured out how to schedule it into my day, even if I'm busy somehow. Which I don't plan to be, so you better keep your evening free, too."He

scolded lightly, playfully nudging her as she easily rolled onto her back with the movement to gaze up at the star and moon shaped projections playing across her ceiling from the humidifier her aunt had gifted her years ago.

"I will." She promised, watching the mist shift and flow around the lights like clouds against the night sky.

---

The day arrived entirely too soon, with Glimmer barely managing to pull herself out of bed to make her way down the stairs for breakfast. To her surprise, a familiar face was waiting at the dining room table in the seat across from Bow.

Adora Ryder, Glimmer's across-the-street neighbor and crush for who knows how long.

She played it cool as she plopped down beside her best friend, glancing at him from the corner of her eye as he shrugged with a smile that said he didn't expect her to be there, either.

Bow knew of Glimmer's- admittedly *strong*- feelings for Adora, and had for years. He had even helped her write out a letter to her when they were thirteen, to "get it out of her system." A failed plan on their parts, considering her heart still couldn't seem to calm down no matter how many shared classes they spent together or how often

they'd visited each other's houses since Adora moved in when Glimmer was eight years old (eight years without the prettiest girl on the planet, according to her).

The butterflies were quickly doused in bug spray, however, when the reality of what today was hit her in the face again after the initial shock wore off. Right, Bow was leaving. Leaving Glimmer for bigger and better things (that he totally deserved, but didn't lessen the hurt).

Breakfast was had with cheerful encouragement and praise from both Bow and Glimmer's parents about Bow's scholarship, hyping him up for what the girl didn't doubt would be the coolest years of his life.

Glimmer was happy for him, really.

Once everyone finished their eggs and toast the two families- accompanied by Adora- ushered out the door carrying bags and suitcases to be loaded into the hatch of his father's van as Bow's dad hugged him from the side to declare how proud he was.

Bow caught Glimmer's gaze and smiled sadly, waiting for his father to let go before hugging her tightly as she barely stopped herself from crying. She'd been crying too much the entire week, she couldn't let Bow see her cry on his big day.

The families loaded into their respective cars as the girl's mom began backing out of the driveway to follow the Fletchers to the airport.

Glimmer let her head thud against the window just in time to see Adora running down the sidewalk beside the car housing her best friend, waving exaggeratedly with that big smile Glimmer fell for. Suddenly, she didn't feel like crying so much.

---

"Make sure to keep us updated as well, young man. You're family, too." Angella- her mother- scolded Bow lightly, unshed tears shimmering in her eyes as Glimmer tried not to feel sick at the sight. Her mother *never* cried, at least in front of anyone but her dad.

"And don't go to any parties alone. That goes for anywhere, though. Safety in numbers!" Her dad, Micah, chimed in, resting a hand on his wife's shoulder.

Bow laughed through his tears (Bow was always a crier) to hug the adults close. It was common for Bow and Glimmer to be as affectionate with each other's parents as they would with their own, both being considered members of the two families.

"I know, I know. I'll text you guys *just* as often as I text my dads, I promise." He said with a quivering smile, clearly holding back a sob

just like Glimmer found herself doing.

Glimmer looked down at her phone for a distraction, scrolling through photos she'd been taking all summer as she bit her lip with a smile. Dozens of pictures of Bow by her side, making silly faces and stupid poses with various backgrounds from the places they'd been these precious months. She didn't look up until a warm hand took the device from her gently, tilting her chin up with his free hand to reveal a tear-stained, smiling face.

"Where's my hug?" He asked with a weak laugh, opening his arms wide as Glimmer surged into them with a whimper.

"Come back soon." She whispered into his neck as Bow squeezed tighter in response.

"I promise." He muttered, chin resting on her shoulder as the vibration of his voice echoed into her bones and very soul.

And just like that, he was waved through security, up an escalator, and out of her life.

Now Glimmer was alone.

# Chapter One

The first day of school came entirely too fast for someone still mourning the loss (get a *grip*, Glimmer) of her life-long best friend. She pulled on her pink white-washed denim jacket over a lavender v-neck with some black leggings, her movements sluggish the entire time she moved around her room until finally stumbling out and down the stairs so slowly a snail could have passed her. Probably.

"There's my little girl!" Micah cooed once she reached the bottom, pinching his daughter's cheeks as Glimmer whined and squirmed out of his reach. "Who's ready for her last first day?" He chuckled as she rolled her eyes in amusement.

"I'm eighteen, dad, do we really have to do this *every year*?" She whined as a small chalkboard she'd made the frame for herself when she was four was passed into her hands, a large number 12 written in her mother's signature swirling handwriting.

"It's a tradition! Now come on, smile!" He encouraged as her mother stepped closer with her ancient flip phone camera to snap yet another picture she'd most likely print out at the store once she left for school.

"Great! Picture taken, breakfast please." She said, setting the board down on the dining room table as she slid into her dad's chair. She couldn't sit in her own, not when she knew the chair beside it would remain empty now.

If her parents noticed her seat change, they didn't bring it up. Glimmer was grateful for that.

She set her dishes in the sink and kissed both of her parents on the cheek before grabbing her bag, slinging it over her shoulder to tie up the bubblegum pink laces of her sky blue high top sneakers. (What, cotton candy is a great color palette!)

She made her way outside, pointedly ignoring her father's joking sobs of "she's all grown up!" and "look at our little girl go!" as she walked down to the bus stop. She's meant to get her license with Bow last year, but he had been studying for finals and she hadn't wanted to take his attention away from something he considered so important. Besides, taking the bus wasn't *so* bad.

Adora rode the bus, too.

Or, she had been since the second-to-last week of school (not that Glimmer had been paying close attention to the girl's change in schedule). Adora was a private sort of person, but gossip said that she had broken up with her girlfriend- and ride to school- just before summer break, and apparently it was serious this time.

Adora saw her and offered an awkward smile, obviously not wanting to talk about why she was riding the bus. Glimmer respected her privacy and sat in the seat adjacent to her , not saying a thing about it. She saw the tension leave the blonde's shoulders from the corner

of her eye at that, and smiled softly to herself knowing she brought the girl even a moment of peace.

They may not be friends, but it was nice to have her crush look her way every once in a while.

---

School was always rough for Glimmer, but she hadn't anticipated just *how* rough a schoolyear without Bow would be until she entered the too-large halls crowded with a sea of students alone.

Bow wasn't the only early graduate in their year, but she couldn't seem to escape the overlapping conversations from his friends (Bow was always a social butterfly;Glimmer envied him for that) about his departure and it soon became too much to handle.

She quickly rounded the corner with her gaze lowered to the ground, seeing the other pair of shoes all too late as she crashed into someone and tumbled to the ground with them.

"Hey , watch where you're-" the voice cut of f and Glimmer blinked her eyes into focus on none other than Catherine Felina- known by "Catra" to anyone who didn't want to be beaten to a pulp (and Adora's *ex*, Glimmer reminded herself). "Oh, hey Moonbright." She said upon noticing who had fallen with her, signature smirk settling comfortably over her features like any other expression was

unnatural for her. The hint of a canine showed when she spoke, and Glimmer found herself entranced by it until snapping from her thoughts with a quick shake of her head.

"I'm so- I'm *so* sorry, let me-" she cut herself off, scrambling up to her feet to offer Catra a hand. The brunette laughed and allowed Glimmer to tug her to her feet as her heterochromic eyes bore into her for a moment that felt like forever, blue-green and hazel-gold staring back into Glimmer's own light brown eyes that only reminded her of muddy water any time she caught a glimpse of them in the mirror.

"It's all good." Catra chuckled, dropping her hand as Glimmer ignored the stirring in her heart as she did so (Glimmer barely knew her, she barely knew anything about her, she chanted in her mind). She crouched to pick up both of their bags in one swift, graceful movement, handing the pink haired girl's over as her gaze eyed her locks briefly with an amused exhale. "Try to look *up* next time, got it? Not everyone's gonna be as understanding." She teased, poking her forehead slightly as she took a step back and turned on a heel.

"Later, Sparkles!" She called as she strode away, *knowing* it would earn an eyeroll from her. Glimmer had hated that nickname ever since she accidentally dropped her glitter volcano down her shirt during the eighth grade science fair (hey, a sparkling baking soda volcano seemed like a *great* idea at the time!) in front of her entire science class.

Catra had saved her from the dozens of kids pointing and laughing at her, offering her sweatshirt to cover up Glimmer's wet, invisible

shirt and nudging her into Bow's arms so he could get her cleaned up, and Glimmer had loved her ever since. That day earned Catra a matching letter to her blonde ex only *day* after Adora's had been written, safely stored miles away in Bow's new dorm room where no one would *ever* see it.

---

By lunch, Glimmer was certain that she would be friendless the entire year. It was so late into their highschool lives that friend groups and cliques had already long been established, and with only one friend under her belt all that time, it seemed finding a place to sit would be impossible.

So she sighed, took her totally-mature black lunchbox (purple sequins were for people of all ages!) and made her way to the forgotten, overgrown track field at the edge of the school's expansive yard, sitting down on the rusty bleachers with a sad creak to eat her spring rolls and ham and cheese sandwich.

"Glimmer!" She heard distantly, wondering if she had actually heard it.

"*Glimmer*!" The voice came again as the girl whipped her head to the side to see a living goddess- or, well, *Adora*- jogging her way. "Hey!" She greeted cheerfully, hands on her knees as she panted with effort, a soft smile still gracing her tired features.

"Oh, uh, hey Adora." She said back, hoping she only imagined the crack in her voice. "What are you doing here?" She asked, scooting over to make room for the athletic girl.

"I came to find *you*, obviously." Adora chuckled, voice still rasping and breathing almost as fast as Glimmer's heart (she wondered idly if her heart was beating faster than Adora's just then, despite the fact that Adora had ran the length of the schoolyard and Glimmer had walked there at a turtle's pace).

"Me?" Glimmer pointed to her chest as Adora nodded with a grin that made her head spin.

"You." Adora chuckled. "I wanted to see how you were doing, you didn't look so hot in calculus." She said, very clearly trying to hide the worry in her tone despite the fact that Adora Ryder was a notoriously awful actress. (If their fourth grade play was anything to go off of, where Adora had read her lines so loud and awkwardly that the auditorium was filled with the piercing ring of her microphone. Glimmer found it utterly adorable as she stood on the side as her *humble* role of Commoner Number Two.)

"*Nobody* looks hot in calculus." Glimmer joked, internally smacking herself for her lameness. Thankfully Adora seemed to find it funny enough to laugh (either that or it was a pity laugh, but she'd take what she could get).

"That's true. But really , are you okay?" Adora asked, scooting only *slghtly* closer to rest her elbows on her knees and look at her.

Glimmer pushed the butterflies in her stomach down, willing her heart to get out of her stomach and her throat to swallow its forming lump of nerves as she nodded and exhaled her held breath slowly . "Y eah, I'm okay." She said quietly , not trusting her voice to stay intact if she raised it any more.

"That's good. And hey , I'm just right across the street if you ever need something, right?" Adora said, her grey-blue eyes twinkling like the stars and golden hair reflecting the very *sun* as she looked at Glimmer with nothing but kindness. She could only nod, struck speechless by the sight.

"R-Right." She forced out, looking down at her nearly finished lunch to avoid staring any longer.

"Okay . Great talk, see you around!" Adora said as she literally *jumped* to her feet- the movement somehow elegant and strong and poised and-, lightly punching her shoulder (it landed soft enough to barely count as a touch, but Glimmer still reveled in the action) before jogging back to her group of friends kicking a ball back and forth between them. Glimmer watched her greet her friends with a grin and side hugs and felt her chest tighten, thinking about what she couldn't- would *never*- have.

Adora's true, undivided attention.

# Chapter Two

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer stood mostly alone in the gymnasium, dribbling a basketball idly as she was certain she wouldn't be able to make a basket if she tried (why embarrass yourself if you know you can't do something? there's no shame in knowing your limits.). It was the second week of school, and she had only chosen to take gym this year because she had failed it the year before (stupid asthma), but it was somehow three times as awful as before knowing Bow wasn't there to keep her occupied as the class did mindless forms of physical activity, most of her classmates only there for an easy passing grade.

A tap on her shoulder startled her into dropping the ball at her feet, turning around slowly to see Catra Felina in all her glory. Hair matted with sweat to her forehead, freckles perfectly reflected in the bright lights above them, heterochromic eyes boring right into her.

Only, wait, something was off. Her smirk looked nervous, and she was looking at Glimmer's forehead rather than meeting her eyes.

That's when her eyes trailed down to notice it. In Catra's left hand, resting on her hip and crinckled slightly, was a torn envelope. A *familia* envelope, decorated with Glimmer's blue, glittery gelpen ink.

Her letter. It's words still burned into her mind from countless rereadings of the thing since she had written it five years ago:

*Dear Cal,*

*You're the coolest girl on the planet. Do you know that? Your smirk captivates me every time I see it, your piercing eyes fail to catch my attention no matter what I'm doing, your freckles like the most beautiful constellation of stars mapped onto your cheeks. I can never look away from you, no matter how hard I try. You're like the moon, and I'm the tide. You move effortlessly through the sky and I get pulled towards you, my arms reaching up but never able to touch you. Because that is what you are, a dream I have. Impossible. Amazing. When you saved me from embarrassment at the science fair, I wrapped myself in your sweatshirt and it felt like I was in your arms, helping me stop crying as nothing else seemed to matter. Even if I got the best mark in class for ruining my project, I couldn't stop smiling. Did you see me smile, and did you notice me? Of course not, you're Cal. You have better things to look at than me. But a girl can dream, right? Wish I could hold your hand and walk by your side down the hall, safe from bullies and annoying kids who only see me as a spoiled brat because of how I look or dress. Because no one would ever look at me in a mocking or teasing way if you were there, you'd scare off the monsters after me. Because you're fearless, and perfect, and pretty and kind. Even though you try to hide it, I know you are.)*

*Love,*

*Summer Moonbright*

*PS. I love you.*

Glimmer felt sick, her head spinning as she barely comprehended anything Catra was saying. How long had the girl been talking to her?

"-so I'm really flattered, and I don't want to hurt your feelings or let you down or anything, but I just got out of a relationship! I'm sorry, but-"

Glimmer cut her off, afraid to hear the rejection spoken out loud. "How did you get that letter?" She asked, her voice full of the panic she felt as she stared into Catra's eyes, full of pity and embarrassment. Oh god, she was *such* and idiot!

"Uh, in the mail?" Catra shrugged, stuffing the envelope and letter into her pocket like it meant nothing. Of course she did, because Catra was too cool for love letters. Of *course* she was. Stupid, stupid, *stupid*!

"Right." Glimmer would've forced a laugh if she wasn't holding on to all of her oxygen to stop herself from passing out.

She opened her mouth to speak when she heard the gym's door pushing open along the wall away from them to reveal Adora, an identical envelope held delicately in her hands as she pushed the door open with her elbow and stared at Glimmer with widened eyes.

Oh no, Adora had her letter, too. Her cheesy, cringy, embarrassing letter.

*Dear Adora,*

*I was only eight years old when I first saw you, carrying boxes stacked higher than your head on wobbling legs into the house across from mine, too stubborn to ask your mom for help carrying them. I thought you looked so cute, I couldn't find the courage to turn my bike in your yard sped down the sidewalk to circle the block again so I wouldn't have to look away any more. I've never been able to look you in the eyes, because I've been so afraid that if I did, you'd turn me to stone or blind me or make me explode into a billion gold pieces and fly away in the wind. I don't know , you seem magical enough for that to be possible. During our sleepovers, I sometimes wake up in the middle of the night and just listen to you breathe, wondering what you could be dreaming about. Do you ever dream of me? Am I even on your mind? I stay completely still until you snore or roll over to break the spell you hold on me, imagining how it would feel to run my fingers through your sun-kissed hair , to but you linger than a second or two. I can never touch you for too long, I'm so scared that I'll break you. Because you're perfect, and I don't want to ruin you. So I stay far from you, even though what I want is to lie on my bed beside you watching dumb movies as you hold me beneath a pile of blankets. Just the two of us. You shine brighter than the sun, and you're warmer than it could ever dream to be. Because you're like Aurora Borealis , star of the girl's lacrosse team, fastest runner in our grade, and girl of my dreams.*

*Love,*

*Summer Moonbright*

*P.S. Wonder if you'd ever kiss me, please?*

Okay. No. Nope! She could *not* do this right now.

Before Catra could start speaking again, Glimmer pushed her hard in the chest and *ran.* Ran to the other door at the opposite side of the gym, out of the room and down the hall until she made it to the girls' bathroom, locking herself in the nearest stall with a resounding *slam*.

She pulled out her phone with trembling hands, tears welling in her eyes as she looked at all of the text messages from Bow, all dating back to this morning when she had put her phone on silent after the initial buzzes during her first class.

So *that's* what all the buzzing was about.

**Bow 💗** ***7:24AM***

Glimmer

**Bow 💗** ***7:24AM***

Call me

**Bow 💗** ***7:26AM***

My new roommate found your letters when he was helping me unpack and thought they were REAL LETTERS so he sent them out and I JUST found out I am SO SORRY

**Bow🤍** ***8:04AM***

Glimmer please open your messages, I think your letters already arrived

**Bow🤍** ***8:04AM***

Glim I'm so sorry, I didn't mean for them to ever be found

**Bow🤍** ***8:17AM***

Please call me

**Bow🤍** ***8:40AM***

I'm so sorry Glimmer

This was it, this was her divine punishment for not applying herself in school. She was going to be publicly humiliated for writing love letters to people she knew she couldn't have even if she tried.

A knock on the stall startled her as she put the phone back in her pocket, trying to quiet her crying with a snif f. "Uh, occupied!" She called weakly, voice trembling with her lips.

"Y eah, I kind of got that." A girl's voice replied. A vaguely familiar one…

"Mer- Mermista?" Glimmer tried, peeking through the thin crack of the stall door to see if her assumption was correct.

"Yeah, Mermista." The girl repeated, sarcastic as ever.

Glimmer heard the sound of paper rustling as something was slipped through the crack, nearly hitting her in the face.

Another letter, one she nearly forgot about entirely.

*Dear Mermista,*

*I know we don't know each other well, so in case you need reminding, I'm the girl you danced with at the Spring Fling. (The pink-haired one, in case you danced with anyone.) I just wanted to thank you, and tell you that you looked really pretty in your dress that night. I was too nervous to tell you to your face, sorry. I was so worried I had made a mistake going alone since my only friend (Bella Fletcher, the nice one in class) was dancing with some of his friends and I don't have any other friends. But then you came, and you said your stupid date had ditched you (which he's stupid for, since you're clearly one of the prettiest girls I've ever) and you offered me a dance. I don't know if you were taking pity on me, or just trying to be nice, or if it was some kind of dare (no offence, but I wouldn't put that past you) but it made my night. I still think about it sometimes, and how pretty you looked with the colored lights shining down on you as you twirled me through a song that wasn't fast or slow. You were dashing. I*

*that the right word to use here? I think it is). I never forget that night, and it's thanks to you.*

*Love,*

*Glimmer Moonbright*

*PS, I think you're super cool* ♡

She scanned the forgotten document over, reading it again and again as her breathing came out loud and quick with an oncoming panic attack.

It wasn't just Catra and Adora. All of her letters had been sent. Every last one; ending with Mermista's letter , the last one she had written.

How many did she write, again? How many times was she going to be confronted about them? Couldn't people just read and forget?

"You still in there, Glimmer?" Mermista's voice brought her out of her spiral enough to unlock the door, tugging it open as her red, teary face met the taller girl's. Mermista's brows raised with more emotion than Glimmer had ever seen the girl use before. "Woah, calm down. I'm not gonna lynch you, or whatever." She said, voice still monotonous despite her surprised expression.

"Y-You're not?" Glimmer asked, hating how frightened and weak she sounded.

"No? Why would I? I mean, you know I have a boyfriend, right? Or , fiance, I guess." The girl rolled her eyes, but there was a hint of fondness there. "I just came to ask why you'd send me a letter knowing I'm taken. You don't seem like the 'bold' type. Especially considering the way you called my man stupid, like, *twice.* " She asked, crossing her arms with a smirk to lean back against the bathroom wall behind her.

"I-I didn't-" she took a deep breath, palms pressing into her closed eyes to stop her flow of tears. (She didn't care how wet and damaged the letter in her hands became, she never wanted to see any of them again.) "I wrote that letter *years* ago. Like, *three years ago.* I didn't think you'd ever see it." She explained.

"Oh." Was all Mermista said, followed by the squeak of her shoe on the tile. "That makes more sense." She said with a hum.

"Is that all you have to say?!" Glimmer snapped, feeling underwhelmed by her reaction. "Aren't you, like, creeped out? I wrote you a *love letter!* " She tried, hoping to spark *some* kind of reaction as she uncovered her eyes in time to catch a shrug of indifference, watching Mermista check and pick at her manicured nails.

"Who cares? You wrote it a long time ago, right? Or do you still have some kind of crush on me?" She asked, her voice full of intrigue suddenly as she glanced up from her hand at Glimmer with her smirk returned.

"What?! No!" Glimmer said, rapidly shaking her head.

"Then what's the problem? Sure, it was *really* dorky," Glimmer winced, "but it's just a letter. It's like an old fashioned way to send a text, only like, *super* mushy and cheesy."

Glimmer groaned, thunking her head back against the side of the stall door as she raked a hand over her face. "Well, I guess I'm relieved to hear that you aren't mad. You aren't- You won't *tell* anyone, right?" She asked, looking Mermista in the eye.

"And feed you to the gossip wolves? What do you take me for?" The girl scoffed, frowning. "No, I'm not telling anyone."

Glimmer sighed deeply in relief, feeling like all of her bones simultaneously turned to mush as she slumped back against the stall support. "Thank *god.*" She said, earning an amused huff of laughter from the other girl.

"Well, that's all I had to say. But just so you know, I saw Adora with one of those letters and I think she's looking for you." She said, turning Glimmer's blood to ice all over again. "See ya." Mermista added, opening the door to leave.

Once she was gone, Glimmer felt her earlier fear creep back in. Right, Catra and Adora still had their letters. This was still bad. *More* than bad. *Catastrophic.*

She pulled out her phone and hit the emergency contact button, clicking the first name on the list as it thankfully picked up after the second ring.

"Dad? I need you to pick me up."

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Lying back on her bed with a cold, damp rag over her eyes, Glimmer sighed. She had long since run out of tears, and after sending Bow a text letting him know that she wasn't angry and needed some time to herself, had shut off her phone to curl up in bed. By the time she had finally lifted the rag from her eyes and finished the plate of dinner her dad had brought to her, the last streaks of light were just barely shining in from the setting sun.

"*It's pretty, isn't it?*" She heard Adora's voice, sounding too real to be in her mind. Turning over in bed, she gasped as she saw Adora sitting there beside her, legs crossed and signature ponytail draped over her neck as she grinned down at her.

There was no dip in the bed, and when she reached out to touch the girl's hand, her fingers phased through her. Yup, she was officially

losing her mind.

"*You're not losing your mind.* "Adora giggled, the sound stealing Glimmer's breath away. Though she couldn't feel anything, she watched the blonde reach out and touch her cheek, caressing it the same way she had in countless dreams. "*You're just a little stressed. Are you taking care of yourself?* "A look of concern passed over her features, and Glimmer's heart lurched, *aching* for her smile to return.

She nodded her head in hopes that Adora would smile again, granting her wish as the figment beamed at Glimmer like she was the loveliest thing in the world.

"*Get a room.* "Came another voice, startling a gasp out of Glimmer as she rolled over quickly to see Catra lying beside her , propped up on an elbow with her other hand resting against Glimmer's hip.

"*Hey, Sass.* "The vision said, and Glimmer was sure she had died and passed on, because that smirk looked too real and too hot and too kissable and Glimmer was *really losing her mind.*

"*Bow Sunbright.* "Catra laughed, hand trailing up along her side all the way to her forehead, poking it slightly as Glimmer instinctively leaned back with it despite the pressure being nonexistant. "*Don't abuse it.* "

"How are you even?" The question faded out as Glimmer realised how crazy she must sound for talking to what was essentially a ghost.

"*Doesn't matter*." Catra shrugged, her hand coming to rest on Glimmer's chin as she must have grabbed it out of the corner of the girl's eye. "*Wanna see a cool trick?*" She asked, her gaze suddenly shifting over the real girl's shoulder.

Glimmer slowly turned her head and gaped at the empty spot where Adora once sat. "Wha..?"

"*Wanna see me do it again?*" Catra whispered into her ear , but when she turned again, Catra was gone.

Glimmer buried her face in her pillow and screamed in frustration.

Chapter End Notes

And so it begins...

# Chapter Three

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the lack of updates, I probably have covid <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Calling Bow the following day did *not* ease her unrest, knowing that come Monday morning, she'd have to confront the two people she *least* wanted to see. She let his words play in her mind as she rode her bicycle towards her favorite diner: "Just tell them the truth, let them know the letters were written a long time ago. They won't be upset with you, Glimmer. You were barely a teenager at the time, of course those letters were a bit over the top. You only had movies to go off of!" (She *still* only had movies to go off of, but she tried not to think about her lackluster love life given the situation she was in now.)

She parked her bike and entered, sighing softly at the smell of coffee she was hit with as a bell chimed upon pushing the door open. She slid into her usual seat and ordered some strawberry milkshakes, aiming to douse her worries with a brain freeze (*Others* may not be the *best* movie to take life lessons from, but she had to admit that freezing her brain into silence was something she could get behind. *Especially* now.)

"Hey." Came a familiar, gravelly voice, coming out of nowhere so suddenly that Glimmer nearly choked, coughing a few times to clear her throat before blinking rapidly as her eyes settled on a familiar brunette.

"Mind if I sit here?" She asked when Glimmer didn't answer, earning a slow, confused nod as Catra shrugged off her torn leather jacket and slid into the booth across from her.

A waiter came by to take Catra's order, who pointed to Glimmer's glass cup. Her voice sounded muffled, as if Glimmer were underwater and Catra was far above the surface. How fitting, considering how strongly Glimmer wanted to walk straight into the ocean at that moment.

Once Catra got her milkshake and the waiter left them alone, the girl turned to her again, chin resting in her palms as she leaned her elbows onto the table to close the distance, speaking lowly and quietly. "Are you going to let me talk about the letter this time, or are you going to run away again?" She asked, brow raised.

Glimmer took another long sip before letting out a sigh, raking her hand through her hair. She knew she should just be honest with her, that she should just explain the situation like Bow said.

That wasn't what she did.

"Listen, Catra, I- I only gave you that letter to get someone off of my back. Someone who thinks I like them." She lied, stumbling over her words as they came out rushed in a single breath. "I'm *really* sorry to confuse you, but I-"

"Who is it?" Catra asked, leaning back as she took her glass in one hand to lift it to her lips and ignore the straw provided to her entirely.

"Who- What?" Glimmer blinked, brows furrowed in confusion.

"Someone thinks you like them. Who is it?" Catra clarified, looking and sounding more interested by the treat in her grip than by what Glimmer was saying.

She couldn't *possibly* have said a worse name than the one she did. "Adora Ryder ."

Catra's eyes blew wide, slowly lowering the glass to the table as she leaned forward again at the same speed. "Adora Ryder . As in, my *ex-girlfriend* Adora Ryder?" She asked, as if that was a *super common name* like Jennifer Miller or James Smith.

Glimmer nodded timidly, feeling her back crawl as the little angel-Bow on her shoulder shook his head in disappointment.

"Yeah, that one." She confirmed, looking down at the table to go on with her faux-explanation. "You see, I gave Adora a letter too, but she wasn't supposed to find it because it was written a *long* time ago and I *totally don't* like her anymore, but now she thinks I *do,* so I panicked and wrote you one too to throw her off!" She said, hoping she sounded believable enough to not have Catra laugh in her face.

Only Catra *did* laugh, but she was smiling, head thrown back as the sound filled the space between them and Glimmer felt her cheeks heat up at having never heard the sound before. She'd heard Catra laugh before, sure, but it was always so sarcastic or teasing. This was real, gut-shaking, tear inducing laughter.

Glimmer wasn't sure whether she loved or hated making Catra laugh like that, given the context.

"To think you can make a lady feel special getting a love letter, only to find out she wasn't the only one."She wiped a tear and sighed, still grinning even after her laughter faded and she leaned on one elbow again to look at her. "That has *got* to be some cosmic-level irony. A girl thinks you like her, so you turn to her *ex-girlfriend* to throw off the scent. That is *priceless.*"She mused.

Glimmer huffed, cheeks turning pink from more than just the cold of her second refill of the cold drink pressed between her hands. "I get it, it wasn't the best idea. You don't have to rub it in."She muttered, craning her neck down so she wouldn't have to look at Catra's smug face as she finished the glass off.

"I'm not rubbing anything in, I just so happen to find the situation *hilarious.*"Catra teased lightly, like they were old friends. Only they weren't friends, they barely knew each other outside of the odd group project and occasional likes on social media.

Glimmer didn't bother with a response, simply rolling her eyes before keeping her vision centered on the straw she was idly twirling against the rim of the cup.

"So was any of it true?"

"Any of what?"

"The things you wrote."

Glimmer snapped her head up to see Catra had replaced her smug, teasing expression for a curious cheshire grin.

"Why do you care? It was a fake letter."(Lies.)

"Because you said some *pretty detailed stuff* for it to not hold at least *some* truth."

"You've got a brain, figure it out yourself."

"Ooh, so she's *spicy* when she's angry."

Glimmer glared as Catra's smirk returned, chuckling as she took another swig from her half-finished glass. "Fine, let's say only *some* of it was true. You really think I'm this super cool, unapproachable rockstar or something?" She asked with a raised brow as Glimmer could *f eel* her ego inflating itself.

"Don't flatter yourself so much." Glimmer huf fed, starting to wonder why she liked this girl anyway.

"I think I will." Catra cooed with a wink.

Right. *Th at* was why. Catra was incredibly cool *and* smoking hot. A deadly combination in her hands.

"*I* think I'm finished here." Glimmer sighed, taking her purse as she stood, leaving her total and then some on the table between them before sliding out of her booth.

"What?" She heard Catra squeak, the sound of leather shifting and boots scuffing before a rough, slender hand wrapped around her wrist and tugged slightly.

"What do you want, Catra?" She asked without looking, knowing how red she must be just then.

"That's your bike outside, right?"

---

Of all the things Glimmer had expected would happen after being confronted by Catra, getting a ride home in her sleek green Forrester was *not* one of them.

The car slowed to a stop at the corner of her block, confusion settling in Glimmer's mind for only a moment before reality returned. Right, this was *Adora's* street. To Catra, at least.

Glimmer didn't mean anything to Catra, she was *well* aware of that.

"I have a proposition for you." The driver said, red-tinted sunglasses hiding her eyes as Glimmer was thankful she could look at her more easily now.

"Proposition?" Glimmer chuckled, expecting her serious tone to be some kind of joke and that she'd get on with her real question any moment.

"Yeah. You wrote me a letter hoping Adora would think you're interested in me and not her, right?" Catra asked, setting the car in

park against the curb to turn to her. "So, let her think I'm interested too."

If Glimmer had taken a drink, Catra would be soaked from the shock she felt. "*What*?" She asked in disbelief. Was she hearing things? Was this another vision- Catra?

"You heard me." Catra shrugged, like she was suggesting they swap notes for chemistry class instead of *going out with each other*. "Let her think I like you back. I'm *done* with Adora breaking up with me and expecting me to come crawling back to her." (Glimmer suddenly felt like she was hearing information she shouldn't have access to), "If you're in, we can get her off of *both* of our backs. What do you say?"

Glimmer swallowed thickly. How long had she dreamed of dating Catra? Of being noticed by her? But..

But this would all be pretend, *fake*. To help Catra get back at Adora, someone she was too reluctant to call a friend but who's feelings mattered to her.

"I won't force you or anything, but I think this would be good for both of us. Come on, Glimmer. Aren't I *the moon to your tide*?" She smirked, bringing up the letter as the pink haired girl felt her face and neck turn a similar shade.

Glimmer took a deep breath, reached behind her, and tugged the door handle, stumbling backwards out of the door as she quickly grabbed her bike from the trunk and began walking down the street to her house.

She heard a car door slamming shut and sped up her pace, only for that *hand* to find her wrist again.

"Think about it." Catra said, almost as if she were pleading with her. (Which was impossible, since Catra Felina was too awesome to beg for things. Especially to beg to *Glimmer* for things.)

Glimmer felt her back tense in inner conflict. The angel-Bow on her shoulder shouted how wrong this would be to Adora, how bad it would be to play out her lies any longer and to tell Catra the truth before things got any messier. The devil-Catra on her shoulder only chuckled, a purr in her voice as she tempted into Glimmer's ear to just *go for it.*

"I-I'll think about it." She agreed, relaxing only slightly when Catra let her go.

"Thank you, Glimmer." The girl said with a sigh of relief.

Glimmer waited until she heard Catra's boots carry her away before continuing the last few houses to reach her own just in time to watch

Catra drive past, honking once with a wave as she watched her speed off from her place on the porch.

She would smile, if she couldn't feel Adora's eyes on her from the girl's bedroom window across the street.

---

Glimmer stood in the middle of the schoolyard, hugging her arms around her waist anxiously as she willed her legs to move forward even a *step* to carry out her plan of action before she lost her resolve.

She stared at Catra not far away from her, surrounded by a few of her friends as they all laughed at something on one of their phone screens. One of them looked up and noticed her, saying something she couldn't hear to the group before Catra perked her head in her direction with a small smile.

She watched Catra wave to the others and walk over to her, leaning close despite them being far away enough from other people to be overheard. "What's up, Sparkles?" She asked casually with a smirk, hands stuffed in the pockets of her ripped black jeans.

Glimmer took a deep breath, dizzy with the sudden smell of Catra being forced into her lungs by the wind. She smelled like cinnamon and vanilla and it made Glimmer shiver slightly where she stood.

"Well?" Catra tilted her head, smirk turning wider as if she just *knew* what Glimmer had found her for.

Glimmer squeezed her eyes shut tight, hands forming fists as they gripped the cotton fabric of her t-shirt. "I'll do it." She agreed in a shaky exhale.

"What was that?" Catra asked, jokingly leaning her ear closer with a grin.

"I'll do it!" She huffed, raising her voice just slightly to be heard more clearly.

Catra looked down at her, lifting her sunglasses to rest on the crown of her head as Glimmer's breath hitched once the girl's eyes locked onto her own. Just when Glimmer thought she couldn't possibly get any more flustered, Catra leaned closer, planting a kiss to her forehead as the pink haired girl was certain she stopped breathing entirely for a solid minute.

"Great!" The brunette cheered, sliding next to her as she slung an arm around her waist snugly. "Guess that makes you my girlfriend." She muttered beside her ear, barely audible over a loudly beating heart.

"Wait, *wait*," Glimmer finally said, forcing the air from her lungs before she could spontaneously combust or something. "We need to- Can we talk somewhere more private about this?" She asked, glancing around as it suddenly felt like the entire student body had eyes on her.

Catra seemed to sense the panic in her voice, because the next thing she knew, she was being pulled by the hand away from the thousands of eyes locked onto her into the school building, heading down a hall she didn't even recognise.

Pulling open a door with a creaking knob, Catra nudged her into a dust-filled classroom full of boxes scattered along the walls and on top of desks.

"Nobody comes here. Well, unless they're like, making out or crying, but yeah. We should be fine in here." The girl explained, closing and rigging the door behind them with a chair before grabbing a second seat, sitting with the back of it against her chest and her arms resting over it, legs spread on either side.

"Oh, um, thanks." Glimmer said, finally feeling like she could breathe again properly. She was by *no means* a popular person, so having the attention of *half* of her peers at once was more than a bit jarring.

"So, what did you want to say?" Catra asked, her tone still soft as if she were worried Glimmer would freak out again. (She hated thinking that Catra thought she was weak, but she couldn't deny that

it felt nice to have her crush speak so gently to her when she was normally so straightforward and snarky.)

"Look, if we're going to do this, we need to set some ground rules." Glimmer said, feeling angel-Bow's nod of approval as she brought up consent and the things she knew would be necessary no matter *what* kind of relationship this was supposed to be.

"You mean like, boundaries?" Catra questioned.

"Yes and no." Glimmer said, a bit unsure herself of exactly how to go about this. She decided to stick with what she knew and hope it would work for them. "More like a contract."

"A contract? What, are you planning on making me do *paperwork* to be your fake girlfriend?" Catra joked.

"Yes." She said, shutting her up instantly as Catra looked at her with raised brows for a long moment of utter silence.

"What *kind* of contract?" She eventually asked, eyes trained to Glimmer's own as the girl took a deep breath to steel her nerves.

"Nothing fancy . It'll just outline what we both want out of this. What's okay and what isn't. Those kinds of things." Glimmer said, moving

her backpack in front of her from her shoulder to rummage for her day planner and one of her sparkly gel pens.

Catra snickered. "Never thought I'd have to sign a contract to date a girl, but sure. If it'll make you feel better, why not?" She agreed, scooting her chair closer with a loud squealing sound as Glimmer sat down at the closest desk to write.

"Okay , so the purpose of this relationship is to make Adora think we're into each other and not her, right?" Glimmer asked as she wrote that down, glancing at Catra for confirmation as she nodded with a slight frown. "Okay . Now for some rules. First of all, I don't want you to kiss me like that anymore."

"What!?" Catra stood up abruptly , chair clattering to the ground. "How is anyone supposed to believe we're dating if we don't *kiss* each other?"

"I don't know , you could- You can put your hand in my back pocket, or ruffle my hair, or call me cute names. Things like that." Glimmer shrugged.

"Put my *hand* in your *pocket* ?" Catra raised a brow . "What, did you get that from some 80s movie or something?"

Glimmer blushed and looked back down at the paper, writing down what she had said instead of responding.

"Oh my god, you totally did!" She ignored Catra's cackling until it subsided and the girl must've realised she wasn't getting a reply. "Right. Fine. No kissing, hands in the pockets." She agreed.

"Yes, thank you."

"But just- Like- *why*, though? Why does it even matter?"

Glimmer felt her heart clench as she snapped her head up to meet the other girl's, gripping the pen in her hand tightly. "It *matters* because I've never dated anyone before, if you're gonna be nosy about it. I know none of this is new to you, but it's *all* new to me, Catra. I don't want all of my firsts to be fake."

Catra stared at her in surprise before blinking a few times, averting her gaze to the chair on the ground as she picked it up to sit back down. "Okay. Sorry I asked." She muttered, mouth muffled by her arms resting atop the chair's back.

Glimmer nodded her thanks curtly and took a deep breath to calm herself down, grip loosening on her pen again before she could accidentally break it and spill ink everywhere.

"I could.." Catra began after a moment, clearing her throat. "I could write you notes. Every day." She suggested without looking up from

the half-formed contract on the table. Glimmer's brain tried to leap out of her body.

"Write me notes?" She repeated dumbly, earning a glare from Catra as she watched the girl's cheeks flush for the first time.

"Yeah, write you notes. Ad- *She* and I used to leave notes for each other all the time. She thought it was sweet, so I kept it up." She explained with a shrug.

Right. Adora. The girl Glimmer was helping her deceive. The *other* girl she was head over heels for.

"Okay, sure. You'll write me notes." Glimmer agreed, adding it to the contract. "Another rule, we can't let anyone know this isn't real." She pointed out, trying not to picture the pain on Adora's face if she found out Glimmer had lied and tricked her just because she was too much of a coward to be honest about her own letters.

"Well, duh. It'd be bad for both of us if anyone found out. We don't talk about Bruno, right?" Catra joked, frowning at Glimmer's frown. "Come on, you *can't* tell me you haven't seen *Excalibato.*" Glimmer shrugged with a sheepish smile. "Add that to the list. You need *educating.*"

Glimmer laughed, writing it down before Catra leaned over to take her pen, fixing the way she spelled it as Glimmer tried to stop her

heart from racing. She handed it back over and Glimmer took another deep breath before writing something of her own. "Fine, I watch your *Ecate* movie, you watch some of my 80s movies."

"Sounds fair to me. Then add *Sleep Well* for me, too, if you haven't seen it. It's a total must-watch series." Catra said, stretching her arms above her head as Glimmer paused for a moment to watch her shirt ride up just beneath her belly button, where the hint of a hoop ring could be seen.

"*Sleep Well*, got it. Well, is that everything?" She asked once she finally wrote it down.

"Sounds good to me. No kisses, cheesy 80s flirting, movie swaps, no blabbing. I think that covers it." Catra shrugged.

"Wait." Glimmer said, pen hovering just above the paper. Catra raised a brow for her to continue. "You have to drive me to and from school." She said, figuring she might as well get a perk out of this if Catra was getting something from this.

"You don't have a car?" Catra chuckled.

"I *do,* I just can't *use* it until I get my license." Glimmer said, cheeks turning slightly pink as she realised how lame it must sound.

"Which you don't have because?" Catra drawled out, leaning closer with a somehow even *bigger* smirk.

"Because I just don't!" Glimmer huffed defensively, cheeks heating up even more as Catra grinned and shrugged at her.

"Fine, okay . I'll be your chauffeur." She agreed, slumping in her chair again.

Glimmer smiled as the heat drained from her face after a moment, drawing two lines at the bottom of the page with their initials beneath them (what? a girl doesn't have a lawyer for a mother and *not* pick up how to make a legit-looking contract!) as she signed her name before passing it over for Catra to sign.

She glanced it over as the page was handed back to her with an odd mix of relief and dread, like knowing a scary movie is all special effects and movie magic but a small part of the brain is unconvinced it isn't real.

"Okay , I guess this makes it official." She said, offering her hand to the other girl.

Catra eyed her hand before raising a brow her way, giving in after a second's thought to shake before tugging Glimmer so close she could smell something minty on the girl's breath, most likely from brushing her teeth before school began. "Guess *we're* official. *Bae.* "

Glimmer was a goner.

Chapter End Notes

I wasn't calling anyone out with those "super common names", those are just legitimately, statistically THE most common names on the planet. The more you know!

# Chapter Four

Glimmer whined as her father hugged her close, blushing in embarrassment as Bow's dads chuckled in eqal parts amusement and fondness from their seats on the couch. Lance and George had come over that morning for her mother's book club, apparently they were supposed to watch the 90s movie adaptation of *Romeo and Juliet* to compare it to the original source material.

"Dad, let me *go.*" She huf fed, grunting in effort as she finally broke free of his much stronger grip as she lunged for her bag and hopped into some slide-on shoes with a triumphant cheer, at last finished getting dressed.

"Micah, love, stop tormenting our *precious little angel* so she can finish getting ready for school." Her mom teased, stretching down to kiss her cheek with a humored smile as Glimmer rolled her eyes in annoyance.

"*Bye*, parents." She grumbled, turning to the couple on the couch with a much wider smile. "Goodbye lovely fathers whom I love and adore." She said in an overly-dramatic way , earning a fond scoff from her mother and chuckles from the three men in the room before opening the door to leave the house.

"Don't think you can get away with this, young lady!" Angella called after her as all four adults followed her onto the porch to watch Glimmer walk down the driveway like (adorable) creeps.

Glimmer glanced back to wave before quickly turning her head at the sound of a car coming to a stop in front of her house.

There in the driver's seat sat none other than Catra, red sunglasses perched on the bridge of her nose as she leaned towards her through the car window to grin at the girl. "Hey , Moonbright." She greeted smoothly, causing Glimmer's heart to do a backflip. "Ready for school?"

Glimmer stuttered to respond, glancing over her shoulder at four shocked expressions before her mother began briskly walking down the driveway with her dad following on her heels. She quickly turned to Catra again with wide eyes and opened the passenger door, looking down at her lap as she muttered, "Drive ."

"Hello, I'm Glimmer's mother ." Angella greeted firmly , and Glimmer groaned at the inevitable humiliation she was going to withstand if Catra didn't leave *immediately* .

"Nice to meet you, ma'am. I'm Catherine Felina. Please, call me Catra." Catra greeted more politely than she'd ever heard the brunette speak before. Who was this stranger and what had she done with the real Catra?

"Catherine," her mother said as Glimmer watched Catra grip the steering wheel tight as she spoke the word, "May I ask why you've suddenly decided to offer my daughter a ride to school?"

"Sweetie, they'll be late. I'm Micah, by the way . Nice to meet you, Catra." Her dad greeted with a grin. Glimmer peeked over to see her mom barely hiding an unhappy expression while her father radiated enough joy for the both of them.

"Nice to meet you, sir ." Catra smiled a bit brighter to match his energy. (Seriously, someone needed to be called if the real Catra wasn't returned soon.)

"And who might this be?" Lance mused as he and George flanked her parents' side as the pink haired girl groaned in frustration and embarrassment.

"Catra, *drive.*" She said through grit teeth as she pointedly ignored the adults cooing and gossiping right beside the vehicle.

"And how do you know our little Moonbeam?" George said, voice full of mocking babytalk.

"Well, I guess you could say I'm her girlfriend!" Catra laughed. Glimmer did not.

She turned to grip the collar of the brunette's maroon halter top to tug her closer. "Catra. If you don't want me to dump you *right now*, I suggest you *f bor it.*" She said, her voice scarily calm.

Catra seemed to take the hint, pulling the car into drive as she waved to the adults with a grin before speeding off as the men's laughter faded.

"Well your dads seem cute, at least." Catra teased. "All of 'em."

"Just keep driving." Glimmer whined, smacking her head against the glass of her window as Catra's chuckles made her feel just a *bit* better. (Okay, a *bt* better.)

---

It turned out, Glimmer realised after a week of their "relationship", that dating Catra was easier than she imagined it would be. By Friday, she had at least *twelve* handwritten notes stuffed into her locker, but it didn't end there.

Any chance the girl had, Catra would stick her hand into Glimmer's pocket- sometimes to slip a *note* into it- or ruffle her hair as she leaned into her affectionately like a clingy girlfriend would. She had listened to her boundaries and treated them with all of the care and respect a *real* girlfriend would, and sometimes Glimmer found herself swooning before reminding herself it was all for show and kept herself in check.

Sometimes she'd lean in to whisper random things against her ear to pass as loving words, each time earning a shudder she brushed off as playing the part when Catra tried to tease her for it. It was *inf uriating.* (Though she'd be lying if she wasn't enjoying every moment of their faux-love.)

She stepped into the cafeteria and instantly Catra sought her out, striding through the crowds of students like she owned the place before stopping within arm's distance of the pink haired girl. "Hey , you."She greeted in a flirty tone as Glimmer felt her cheeks heat up, *stil* not used to that. "How's my favorite girl"?

Glimmer smiled shyly at the positive attention from Catra, pushing her nerves to the back of her mind as she looked straight into her fake-girlfriend's eyes to make herself ignore anyone else's on her. "Hey , Catra."She said, her voice soft and timid compared to Catra's crisp, clear one.

"Y ou wanna come sit with my friends today? W e've got room at our table for you."She asked, one hand on her hip as the other twirled against her hoodie's drawstring idly.

"Oh, um- I don't- I dunno if I should-"Glimmer stumbled, shaking her head as she lowered her gaze pathetically to the ground. She was still uneasy with the thought of getting close to any of Catra's friends, knowing it would all go away whenever Catra called this off. She'd rather save herself from *tw* kinds of heartbreak, if she could help it.

Catra silenced her by resting her palm against her forehead, fingers threading into her hair to push it back as she slowly leaned closer while Glimmer felt her heart go into overdrive. Her face hovered closer to Glimmer's before suddenly jutting her chin forward at the last second without actually touching her lips to the girl's skin, making it *bok* like she had given her a kiss. As if that wasn't enough to kill her, she leaned close to whisper into her ear to finish the job. "You're doing great, Moonbright."

Catra pulled away and she sucked in a tight breath, spine stiffening as the girl grinned at her like she hadn't just blown Glimmer's mind. "That's fine, let me know if you change your mind. Okay, princess?" She said with a wink.

Glimmer almost forgot she was talking to *her* with a petname like that, nodding her head once it clicked as the heterochromic girl's beautiful eyes crinkled at the corners with laughter, shaking her head. "Cute." She mused.

Glimmer took a step back with one foot, feeling like her legs would turn to jello or fall off if she stayed there much longer. "I-I'm gonna- I'm gonna go, uh, bye!" She said, turning to speed-walk away as she clutched her lunchbox to her chest as if the squishy coolant inside the walls of it would chill her racing heart back to normal.

She made her way to the bathroom she'd fled to the day her letter had come crashing back into her life, sitting down beneath the sinks to eat her lunch with a sigh of relief, finally having a moment of peace away from prying eyes and flirty brunettes.

Maybe dating Catra was a *little* harder than she thought it would be.

---

Glimmer was possibly the worst chef in the world. No, really! Baking came so easily to her, so why couldn't she manage to make a simple after school snack on the stove?

A knock on the door forced a groan out of her, wiping the olive oil from her hands using a nearby hand towel and then on her jeans for good measure before stomping over to throw the door open to the *last* person she expected to see on her front porch.

Catra Felina, her (fake) girlfriend, was standing on her porch. Looking Glimmer up and down with a poorly withheld laugh at her appearance.

"Hey, Sparkles." She managed to say, and Glimmer was almost impressed at how she kept the laughter out of her voice.

"Why are you here, Catra?" Glimmer asked with a huff, unamused.

"What, no *oh wow, hi Catra! It's so good to see you!* for me?" Catra asked, raising the pitch in her voice for what was obviously a poor attempt to mimic her.

"I don't sound like that."

"You still haven't invited me inside, cute stuff."

"In your *dreams*, Felina."

As they bantered, Glimmer heard the floor creak behind her just in time to dodge a hug from her father, who took her place at the front door with a grin instead.

"Catra! My my, what a great surprise! Come in, come in. Glim-Glim, you've got a little something uh.." He turned to his daughter to gesture towards her hair.

Glimmer slowly reached up and whined in frustration, stomping her foot. "How did I get olive oil in my *hair*!?" She cried, glaring at Catra as she sauntered into the house, snickering. "Take your shoes off, you pig." She huffed.

"Now Glimmer, be nice to your *girlfriend.*" He sang out, pinching her cheek until she bit the air beside his hand as a warning and he let

go.

"Yeah, *hmm.*" Catra cooed with that *smirk*, pinching her other cheek as she slid in beside her. (Curse Glimmer's stupid heart for fluttering.)

"*You,*" she caught the girl's wrist as Catra grimaced at her oily , flour-specked hand, "still haven't said why you're here."

"To see my favorite girl, of course!" Catra said, dramatically slumping against her with her arms draped around her neck from the side. She laughed when Glimmer pushed against her and began following her back into the kitchen with a grin. "But for real, I'm here to take you to Scor's party."

"Party?" Glimmer turned on a heel, eyes wide. No, oh no, no *way* was she going to a party. "What *party*?

"Glimmer , you wound me!" Catra rested a hand over her chest as Micah chuckled and slung his arm around the girl's shoulders like they were old friends. (Why did she even like this girl again?) "Didn't you read my notes?"

Right. The notes. Honestly, Glimmer had assumed they were all blank. She wiped her hand again and pulled the most recent one from her back pocket where Catra had left it during lunch to unfold it.

*Yo, Sa*

*You, me, Scorpia pa*

*I pick you up at 5*

*Babe")*

She groaned and stuffed the paper back into her pocket, not bothering to fold it as she listened to it crinkle and possibly tear with satisfaction.

"What're you even trying to make?" Catra asked, face scrunched up as she looked at Glimmer's cooking station. (Okay, so what if it was an unsanitary mess? It was *her* unsanitary mess!)

"I was *trying* to make some fried salmon, before *you* showed up." Glimmer said, definitely not pouting. (Liar.)

Her dad came over and patted her back with a smile- pointedly *not* looking at her mess probably for his own sake more than her own. "Why don't you hop in for a quick shower and get dressed? I'll entertain your guest and make you guys a bite to eat for the drive there."

"What?" Glimmer's eyes blew wide as she wondered how they didn't pop right out of her skull. "Dad, please, I *can't* go." She begged.

"Oh come on, Moonbright. It'll be fun!" Catra encouraged before looking up at her dad. "And don't worry , sir. It's a small party, her moms will be right upstairs if anything happens, and I'll have her back whenever her curfew is."

"W ell, since you seem like a nice girl, I'm sure I can talk Glimmer's mother into extending her curfew an extra hour ." Micah laughed as Glimmer looked at him in betrayal. Why was he letting this happen? Why was he *encouraging* this?!

"Don't I get a say in any of this?" Glimmer whimpered pathetically as four hands pushed against her back to nudge her closer to the staircase leading to her room and the upstairs bathroom.

"Nope!" Catra and Micah said, chuckling to themselves as Glimmer sulked up the stairs, just faintly catching her father's warnings.

"No drinking, no drugs, and hands stay *above* the hips but *below* the chest unless both arms are around her neck to dance with my precious baby."

Oh please, somebody, end her suffering.

---

Catra's friends weren't as bad as she thought they'd be, actually. Not that she'd expected thugs or supervillains, but she hadn't expected her "girlfriend's primary friend group to consist of a dorky hacker girl, a woman who loves hugs, a guy at least twice Glimmer's height, and *Hermista* .

She and her letter recipient had nodded in greeting and understanding when she arrived but otherwise hadn't spoken, and Catra's nerdy friend- Entrapta, she heard her say at some point- hadn't paused from speaking to take a breath in at least ten minutes. She learned the guy's name to be Rogelio from Catra, after Glimmer awkwardly explained that she didn't know any sign language, and he taught her a few basic words that she was happy to learn. Last came Scorpia, the hug-loving girl hosting the party. (Glimmer had been *beyond* relieved when she stepped into the house and realised the party was at least a third of the size she had been picturing dreadfully in her mind on the ride over, internally thanking the universe that Scorpia was an introvert and her parents were home so the party wasn't hectic and wild.)

"-so I knocked her down, but I didn't even mean to!That's when I realised sports weren't really my thing, despite how I'm kinda built for them."Scorpia finished her story , taking a drink of something Catra said she wasn't allowed to try (no matter how much her curiosity wanted her to).

Glimmer nodded and took a drink from her Catra-approved soda can just as the brunette walked over to them after mingling with the other party-goers. Apparently Catra had more friends than Glimmer initially thought, since of the fifty-something people there she seemed to get

along with nearly all of them and had spent nearly the entire party just greeting all of them.

"Hey , you." Catra said, affectionately wrapping an arm around her waist to stick her hand in Glimmer's back pocket. (Glimmer *totally didn't* blush every time she did that.) "Ready to get out of here?" She asked, using her free hand to stroke her cheek with the knuckle of her index finger .

"Uh, sure, yeah. It was nice meeting you, Scorpia!" Glimmer called with a wave as Catra held her hand to pull them through the crowd of dancing teenagers.

They hopped into Catra's car just as Glimmer finished her soda, watching in awe as Catra crushed the can against the side of her head while one hand stayed on the wheel to throw it into Scorpia's moms' recycling bin on their way down the driveway.

"You have fun?" Catra asked with a grin, lifting her sunglasses to the crown of her head to look at Glimmer once they reached a stop sign.

"Yeah." Glimmer nodded, transfixed by her eyes as she surprised herself by the answer. "Yeah, I did."

---

Catra took her back to her favorite diner after Glimmer received a text from her dad saying her curfew actually *had* been extended by an hour after all, which meant they were in no rush to get her home this time.

Glimmer eyed the brunette stirring her untouched milkshake with her straw between bites of her order of cheese fries. Catra glanced up at her and pushed the glass away from her, resting her arms on the table as she slumped forward onto it.

"Adora left like, five minutes after we got there." She eventually said, looking like a sulking child.

Glimmer couldn't suppress a giggle, earning a glare as she shook her head and grinned. "Is that why you were 'mingling' the entire time? You were scoping her out?" She asked, *very* amused by the way Catra blushed and sputtered to respond.

"I- She- *She's* the whole point of this!" She gestured between them with a hand, "Of course I was looking for her!"

Glimmer smirked and rolled her eyes at how flustered the girl was being. It was honestly really cute. She reached across the table to poke her forehead like Catra had done to her countless times since they first met, melting the frown from her face as she watched her eyes cross trying to look up at the finger. "*You* sound crazy." She teased. "Relax, won't you?"

"Re- *Ba* "? Catra finally swatted her hand away as Glimmer giggled, but she was smiling this time. Good. "Y ou should be upset, too! How is she supposed to believe you're not into her if she's never around to *see* you're not into her"?

"Sorry , I'm not supposed to listen to obsessed lunatics." Glimmer jpked, earning a scof f and a light shove to the shoulder.

"I'm not obsessed." Catra rolled her eyes and checked her phone for the tenth time since they left the party.

Glimmer snatched it out of her hand, holding it out of her reach as Catra yelped and tried to reach for it. "See? *Obsessed.* "She tutted, shaking her head. "W ould it *kil* you to shut your phone off for the night? I swear , every time we're not in school I see you check your phone every five minutes." She said as Catra frowned and plopped back down in her booth seat as the springs squeaked loudly .

Glimmer hummed as Catra scoffed in defeat and set the girl's phone in her pocket much to her visible dismay. "Y ou can have it back when you drop me off at home. Until then, no more checking your phone for tex s every five seconds, crazy lady ."

"Ugh, fine." Catra sighed, staring down at the table as she anxiously drummed her fingers against the surface before smacking her hand down and snapping her head up to look at her. "Cheese fry me." She said, holding out her hand.

Glimmer laughed, so hard it almost hurt, as she passed Catra a handful of the greasy diner food. Their hands touched.

---

"Thanks for driving me home. I really did have fun tonight." Glimmer smiled as they pulled to a stop in front of her house.

"No problem." Catra said, taking those red sunglasses of f to brush her hair back after the wind had messed it up.

Glimmer giggled as she tried to move it back into place, unbuckling to turn in her seat as she sat with her legs crossed, facing her. "Here, let me." She of fered.

Catra shrugged and copied her sitting position, folding the leg she didn't use for driving under herself as she leaned forward with her head tilted forward slightly so Glimmer could reach her hair. She gently threaded her fingers into Catra's wily locks, cheeks burning as she tried not to focus on how soft her hair was to the touch. She gently combed out tangles with only the occasional wince from Catra until she was finished.

"Uh, look up." She whispered, licking her lips as her throat felt dry as she used one hand to gently lift Catra's face so their eyes locked. Blue-green and hazel-gold stared back at her , though instead of their usual piercing intensity Glimmer felt oddly...relaxed, unable to see

anything but the girl in front of her as her heart threatened to beat out of her chest.

"Have I ever told you how pretty your eyes are?" Catra blurted after some silence, and Glimmer felt her breath hitch at the question. "They're like, I dunno, chocolate. But like, milk chocolate? Like a lighter, not dark kind of. Y- -You get it." She stuttered.

Glimmer smiled softly, letting out a quiet giggle as they still couldn't seem to break their sudden staring contest, faces close enough that almost nothing could be seen in her peripheral even if she *wanted* to look at something other than Catra, Catra, *Catra*. "You're one to talk." She said back, slowly and hesitantly lifting her hand to rest on Catra's cheek. When the girl didn't move or shake her off, she saw it as a sign to continue, brushing her thumb just beneath the golden eye. "Your eyes are so amazing. It's like- Like water and lightning. Calming and shocking at the same time. They're amazing. I'm honestly really jealous." She admitted, not even sure where she found the courage to say any of it out loud.

"You? Jealous of me?" Catra chuckled, looking down at her lap briefly before meeting her eyes as that soft gaze was returned to her. (She could die a happy woman with no regrets after seeing that look *twice.*) "What's there to be jealous of?"

"Are you seriously asking me that?" Glimmer deadpanned, raising a brow.

Catra giggled- *giggled* - and smirked and Glimmer *strongly* pushed down the urge to flick her forehead to wipe the look off of her face. "I am. I mean, *you're* the one with the killer fashion sense. *You're* the one with a super cool dad- don't roll your eyes like that, he's cool and you know it. And what do I have?" She shrugged with a sad smile. "A car? A wardrobe full of clothes with unintentional holes that *happen* to look cool? A reputation for being unapproachable? I'm not exactly seeing a contest here, Moonbright." She chuckled weakly.

Glimmer frowned, leaning a bit closer so the brunette couldn't look away from her eyes. "Catra, look me in the eye and *tell* me I'm lying: You're the coolest, funniest, most considerate girl I've ever met. How could I *not* be jealous when everything you do is incredible?"

"I..." Catra gulped audibly, blinking a few times as her eyes scanned Glimmer's back and forth before she closed them and sighed. "You're not lying." She said quietly. When her eyes opened again, she smiled at her. *Actually* smiled, like she was *grateful* to Glimmer.

"I'm not." She confirmed, dropping her voice to a whisper.

Catra began slowly closing the distance between them more and more as Glimmer's senses were overwhelmed with the smell of cinnamon and vanilla and the cheese fries Catra ate and her strawberry milkshake and *please never wake her from this dream.*

Only, the little angel-Bow appeared on her shoulder, one hand on his hip as he held up the contract in his free hand. Right. The rules. No

kissing. Because this wasn't real. Catra wasn't her *real* girlfriend.

She pulled away abruptly, feeling her heart clench and fill with dread seeing the confused look on Catra's face as she dropped the hand from her face and cleared her throat, looking away from her.

"Um, thanks for the ride." Glimmer muttered, turning to sit properly as she fished the girl's phone out of her pocket to hand over.

"Huh? Wait, Glimmer, what're you-" Catra began, but Glimmer didn't want to hear what she had to say. She didn't want to hear Catra talk any more right now, not when she *knew* that anything she said would all be an act and it would only add to the pain in her chest.

"See you at school on Monday." She forced a smile, opening her door to exit the car. She walked all the way to her porch before she heard Catra drive off, and then she broke, finally letting herself cry.

She wouldn't let herself get careless like that again, she couldn't. Catra *can't hers.*

# Chapter Five

It got easier as the weeks went by;the faking, the hand holding, the side hugs- even being around Catra's friends was becoming second nature, as easy as if they were her own friends.

She listened to Entrapta drone on about classes, using the information the girl gave to help give her a hand with her grades (though she always made sure to repay her in bite-sized desserts- which Glimmer learned were the genius girl's favorite snack).

Rogelio taught her sign language during lunch, and she was actually getting the hang of it!(But she quickly learned that swear words were her favorite things to sign, like, ever.)

Scorpia was a lot of fun to hang out with both in and out of school, even inviting Glimmer to hang out when she and Catra went shopping or lounged around her house together. (Her moms turned out to be *great* at cooking.)

She managed to become friends with Mermista and her fiance, Sea Hawk (who wasn't as "stupid" as she remembered from her letter).

But most of all, she seemed to become friends with Catra, too. If hanging out and enjoying her fake girlfriend's company could classify them as friends, at least.

"What?! How could she choose the dumb rich guy over the dude obviously into her?" Catra groaned, shoveling more popcorn into her mouth as Glimmer giggled at her reaction. They had been lying on their stomachs in the pink haired girl's room, watching some of her favorite romance movies from the 80s to cross them off of the movie swapping portion of their contract.

"Are you really getting upset over *Pretty in Pink*?" Glimmer teased, earning a glare before Catra rolled her eyes with a grin to push her shoulder away as she rolled with the action to lie on her back, head dangling from the edge of the bed.

"I just think this ending is stupid! I mean, the *whole* movie, Duckie follows Andie around like some kind of helpless little puppy, and she *still* ends up with Blane? It doesn't make any sense!" Catra continued as Glimmer watched her upside-down with a grin.

"Love doesn't *need* to make sense." Glimmer hummed, earning a scoff and smirk from the girl as Catra ran a hand through her hair to push the long, unruly hair from her face.

"You sound like a hopeless romantic." She teased, nodding her head to the side towards the television without looking away from her. "Now come on, you said you've got more to show me and your curfew isn't for another four hours. That's time for two more of these if we don't waste any time."

"Oh my god, is *the* Catra Felina becoming a *romcom lover*?" Glimmer gasped in a conspiratorial whisper, rolling back onto her stomach before pushing herself up to climb off of the bed just in time to dodge the pillow being thrown at her head.

"In your dreams, Moonbright. You said if I watched six of your movies, you'd watch six of mine. That's enough for every *Stephl* movie and *Ecnato,* which you need to watch like, *immediately*. I'm just upholding my end of the deal so you'll uphold yours." Catra reasoned as Glimmer slid the next flick on her list into her disc player to be watched.

"Sure, sure. Whatever helps you sleep at night, Felina." Glimmer said in a singsong tone as she hopped onto her bed, both girls laughing as the mattress bounced them with the sudden movement to crash into each other.

Glimmer watched the movie with a smile as they lay comfortably in a pile of tangled legs, head resting on Catra's chest as the girl played with her hair with both hands without once tearing her eyes from the screen.

She could get used to being Catra's friend if it meant more moments like this.

---

Glimmer gulped silently as she helped set the table, knowing any minute now her "girlfriend" would be there to have dinner with her family. (It was already too late to add "no family involved" to the list, or she would've done so as soon as she heard her mother suggest inviting Catra over to eat with them.)

The dreaded knock came from the door as Glimmer called out, "I'll get it!" over her shoulder as she rushed to answer it before either of her parents could.

"Hey , Sparkles." Catra said, leaning close to hover her lips barely a breath away from her cheek to make it look like a kiss to her parents just on the other end of the open floor-plan. "Am I late?" She asked softly, a rare hint of nervousness in her tone.

Glimmer smiled softly and shook her head. "Right on time, we're setting the table now." Glimmer said back in a hushed voice as Catra nodded, looping her arm through the other girl's to head over to the table together (taking off her shoes at the door had become second nature to the brunette at this point, Glimmer noted).

"Catra! Good to see you." Micah greeted. Catra let go of Glimmer to allow the man to pull her in for what looked to be a rather tight hug.

"Good to see you too, sir ." Catra chuckled with a genuine smile, her eyes bare of her usual shades so Glimmer could clearly see their cheerful brightness. Catra seemed to dress up for the occasion, wearing some black skinny jeans and a maroon blazer with a

magenta bowtie left untied around her neck though she left her pink dress shirt modestly buttoned to the top. She really looked like she was dressed to impress, and Glimmer couldn't help but internally applaud her commitment to the "charming girlfriend" role.

"Please, call me Micah." Her father groaned playfully , grinning as he patted the brunette's back. "I insist every time I see you, and every time you call me 'sir'. What's it gonna take to get you to loosen up around me, huh?" He chuckled.

"*Dad*." Glimmer huffed, tugging Catra closer by the arm as the man held up his hands in surrender with a grin, ruffling his daughter's hair as she squirmed away in protest.

"Alright, alright. You two take your seats, your mom should be out any second now with food." He said, taking his seat beside the head of the table as Glimmer sat opposite him, gesturing to Catra to sit beside her.

Angella strode into the room holding as much power and grace as usual, the same aura that could persuade an entire courtroom and jury no matter how slim the odds of her client winning the case were. She carried a large two handled pot between mitten-covered hands, setting it down in the middle of the table to set her oven mitts down beside her when she took her seat at the table's head.

Everyone began filling their bowls as Catra slowly leaned closer to Glimmer to whisper in her ear. "So, uh, what *is* this stuff?" She

asked.

Laksa." Glimmer answered, trying not to giggle as Catra's face remained confused and a bit off-put. "It's like soup, it's really good. Just try it." She encouraged.

Catra slowly raised a spoonful of the broth to her lips, closing her eyes to try some. Her eyes blew wide as she stared down at the spoon in awe before trying another bite, then another.

Angella cleared her throat as the other three present turned their heads to look at her as she ate her dish daintily, patting her lips dry every few bites to keep them clean. "So, Catherine," (Glimmer gripped her knee beneath the table as Catra tensed. she didn't know why, but Catra hated being called that no matter who was saying it.) "What do you plan to do after graduation?" She asked, seemingly brought up at random.

Catra coughed into her fist before clearing her throat, smiling sheepishly as the attention was turned onto her while everyone ate. "Uh, well, I'll probably find a job after I'm done with school, so I can work full time without worrying about my grades dropping."

I see." Her mother nodded, taking a sip from her glass of water. "So you haven't applied to any universities?" She asked, and even Glimmer shuddered from the gaze directed at the girl beside her.

"My uh, my moms never really pushed it on me or anything. I just can't see myself in college." Catra said, trying her best to answer as she was scrutinised.

"Surely your mothers want you to succeed in life, though." Angella countered.

Catra took a deep breath and nodded. "As far as they're concerned, I'm already doing well for myself. I'm already succeeding in their eyes."

"You haven't truly lived yet, you're still just a child! How can a child succeed at life?"

"I like to think I've lived through more than my peers, so I guess that means I'm not a child."

The two locked eyes as Glimmer darted her head back and forth between them anxiously.

"What kind of job did you have in mind, Catra?" Her father saved them from the tense atmosphere, holding his wife's hand as he smiled at their guest.

Glimmer breathed in relief, but couldn't shake Catra's words from her mind. *Lived through more than her peers*, what did that even mean?

Dinner passed without any more hiccups as Micah and Glimmer led the conversations this time, an easier atmosphere settling around the table until everyone was finished eating.

"Excuse me."Angela said as she stood from the table. "I think I'm going to lie down. It was a *pleasure* to see you… *Catra*."She said before her slipper-clad feet carried her down the hall to her bedroom.

Micah smiled apologetically. "I'm going to check on her. Glimmer, can you handle cleaning up?"He asked.

"I'll help."Catra chimed in before the girl could even respond, watching Micah hurry after his spouse as the two set about clearing the empty bowls and utensils from the table.

"You don't have to stick around, you know."Glimmer said softly despite them being alone. "I can handle the dishes on my own."

Catra shook her head, shrugging with a half-smile that didn't reach her eyes. "I wanna help."She hummed.

Glimmer smiled softly and nodded as they got to work.

"What did you mean back there?" Glimmer blurted before she could stop herself as the bowl in Catra's hands nearly dropped if not for her quick reflexes.

"Mean about what?" Catra asked slowly.

"You said- You said you've lived through more than our peers. What does that even mean?" Glimmer clarified.

Catra set the bowl down gently to dry and took a deep breath, closing her eyes as she nodded as if agreeing to tell her the answer. "I had- I had a pretty nasty foster mom when I was a kid. Before my moms, Netossa and Spinnerella, adopted me, that is. She, uh, she always called me 'Catherine'." She explained, cutting Glimmer off with a raised hand before she could apologise for bringing it up. "I'm fine now, really, but when you live with something like that as a little kid, it sticks no matter what you do. You know?" She shrugged.

Glimmer could only shake her head. She *didn't* know.

"Catra, I'm- I'm *so* sorry you had to think about that. I don't know whether it was what my mom said, or the atmosphere, or the situation, or what, but I just-" Catra looked her in the eyes as the apology stopped instantly in Glimmer's mouth.

"Don't worry about it." Catra said smoothly, but her eyes seemed to be pleading with her to *please, don't worry about it.*

"Yeah, sure. Got it." Glimmer nodded, turning her attention back to the few dishes she had left to wash as she kept glancing over at Catra from the corner of her eye.

"My moms adopted me right before seventh grade, when I transferred to your school." Catra brought up, changing the subject.

"Yeah, I remember." Glimmer said softly as she thought about Catra back then, where the girl would constantly be getting into fights and trouble in class, before Glimmer even paid any attention to her. "You used to be a *nightmare* to our teachers." She giggled.

Catra chuckled weakly with a nod, shrugging as the faintest blush settled on her cheeks. "Yeah, I guess therapy really helped me get rid of my urge to punch people's faces." She joked, smiling slightly her way to let Glimmer know it was okay to laugh with her. She did.

The girl went quiet for a second before inhaling sharply. "That's about the time I started becoming friends with Adora. She wasn't scared of me like the other kids in class were, she's just so-"

"-compassionate." Glimmer finished for her.

Catra stared at her for a moment before nodding slowly, drying her hands off with a hand towel before passing it to Glimmer as they finished the last dish. "Yeah." She agreed. "She was really understanding. Always has been."

"Yeah." Glimmer echoed, feeling her chest clench even as she looked Catra in the eye. "She really is."

She shouldn't have been surprised that Catra still had some kind of feelings for Adora (especially when Glimmer herself had feelings for the girl as well), but somehow it gave her a mixed sense of relief and disappointment that Catra could understand how she felt. After all, they were only "dating" to gain Adora's attention, anyway. Once they had it, there was no reason to keep *this* up any longer.

Regardless of whether Glimmer wanted to or not.

# Chapter Six

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer couldn't run. She had absolutely nowhere to go, especially once her father called from the front door, "Oh, she's right here, Adora!" So, begrudgingly , she stalked around the corner of the house into view from the front door, where her blonde crush stood in all her otherworldly beauty.

"Hey , Glimmer." Adora said stif fly, rubbing her arm as she offered the worst smile of faux-reassurance possible (Glimmer ignored the part of her that easily pointed out the tells of Adora's body language, unsure if it came from all the lying she had been doing to date Catra or the years spent pining after her; probably both).

"Hey ." Glimmer said back through held breath, looking down at the floor between them to avoid seeing the look in her eyes. Would it be sadness? Anger? Pity? She didn't have it in her to find out.

Micah rested a hand on her shoulder and nudged his daughter closer to the door. "Y ou two talk on the porch, I'll stay out of your way." He said, closing the door before Glimmer could voice a complaint.

Silence spread between them as Glimmer could practically *f ee l* the taller girl staring at her from the corner of her eye.

"Why have you been ignoring me?" Adora asked, so softly Glimmer wondered if she was hearing things. She perked her head up to see the blonde's face, a deep frown on her lips and eyebrows furrowed enough to crease her forehead (she had to physically *f ight* her desire to brush them away with her thumb). "Why did you send me that letter?"

Glimmer took a deep breath and took the few steps needed to reach the porch steps, plopping down as the wood creaked in protest. She ran her hands over her face and sighed once she felt and heard Adora sit beside her, silently thanking the distance between them for once. "Y ou weren't supposed to see it." She answered vaguely .

"So you meant it?" Adora questioned. Glimmer winced.

"It was a *long* time ago, Adora." She said, looking down at her feet.

"Glimmer , I-" the girl huf fed, and Glimmer heard her smack her knees in frustration. "If I knew how you felt, I-"

"Adora." Glimmer cut her of f, not wanting to hear whatever she had to say in response. "Not now , please." She said, voice barely audible.

Another stretch of silence passed between them, the only sounds audible being the autumn leaves rustling and the occasional car zipping past. Just when Glimmer felt herself calming down again, Adora spoke.

"I wasn't the only letter, was I?" She asked, almost as a statement rather than a question. As if she knew the answer already.

Glimmer shook her head. She should stop lying about unnecessary things. (*Every she'd told a unnecessary*, angel-Bow's voice rang through her ears.)

"Who else got one?" The blonde asked, scooting closer into Glimmer's line of sight as she pulled her knees to her chest to rest her cheek upon.

Glimmer took a deep breath, leaning back to prop herself up on her hands as she watched the clouds above them. "Perfuma Fleur from fourth grade, Kyle Lewis from summer camp, Mermista Wells-"

"Isn't she engaged to that guy from chem?"

"I didn't know that *at the time*."

"Sorry, sorry."

Glimmer went quiet again, wondering if Adora would be upset to hear that Catra had received a letter too.

"I just-" Adora began, taking a deep breath. "Why *now*? You wrote it a while ago, right? Why'd you wait so long to send it?"

"I didn't *mean* to send them." Glimmer sighed. "But they're out now, so I can't really do anything about it."

"Yeah but, if you really liked me, why didn't you say something?" The other girl asked, gray-blue eyes wide and full of confusion.

"Because-" Glimmer tried, but her mind came up empty with reasons. "Because you're *you*, Adora. And I'm...me."

Adora leaned closer, frowning even deeper. "Don't say it like that." She scolded. "I'm not some famous celebrity, Glimmer. I'm your neighbor, your *friend* You could've just *told* me, I would've understood!" She stood suddenly, pacing back and forth from the bottom of the steps to Glimmer's porch as she ran a hand through her hair to let her golden, bright locks loose around her shoulders much to Glimmer's visual appreciation.

"Maybe if I'd known, Catra and I would never have-"

"*Don't* finish that sentence." Glimmer said, stopping Adora in her tracks as she looked down at the girl white in the face.

"Glimmer , I- I didn't mean- I-I know you and Catra are-" she panicked, eyes wide and full of so much emotion it made Glimmer feel sick to her stomach.

"It's okay ." Glimmer said, cutting of f her rambling. She stood, stepping back onto her porch as she held onto the railing with both hands to look at Adora fully while still feeling grounded.

It was the first time she'd ever looked her in the eye.

"I think you should go." She added, her chest still churning at everything Adora had said about Catra, a girl Adora had claimed to love for *years* .

Adora took a step back, shaking her head slowly. "G-Glim, are we- Are we okay?" She asked, her voice cracking slightly . "Are we still friends?"

Glimmer blinked, finally understanding. Adora hadn't been upset by the letter *itself* , she was upset by how *Glimmer* reacted to it. She had been driving herself crazy with worry and panic for nothing, all these weeks.

"Yeah." Glimmer nodded, smiling softly as she watched the tension roll off of Adora's shoulders, "We're friends." She said, because they were.

Because Glimmer was with Catra (not in the way she wanted, but that *didn't matter*), and Adora was the girl they were trying to fool. It would be cruel to want anything more from the blonde when she was willingly tricking her like this, so friends were more than Glimmer could ever hope to be.

She'd have to be fine with that.

---

Adora started coming around more often, meeting Glimmer before school and after (she tried not to think about why the blonde avoided her at school, feeling Catra's presence around her between classes and during the ones they shared) as their friendship grew even stronger than before.

She'd lie in Glimmer's bed and let the girl braid her hair as they watched movies, invited her to watch her team practice, and attended a couple of their games, practically glowing any time Adora smiled her way from the field.

Glimmer had been *so* wrong, those letters were the best thing that could have happened to her. She finally had Adora's attention. She finally had Adora's trust. She was finally friends with Adora Ryder, and apparently had been for *years* without even realising.

"Glim, you okay?" Adora snapped her from her thoughts as she came jogging over from where she'd been running drills with her team (being team captain must be hard). She was dripping with sweat and panting with effort and Glimmer was *sure* she had died and was looking at a goddess instead of her neighbor.

"Oh, yeah, I'm fine." She said, shaking her head with a smile. (It was technically the truth, since she *had* been fine until Adora killed her with her beauty.)

"Good, good." Adora said, sitting down in the row below her on the bleachers as she turned in her seat to look up at her with a grin. "Hey, some of us were gonna go for pizza later, do you maybe wanna-"

"Can't." Glimmer interrupted with an apologetic smile. She had already made plans with Catra, her "girlfriend". (It was sort of an unspoken agreement between the girls that Catra wouldn't interrupt Adora's time with Glimmer, nor would Adora interrupt Catra's time with her, either.)

"Right." Adora said, still smiling but not as widely as before. It hurt Glimmer's heart to see it weaken like that. "Another time?"

"Totally."Glimmer agreed, nodding. "I'll treat you."She offered, wanting to make it up to her in some way.

"That sounds nice."Adora agreed, smiling down at her lap. (Glimmer hoped she meant it, wished more than anything that Adora wasn't saying that for her sake.)

"Cool."Glimmer said.

"Cool."Adora echoed.

Glimmer watched her golden hair sway with the breeze until those beautiful eyes rose to meet her own again, squinting just slightly from the sun but not enough to obscure the color from her view. That gorgeous, striking blue.

"I should get back to practice."The girl brought up, gesturing with her thumb vaguely over her shoulder at the group of girls still taking their water break.

"Oh, yeah, of course."Glimmer nodded her understanding.

She watched Adora wave and jog back to her friends, and finally let out her breath.

---

Getting pizza with Adora Ryder- to Glimmer- was better than meeting her favorite celebrity in person, or winning the lottery, or *anything in the world.*

She had never felt so in love than she had while watching Adora laugh as she tried to eat a slice of her everything-topping pizza without dropping anything, a carefree grin on her face as she squinted her eyes in concentration.

Eventually Glimmer had to rush to her kitchen for spare napkins when the blonde inevitably dropped some sauce on her arm in an attempt to catch a falling pepperoni, but even still neither girl could seem to stop laughing.

"Sorry about your sheets."Adora said once their giggles died down, gesturing with a guilty smile to the red blotch on the girl's bed.

Glimmer shrugged. "I'm sure I can get the stain out, you got most of it off already, so I wouldn't worry too much."She said with a smile.

Adora nodded and sighed, tossing her crust into the now empty pizza box before lying back with her hair and head dangling from the edge of the bed. "I'm stuffed." She said, patting her stomach for effect.

Glimmer giggled and copied her position, flopping back with their arms brushing against each other lightly. It felt oddly *peaceful* to sit here with Adora like this. She wasn't sure if it was the sleepovers they'd spent in this exact position, or the weight of the letter finally being off her back, but it suddenly felt so *easy* to spend time with her like this. Her *friend*, Adora Ryder.

Adora shifted to look at her, all bright smiles and warm like the sun, and Glimmer felt her face heat up at the sight. She truly was too beautiful, too wonderful, too *radiant.*

Then, she kissed her, and Glimmer *knew* she was doomed.

It only lasted a moment- maybe less- before Adora gasped and pulled away, eyes wide and lips parted in surprise. She reached up to touch her lips and-

"Woah!" She cried, falling straight on her head.

"A-Are you okay?" Glimmer scrambled to sit upright, too stunned to even feel the dizzying effects of being upside down for so long as she looked down at the blonde sprawled out on her floor.

"Yeah, yeah! Of course I am!" Adora said in that odd (cute) voice that came out when she was lying. "I just- Um- I should, I should go." She decided, sitting up quickly as she stumbled to her feet. She made it to the doorway before finally looking at Glimmer again, unshed tears in her eyes as she bit her lip. "I'm sorry." She said, then ran out of the room.

Glimmer sat completely still for a while, the events of the past few minutes slowly downloading to her brain before she finally grabbed her pillow and screamed into it.

"Adora Ryder just kissed me!" She cheered into it, then her expression darkened as she felt her heart drop to her feet in a freefall. "*Adora Ryder just kissed me.* I have a *girlfriend*, and Adora Ryder just *kissed* me." She muttered it to herself as if it would make it sound any less like her imagination. "I'm dating her *ex-girlfriend,* and Adora Ryder just kissed me."

Yup, she was screwed.

Chapter End Notes

So fun fact, the character(s if you squint) I'm basing Adora off of have like, barely any screen time (apparently they have more in the books, but I haven't read the books so I only have the movie to go off of), which means a lot of her scenes are ad-libbed/improvised. So if it seems /really/ different to the actual TAtBILB, that's why :)

# Chapter Seven

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer was quiet the following day at lunch, sitting with Mermista beneath the field bleachers- she'd only started sitting with her once the snarky girl realised she didn't really have a place to eat otherwise, never the same spot twice since Mermista was *convinced* someone would call them out for not eating in the building (which was *totally* true, by school rules)- as they shared a bag of cheese puffs large enough for both of them along with their own sandwiches and milkshakes. She kept her knees to her chest and ate way fewer puffs than the other girl, her mind drifting off to different places.

"If you didn't want to eat with me, you could've said so."Mermista reminded around a mouthful of sandwich before swallowing to continue. "I wouldn't care."

"I know ."Glimmer shrugged. "It's not that, I like eating with you."She said, which was true. It was nice not eating alone or surrounded by people she was sure would leave her once she and Catra broke up- uh- *ended the contract* .

"If you say so."Mermista said, still eyeing her cautiously even as Glimmer took a fistful of cheese puffs to show her nothing was wrong (nothing she could tell anyone about, at least. no one could know that she and Adora kissed).

That's when she heard it, the metal creaks of the old seats shifting with footsteps. Loud, *heavy* footsteps;stomping.

"Dor , come on. Will you just let me talk to you for five seconds?" A voice said above them.

Glimmer's heart sank. She recognised that voice, recognised that nickname.

Catra and Adora.

"Not now , Catra. I'm trying to figure out what to do about the training schedule for the girls not going on the year trip, something *you* would know nothing about."Adora hissed, the sound of paper crinkling accompanying the sound.

"Y ou're always like this!"Catra huf fed, stomping her foot so hard Glimmer swore she felt the vibration even from the grass below. "Y ou just blow everything of f if it doesn't help you win a shiny trophy, huh?"

"Dude, isn't that Catra?"Mermista whispered, shuf fling to sit closer to the pink haired girl as she craned her neck to see between the rows of seats above them. Glimmer held a finger to her lips, listening.

"*I* blow people off? What about all the dates you canceled to go shopping with Scorpia? Or partying with Entrapta or Rogelio? *Y*ou always spent more time with your friends than you *ever* did with me!" Adora said defensively.

"I'm not like that anymore." Catra said, the sound strained as if her teeth were clenched (Glimmer could practically *f eel* them grinding together).

"Good for you, you've finally grown up!" Adora said, mocking her with babytalk.

"*Y*eah, I have! So when will you!?"

"What's *tha*t supposed to mean!?"

"Uh, Glimmer? Are you gonna step in, or ...?" Mermista tried again. Glimmer shot her a glare to *be qiet* .

There was a beat of silence before one of them took a deep breath (Glimmer knew it was Catra, but refused to acknowledge that she'd listened to her breathe enough to tell, because that would be super weird). "Fine." The brunette said. "*Y*ou're right, like always. It's all my fault."

"Catra."Adora sighed.

"Just- Can we not be weird? On the class trip? We've been looking forward to this trip for *four years*, 'Dor. Can we agree to not- Not *ruin* it for each other? To stay out of each other's hair?"

Adora's weight shifted from foot to foot (a cute nervous habit of hers). "Yeah."She muttered. "You won't even know I'm there."She said, stomping past Catra the way they'd come with the rustling of papers in tow.

"Adora, that's not what I- Adora, wait!"Catra called, her feet thumping rapidly after her as Catra literally *chased after* Adora. How expected.

Glimmer felt Mermista staring at her as she idly stirred her milkshake around with a straw, trying not to look her way as much as possible.

"Wow."She clicked her tongue. "Some people just can't get over their ex. Sorry, Glimmer."The girl said, a touch of sympathy in her normally emotionless voice.

"It's fine."Glimmer shrugged. "I... I'll talk to her."She said.

Though she wasn't sure who to talk to after that. Clearly Adora was more upset, but Catra was her girlfriend. Adora was her first kiss, and Catra was her first relationship. And worse still, neither knew she had overheard what was surely a private moment.

Why did this have to be so complicated?

---

Glimmer avoided both girls in the halls after that, sitting away from them in their shared classes and taking different routes to get to her lessons. She couldn't be near either one of them, the thought of talking to one before the other was making her sick with imaginary guilt.

"Sparkles, hey!" Catra caught her arm just after their final class for the day as Glimmer had been heading to the bus stop (what, she was just supposed to ride home with Catra after what happened at lunch?), tugging her to a secluded spot away from the doorway where they could have some privacy. "Are you feeling okay?" She asked, her eyes so full of (*f a* ) concern it made Glimmer's heart jump.

She wasn't sure whether it was the conversation she had overheard, or her growing friendship and loyalty to Adora, or angel-Bow beckoning her, but she didn't expect the words that came out of her mouth. "I want out." She blurted, looking at the ground as she heard the brunette's breath hitch in her throat.

"You...what?" Catra asked slowly.

"The contract. I...I want out." Glimmer said again, her words growing rapid with oncoming panic. "I-I can't keep doing this anymore, Catra. The lying, the fake feelings, *Adora*, I just *can't* anymore."

Catra stiffened at the mention of the blonde's name (typical), lightly holding Glimmer by the shoulders as she hunched closer to meet her lowered gaze. "Moonbright, c'mon, you can't bail on me. I...I *need* you." She said, her gaze flickering back and forth between Glimmer's eyes with a deep frown. (If Glimmer weren't too frantic to feel hopeful, she would've thought her eyes looked saddened by her confession.)

"I can't, Catra. I'm sorry." She whispered, looking to the side where Catra wasn't obscuring her view.

The girl was silent for a moment, maybe a few, before she gripped her upper arms lightly and moved again into her line of sight. "Okay, you're out, that's fine. But *please,* just help me through the year trip. Adora and I have been looking forward to it since we first heard about it in ninth grade, and since we aren't together anymore, well"... She trailed off, shaking her head. "I can't bail on that trip, I'll look like a total loser, but I can't go alone, either. Please, Glimmer."

Glimmer felt her heart skip a beat. Catra had said her name before, but never with this much feeling. This obviously meant something to her. How could she say no to a girl she loved?

"Fine." She let out a shaky breath, closing her eyes so she could focus without seeing Catra. "But just until the end of the trip."

"End of the trip." Catra agreed. "Then we stage a breakup- say we're better off as buds or whatever- and we never have to talk about this again. But the trip comes first."

"Trip comes first, breakup later." Glimmer nodded, opening her eyes to see Catra with a tight-lipped smile.

"Deal. Now , can I drive you home before your dad freaks out on me?" She asked jokingly .

Glimmer giggled hollowly and nodded, letting Catra lead her back to her car with her hand in Glimmer's pocket.

But it wouldn't be, for much longer.

Chapter End Notes

> We're about to get back into some longer chapters (or maybe one long chapter, I dunno-)

# Chapter E ght

Angella was a patient woman, an unsettling sort of patient that crept in silently until her clients' foes had no choice but to plead guilty to fill the static she created in their minds.

Okay, that was a bit dramatic, but she was still an overwhelming presence to have in a mother.

Though, ever since Adora started coming around, she had becomeless intimidating? W eird.

"Glimmer , are you expecting any company today?" Her mother asked as she typed away on her laptop from the kitchen table.

"No, why? Don't you normally do book club in the morning?" Glimmer asked as she looked through her cabinets for a snack.

"Y ou should invite Adora." Angella suggested as if her daughter hadn't spoken. "She's a very good influence to keep around."

Glimmer pulled her head out of the cabinet and quickly looked back at the woman who still hadn't torn her eyes from the screen in front of her. "Huh?"

"Adora Ryder , from across the street? I quite like having her around, it's been ages since she used to come over here for sleepovers or birthday parties. She's become such a respectable young lady." Angella praised with a small smile. Glimmer blinked in confusion.

"So you want me to spend more time with our neighbor?" She asked slowly.

"Adora, yes." The woman nodded. "She's some of the more *favorable* company you've had recently."

Glimmer tensed, biting down her rage at what her mother was insinuating. Adora was good, Catra was bad. Why did it always have to be black and white with her mom?

"She's busy ." She muttered, turning away to continue her search as she tried to calm herself down. Snapping wouldn't help, she'd probably just end up grounded from hanging out with *either* of the girls.

"That's too bad." Angella hummed.

That's it, she was gonna *snap* .

"What's your problem?" She huffed, turning around to look at her mother as she slammed her hands down onto the counter separating them.

"I beg your pardon?" Angella asked, a look of disgust and horror on her face as she finally looked at her daughter. (Glimmer couldn't help but roll her eyes.)

"Why does it matter what kind of 'influence' my friends are? Aren't I old enough to make those decisions for myself?" Glimmer pointed to herself as she raised her voice. "I can hang out with whoever I want!"

"Clearly not, if you're dating a *delinquent*!" Angella met her volume, sitting impossibly straighter against the chair.

"Stop telling me how to live my life!"

"I'm your mother, it's my *job* to put you on the correct path!"

"Yeah, sure, you just don't want me to have any *fun*! You act like I'm some irresponsible, dumb little kid, but I'm not! I'm *eighteen*, mom! I know right from wrong, so stop telling me which is which!" Glimmer said before storming up the stairs to her room.

"Glimmer? Glimmer Moonbright!" Angella called after her , the tell-tale clicking of her heels following all the way to the door before Glimmer shut and locked it, sliding down against it.

Angella's groan muffled through the door before the clicking footsteps faded back down the stairs, and Glimmer cried tears of frustration.

---

It wasn't until a few hours later that Glimmer heard the heels clicking back to her door, a quiet sigh passing through the door before she heard the knob jggle and twist to reveal her mother , arms crossed and looking unimpressed.

Glimmer stared at the now open door and then at the woman in front of it. "How did you-"

"Car . Now." Angella said, then turned and left the room. She groaned and followed, realising she had no other choice.

The car ride was silent, even when Glimmer asked where they were going or how long they would be gone. Eventually they arrived at the diner Glimmer often visited, being led to a booth near the back.

They sat down as Glimmer watched quietly as her mother ordered them each a strawberry milkshake (which seemed odd in itself, considering her mother's normal distaste for anything sweet) and order of cheese fries.

"Uh, mom? Are you okay?" She asked with a raised brow. "I've never seen you eat greasy diner food before." She said truthfully. Her mother always put her health and hygiene first, needing to look and feel good at all times for her career.

Angella actually *chuckled*, *smiling* at her daughter. "You're so much like your father." She said in an amused hum. "He'd ask the same thing if he had come with us."

Glimmer blinked, surprised. What brought *this* up?

"Catra reminds me of myself. The 'me' your father knew when we were still just college kids. Young and reckless and in love. I made a lot of bad choices at that age, and I see a lot of that in her, too. I don't *mean* to be so judgemental of her, I just can't help it." The woman explained, nodding as their paper container of fries and glass cups were brought to the table between them.

"And what, Adora reminds you of yourself now? The responsible, accomplished you?" Glimmer scoffed. Of course, she was trying to make Glimmer see things from her perspective to convince her to stay away from Catra.

"Not quite." Angella shook her head. "She reminds me of what I wish I was like at that age. Confident, self-assured, reliable. Someone you could ask for help, not someone you could have meaningless fun with."

Glimmer watched her take an extra cheesy fry and pop it into her mouth, sipping her milkshake after before patting her lips dry with a napkin.

"You aren't like me, though." Her mother continued. "You're like Micah. Sweet, funny, so full of love and full of life. You have all of his good qualities, I couldn't be more relieved at that."

Glimmer blushed at the comparison. She was so used to people saying she resembled her mom, she didn't really stop to think about what she might have in common with her dad.

"You know," Angella grinned, pausing briefly for some more fries. "Your father took me here for our first date. It's where I fell in love with him."

"It is?" Glimmer perked up. She'd never heard this story before.

"It is." Her mother chuckled. "Right in this booth. Or, well, maybe not *this* booth, what with remodeling and decorating over the years, but this spot." She shrugged.

Glimmer glanced around the diner she thought she knew so well, trying to picture it when her parents were around her age on a dorky first date. She looked back at her mother to find her absorbed with eating more fries and narrowed her eyes in suspicion. "Why are you telling me all this?" She wondered.

Angella met her daughter's gaze and swallowed, holding up a hand to wait as she took a sip of her beverage and sighed in delight. "Because I'm worried for you, quite frankly." She answered, speaking again before Glimmer could interject. "Yes, I know you're able to make your own decisions, you remind me *constantly* that you are. But a mother always worries."

Glimmer slumped back in the booth, crossing her arms with a frown that totally didn't look like a pout. (Okay, maybe a bit.) "So you're just going to keep trying to tell me who I can and can't like, figures." She muttered.

Angella tsked and shook her head, her lips pulled tight and brows furrowed; Choosing her words, Glimmer recognised the expression. "I just don't want anyone to break your heart." She said finally.

Glimmer felt her chest tighten, feeling in her soul that she'd soon have to deal with that pain firsthand. Her thoughts must have shown on her face, as her mother's hand came to rest over her own, rubbing her thumb soothingly over her daughter's knuckles.

"They won't hurt me." She said so weakly she didn't even believe herself. "They wouldn't. Adora is my friend and Catra"...

The older woman squeezed her hand slightly as she trailed off. "It's your *girlfriend.* I know. Just. Be careful." She advised, her eyes pleading with Glimmer as if saying: *If you never listen to any advice I give, let this be the one you take to heart.*

Glimmer nodded and took a deep breath, smiling softly.

"So, tell me more about you and dad."

# Chapter Nine

The days counted down all too fast yet slower than a crawl for Glimmer, who was torn between dreading the trip full of popular kids and wanting to be free of her contract with Catra so her life may return to some form of normalcy (and her friendship with Adora could stop being built on lies).

The car slowed to a stop as Glimmer grabbed her bag from the backseat only to find her door locked when she attempted to open it.

"Now , sweetie," her dad began, earning an instant groan, "I know this trip will have chaperones, but there's always the chance that one or two of the kids might try to sneak *something* into the lodge with them."

"Yes, dad, I know. No drinking, no drugs, no 'impulsive acts of passion'." She said, quoting her parents rules and warnings she'd been subjected to on a loop for the past *week*

"You have to keep your body just as safe as your mind!" Micah warned. Glimmer's face took on a noticeably red shade at what he was implying.

"Uh huh, great talk, dad." She muttered, struggling to open the door .

I mean it! A weak mind creates opportunities!"

"Yes, dad! I get it!"

"Just be safe, won't you? Do you need some prote-"

"*That's dad. I'm good. Tell mom and the Etchers I love them bye!*"

Glimmer managed to reverse the lock and slip out of the car before her father could continue, face hot with embarrassment as she stomped towards the bus to load her bags inside.

"Oh, hey Glimmer." Mermista greeted, arm locked with her fiance, Sea Hawk.

"Hey, Mermista." Glimmer sighed in relief, happy to engage in a *not* humiliating conversation.

"Shimmer! Pray tell, are you and Catra planning to join my beloved and I for some couple's bonding activities?" Sea Hawk announced jovially. (The guy liked to talk like a Shakespearean pirate for some reason, no one could ever figure out why. Glimmer thought it made him unique, and maybe just a *tiny* bit crazy.)

"He means are you guys going to come ski with us down Lovers Pass."Mermista translated (she did that a lot).

"Lovers Pass?"Glimmer tilted her head in confusion.

"Why , it's only the most romantic, most daring, most exhilarating slope imaginable! *Aventure* !"Sea Hawk proclaimed, striking some weird pose before smoothing out the mustache he'd been growing since grade seven.

"It's technically called Danger Lane. It's where all the couples go on this lame trip to have an excuse to cling to each other and make out before- or after- making it down the mountain."Mermista scoffed, rolling her eyes.

Glimmer blushed, forcing her mind away from anything that involved kissing or cuddling or...gah!No, she and Adora wouldn't- She and Catra *Catra* was her girlfriend. *Her* girlfriend.

"No, uh, I-I don't think we'll be joining you."She said, hoping her face didn't look as red as she thought it did.

"Ah, a pity . But!There will be plenty of opportunity for you and your lady friend, fret not."Sea Hawk patted her back with a grin.

"He means this place is full of secret kissing spots. His brother came last year for the trip and found, like, *seven* killer spots just by walking around for a few minutes." Mermista smirked at the taller man who turned sheepish when she grabbed his hand. "Anyway , we're gonna find our seats. I'm planning to sleep on the way up so I *need* to nab a seat in the back."

Glimmer waved awkwardly as she let everything sink in. She had heard rumors, sure, but that's all they had been. *Rumors.* And now she was expected to just *make out* with Catra on this trip? Oh man, her heart couldn't take this.

"Sparkles!" (Speak of the devil) Catra called with a grin, moving closer to lightly grab her by the jacket sleeve. "We're supposed to be finding our seats, you coming?" She asked.

Glimmer opened her mouth to answer when she noticed Adora not far behind her and tensed, putting on a forced grin as she gently slid out of her hold with an awkward chuckle. "Oh, uh, I was actually going to sit with Sea Hawk and Mermista!" She lied on the spot.

"...Really?" Catra blinked, her grin slowly fading as Glimmer watched Adora pause midstep, most likely overhearing her awful excuse.

"Y -Yeah! Mermista said she's going to sleep the whole trip, which meant poor Sea Hawk wouldn't have anyone to talk to! So he, uh, asked me to keep him company and I said yes." She finished the lie. (She thought that maintaining a fake relationship for the past few

months would help improve her lying capabilities, and cursed herself for her still-subpar skills in that department.)

"Oh." Catra muttered, shaking her head and shrugging as her smile returned a bit less brightly than before. "That's cool. We can just hang when we get there, right?"

"Right." Glimmer nodded, forcing her heart not to leap out of her chest when Catra ruffled her hair before turning to head into the bus.

Adora met her gaze before glancing at Catra and meeting her eyes again. She gave a lopsided smile and jogged after Catra, tapping her shoulder as the two exchanged brief words Glimmer couldn't overhear.

Oh. Why did it feel so *weird* and *wrong* for the two of them to sit together?

Without Glimmer?

---

The ride felt like sixty hours instead of six thanks to Sea Hawk's excitable chatter the entire ride, envious of Mermista's noise-canceling ear plugs the entire trip up to the snowy lodge.

Yeah, she was *not* riding back with them. *No thanks*.

She barely listened to the chaperones droning on and on ("stay to your assigned rooms, *blah blah blah,* no more than three to a room, *blah blah,* no romantic pairings allowed to share rooms, *et cetera et cetera*") before finding their own set of rooms to get checked in, leaving the students to find their *own* rooms. Big mistake on their part.

"Every man-or-other for themself!" Someone shouted, tossing the key cards in the air as couples and friend groups cheered and rushed the falling pile to grab a key before an adult could catch them.

"Oh, Glimmer!" Scorpia called with a wave. "Oh gosh, this is a bit awkward. Do you know anyone who doesn't have a roommate yet I could pair with? I've got a thing with sleeping alone outside of home." The lovable giant said, rubbing her neck.

Glimmer sighed in relief. "You know what? I'll room with you." She said with a grin.

"Oh, really? But I thought for *sure* you and Catra would-"

"Nope! Haha, no. She uh- I'm good rooming with you." Glimmer interrupted before she could blush where everyone could see.

"Oh, great!" Scorpia smiled. "Let's find our room, then." She said, picking up her own luggage as Glimmer trailed after her, ignoring the way she saw Catra try to approach her with her own key in hand.

---

"You're seriously not going to ski? It's a *sktrip*, Moonbright." Catra huffed, a (cute) frown on her face as she struggled to cross her arms in her oversized coat.

"I don't know how! I *tried* to tell you I shouldn't come." Glimmer said back with a slight smirk, maybe just a *bit* amused by the brunette's actions.

Catra sputtered and leaned in closer with a pout. "What will everyone here think if I go up to Danger Lane without my girlfriend?" She said, almost pleading with her.

"Sorry, Felina. No can do. I can't ski, and I'd rather not die on our *second day here.*" Glimmer stood her ground, feeling angel-Bow pat her shoulder in approval.

"Ohh, you don't ski either , Glimmer?" Scorpia asked with a grin as she stepped closer to the pair.

"What?!" Catra's voice cracked. "Y ou too, Scor?"

"Sorry , Wildcat! Acrophobia, remember? I can't go up mountains." Scorpia rubbed her arm with an apologetic grin.

"So *neither* of you are going? Who am I supposed to ski with?" The brunette asked, heterochromic eyes glaring at her friends until someone cleared their throat behind her.

"W ould you be okay with going up there with me?" Adora asked, looking more timid and nervous than Glimmer had seen her since their first brief interaction after *the kiss* (as it lived on in infamy within Glimmer's brain).

Catra looked at the blonde with a look Glimmer couldn't place before glancing her way, lips tightening in a thin line as she nodded stiffly. "Y eah, sure. Beats going alone." She reasoned, following after the other girl. She paused at the doorway and met Glimmer's eye before leaving, and Glimmer was *sure* her heart had been punctured by a wooden stake or meat cleaver due to how much it *hurt* to watch the two girls she loved leave together while she stayed behind.

---

Glimmer laughed at her phone screen with Scorpia as the two crowded together on Scorpia's bed to watch one of the pink haired girl's *may* downloaded 80s films.

"Is there any problem that *can't* be solved through song and dance?" The taller girl sighed with a grin, leaning back against the headboard as she idly rubbed her face with a fingertip, smudging her face mask a bit by her cheek.

Glimmer sighed along with her and rolled her eyes. "I *wish* my problems could be solved that easily."She joked.

"Trouble in paradise?"Scorpia asked, wiggling her eyebrows (which looked arguably hilarious with a bunny-face printed exfoliating mask).

Glimmer couldn't help but giggle as she began to delicately peel off her own tiger-face mask, shrugging with a strained smile. "I guess you could say that."She muttered.

Scorpia took the phone from Glimmer's free hand before she had time to react, pausing during the best part. (She may or may not consider *every* part of *Footloose* the "best part," but that didn't matter.) "Is Catra being a jerk to you? Do I need to have a stern talk with her?"The girl worried with a frown.

Glimmer thought over her words for a moment, trying to figure out the best way to come up with a believable lie that wouldn't get them caught.

But then she thought, what if she didn't *have* to make up another lie?

What if she just told Scorpia, and hoped for the best? What would she have to gain from telling anyone? How would she be hurt by this?

"Glimmer?" Scorpia's voice brought her out of her thoughts to realise she still hadn't responded.

"Can I tell you something?" Scorpia nodded, "You have to *swear* you won't tell anyone. Please."

"You have my word." Scorpia encouraged with a smile.

Glimmer took a deep breath and nodded, closing her eyes as she let out all of the lies and secrets she'd been keeping since the beginning of the school year. By the time she finished and opened her eyes again, Scorpia was staring at her, completely stunned.

"So... All this time, you and Catra- You and she- She- You- You two were *pretending* to date? To- Wait, *tricked* Adora? Aren't you two, like,

friends?"The girl asked slowly , the gears in her brain turning so visibly Glimmer swore she saw smoke coming from her ears.

Glimmer winced. Why did it sound even *worse* to hear it out loud? "...Yeah, that was the deal."She sighed.

"Sorry , sorry, not trying to judge you, it's just- *wow* , information overload, you know?"Scorpia chuckled weakly .

Glimmer sighed, thumping her head back against the headboard as she hid her face behind her hands. "I *know* . I'm just glad we agreed to call it off after the trip, then I never have to watch Catra pretend to be *in love* with me again."She muttered.

"Oh, you think she- You think she's *faking* it?"Scorpia asked, sounding a whole new breed of confused.

"Well, yeah."Glimmer let her hands flop to her lap to look at her , "That was kind of the biggest rule in the contract. It has to be believable."

"Wait wait wait."Scorpia shook her head, *grinning* for some reason, "You *really* think Catra is *pretending*?

Glimmer narrowed her eyes and nodded slowly as Scorpia began *laughing* at her. What the heck?

"Do you even *know* how excited she was for this trip? She wouldn't stop *talking* about how eager she was to hang out with 'the coolest girl ever'."Scorpia nudged her in the ribs lightly (though still hard enough to earn a grunt from the less athletic one in the room).

"Is that supposed to be me?"She asked, raising a brow.

"Yeah, you!"The taller girl grinned. "You know she was really bummed when she found out you weren't rooming together? At first I assumed it was because you two were *dating,* but now- Dude, she just wanted to be around you!She wanted your *company*."

If this were a cartoon, Glimmer's head would have probably exploded or turned into a tea kettle. But it's *not* a cartoon, so she just sat there with a stupid, blank look on her face while the other girl laughed and laughed.

"You should go talk to her."She encouraged after her laughing fit.

"I- I don't even know where she is."Glimmer sighed, running a hand through her hair.

I do."Scorpia grinned, holding up her phone displaying her most recent conversation: Catra.

---

Of all the places to sulk, *why* did that insufferable girl have to pick the most annoying spot in the lodge to get to?

Glimmer eventually made it out to the hot tubs, shivering around her light jacket (Scorpia advised wearing lots of layers would be pointless if she wanted to get in the water, but she never mentioned just how *cold* it would be) by the time she spotted the girl she was looking for.

"Hey , Catra."She greeted softly , seeming to startle the brunette as she nearly dropped her phone in the tub before setting it down on the rim again.

"Oh, hey Moonbright."Catra muttered, attempting to cover her waist with her arms as if that would hide the smoking hot bikini she was wearing from view. "What are you doing out here?"

"Scorpia said I could find you up here."Glimmer shrugged, sitting opposite the other girl with just her lower legs dipping into the nice, warm water.

"Of course she did." Catra rolled her eyes, smiling faintly .

Silence stretched between them for a few minutes, faint music and conversation from the lodge down the hill taking up the space their voices weren't.

"Why're you avoiding me?" Catra eventually asked as Glimmer's eyes shot up to meet her gaze. "And don't say you haven't been."

Glimmer held the look for a few seconds and sighed as she looked back down at her feet in the water. "I don't know ." She chuckled weakly. "But..I'm sorry ." She added, glancing back up with a soft smile.

Catra frowned at her and sighed, running a wet hand through her dry hair as Glimmer tried not to drool at the sight. "Apology accepted." She muttered. "But uh, I guess I kind of owe you."

"For what?" Glimmer furrowed her brows in confusion.

"W ell, since you've been keeping your distance all trip, Adora started keeping me company." A fond smile crossed her lips before she looked at Glimmer and forced it away. "So we made up. No more hard feelings."

Glimmer blinked. "Okay ..." She said slowly, mixed between feeling relief that the animosity was gone and jealous that the two were becoming close again, a third feeling of confusion taking root due to the second.

"What I mean is-" Catra took a deep breath before continuing more slowly and calmly, "We can end the contract. Adora *clearly* knows you aren't into her anymore, and I don't need to show her that I'm 'better without her' anymore." She explained, using air quotes as she apparently quoted either herself or Adora's words (Glimmer wasn't sure which sounded more likely).

Glimmer bit her lip, noticing the way Catra's smile didn't reach her eyes as she talked about ending this. Was it too much to hope that the girl didn't want things to end?

"What- What about you and me?" She blurted before she could stop herself.

Catra's eyes widened in surprise. "What do you mean? What *about* us?" She repeated.

"Like," Glimmer blushed as she watched the signature smirk creep onto Catra's lips, "A-After the contract. Will we still be?..."

"Friends?" Catra finished for her. "Sure, if you want." She shrugged, her eyes gleaming like she just *knew* that wasn't what she was going

to say.

"I- I," Glimmer corrected, then cleared her throat as she ignored the way her voice had cracked. "Can we keep being *us.*"

"That depends." Catra drawled with a shrug.

"On- On what?" Glimmer asked timidly.

"What does 'us' mean to you, Sparkles?" Catra wondered, leaning back against the wall of the tub with her arms splayed out behind her along the rim of it.

Glimmer tensed, feeling the heat radiating against her face as she watched Catra gaze at her with a taunting grin. She took a deep breath and slowly unzipped her jacket, letting it fall from her shoulders onto the frigid pavement behind her to reveal her two-piece swimsuit. She lowered into the water and swam the short distance to reach the other girl, watching the shocked look on her face as she sat close enough to clearly see her constellation of freckles. (If she wasn't scared out of her mind, she probably would have giggled at the brunette's expression.)

"Well. What does it mean to you?" She asked softly, feeling like her heart could stop from looking into those stunning eyes she couldn't help but love.

Catra blinked as her smirk returned. "It means I want to sit with you on the ride back. That I want to drive you home and take the long way so we can sit together longer. That I called your dad before the trip and ordered your favorite snacks online since they don't sell them at *any* of the nearby stores, only for you to sit with Mermista and Sea Hawk when we could've been eating them the whole way up here." Catra went on and on as one of her hands slowly came to rest on her hip as Glimmer let out a silent gasp.

"You- You got me my favorite snacks?" Glimmer repeated, her head swimming and heart pounding at the closeness of their bodies and the sweet words Catra was saying to her.

"A whole *box* of them. There were so many in my package that I had to leave half of them at home to leave room in my bag." Catra chuckled as her other hand came up from the tub's rim to rest on her cheek, cool and damp from the freezing air outside of the water. "What do *you* think that means about how I see us?"

"That-" Glimmer's breath hitched as she tried to take a deep breath, her senses swarmed with the smell of chlorine and Catra. "That I have great taste in food?" She asked, her voice barely audible in her own ears.

"You're *impossible*, Moonbright." Catra whispered, using both hands to grab Glimmer's hips and lift her through the water onto her lap as the girl let out a startled squeak at the movement with wide eyes.

"I know you said no kissing, but-" Glimmer cut off her annoying teasing by pressing their lips together, just for a second at first before Catra chased her retreating lips for a longer, softer kiss.

Glimmer felt like her heart would explode as their lips moved against each other, gripping the other girl's shoulders lightly just to ground herself as her head felt ready to burst. Catra was way too good at kissing, it should have been illegal to be that skilled.

She lost track of time as they kissed, losing herself to the feeling of Catra's full, chapped lips against her own for who knows how long before she finally pulled away, panting for air as their foreheads pressed together.

"Still think I'm only interested in snacks?" Catra teased quietly, as if any sudden sounds would ruin the moment they were caught in.

Glimmer laughed breathlessly and splashed her slightly with water as Catra grinned brighter than any of the stars above them at her, leaning in to press kiss after kiss across her face as Glimmer giggled and weakly attempted to push her away (not hard enough to actually *stop* her, though).

"Come on, I'll walk you back to your room. Don't want you getting sick." Catra offered, gently nudging Glimmer away as she blushed upon realising she was still in the girl's lap. Glimmer quickly scrambled back as Catra chuckled and climbed out. (It took every

drop of willpower Glimmer had not to stare shamelessly at her bikini-clad form until the towel was secured around Catra's body to shield her.)

Glimmer followed her lead and hopped out after her with the help of an offered hand from the brunette, picking up her fallen jacket to wrap around herself for warmth as she shivered from the cold night air.

They talked and giggled quietly the whole way back, being quiet so they wouldn't disturb anyone or draw attention to themselves as they made their way inside the heated building and up to Glimmer and Scorpia's room.

"Guess this is it. Goodnight, Sparkles." Catra whispered, turning to leave.

Glimmer grabbed hold of her towel to tug her close again, catching Catra's stumble by wrapping her arms around the girl's waist for a final, lasting kiss. "Goodnight, Catra." She whispered, giggling at the wide grin on the girl's face as Catra waved and turned to walk away.

Glimmer closed her door softly and sighed, a lovesick grin on her face as she leaned against it. She crept back to her bed- careful not to wake her roommate- and laid down against the pillow, closing her eyes as she let everything that happened that night play through her mind on repeat until she fell asleep, warm to her bones and happy.

---

Glimmer spent the rest of her time on the trip with Catra, even letting the girl teach her to ski using the beginner slopes (with kisses as rewards for remembering the rules and steps involved, which was by far Glimmer's biggest motivation for learning). It felt nice spending time with Catra now that the contract wasn't forcing them to, letting herself relax and let loose to really have fun and enjoy herself until they had to leave at the end of the week.

She caught Adora's gaze on her as they were loading up the bus to go home, turning to face her only to be tapped on the shoulder just as the blonde took a step to approach her. Catra held up a bag of Glimmer's favorite treat and nodded towards the bus for the girl to follow her inside. She shot Adora an apologetic grin and shrugged before climbing onto the bus to find nearly their entire class staring at either them or Adora not far behind and furrowed her brows in confusion as she found a seat beside her former contract-mate.

"What's everyone staring at?" She whispered to Catra.

"Beats me, just ignore them." Catra shrugged, offering Glimmer the bag from before as she pulled out one of her own, bumping them together before tilting her head back to let the contents fall in her mouth.

Glimmer glanced around once more anxiously before sighing and following Catra's lead with the snacks as she pushed it to the back of

her mind.

The ride was over *much* faster this time (Glimmer figured it had something to do with Sea Hawk being on the opposite end of the vehicle from her) and before she knew it, she was already in line to grab her bags when she felt a hand on her shoulder.

"Oh, hey Adora." She greeted after turning around, smiling up at her friend.

"Hey , Glimmer." Adora said, a frown on her face as *she* avoided *Glimmer's* eye for once. "Um, I don't know what you might have heard, but it was a total accident and I'm really sorry." She said quickly .

Glimmer blinked in confusion. "Uh, what are you talking about?" She asked slowly.

"She didn't tell you?" Adora asked, her gaze shooting up to lock on the other girl's with wide eyes.

"Okay , look, I want you to know as your friend that it was *not* supposed to happen and I'd take it back if I could because I would *never* try to hurt you on purpose but-"

"Adora, what is it?"

"Catra and I kissed!" The blonde eventually blurted, squeezing her eyes shut as she held her hands over her ears. "We kissed, okay?! I didn't mean to, we didn't *try* to, it just- It *happened*, okay? Please don't hate me!"

Glimmer stared at her in shock, too stunned to speak. All the times she and Catra had been hanging out, had *kissed,* and not *once* did she tell her that she had kissed her ex?

"I.. I need to go." Adora's voice brought her from her thoughts in time to see Adora sling her duffle and backpack over her shoulders and bolt away from her like Glimmer was contagious.

"Hey, Sparkles!" Catra's voice called from behind her, sounding distant and distorted in her ears as she could only blankly stare off even when the brunette stood directly in front of her. "Woah, you okay?"

Glimmer shook her head to clear the fog around her brain and frowned at Catra's look of concern. "When were you going to tell me you kissed Adora?" She asked in a mumble.

Catra froze, her worried look traded for one of fear. "You.. You know about that?" She asked, her voice cracking.

Glimmer scoffed. The *nerve* of this girl! She grabbed her rolling bag and pulled it with her as she turned to leave.

"Glimmer , wait, please." Catra said, wrapping a hand around her arm to hold her back as the girl tugged away from the touch like it was fire.

"When did it happen? Before, or *after* you kissed me?" Glimmer asked, feeling tears well in her eyes that she *refused* to let fall. Not here, where everyone could see.

"A-After , but please just let me-"

"So you kiss me, and then run off to your *ex*? While still kissing me at the same time!?" She said in disbelief, not caring if her voice raised.

Catra winced, looking like she had been slapped. Glimmer resisted her desire to hug her close and tell her everything was okay. Because everything was *not* okay.

Not anymore.

I didn't think you were that kind of girl."She scof fed and turned to leave. Catra didn't stop her this time.

She didn't know whether that was for better or worse.

She walked all the way across campus before collapsing onto a bench, pulling her knees to her chest as she pulled out her phone, wiping her tears to dial the correct number.

Mom? I know I said Catra would drive me home, but.C-Can you come pick me up, please?

# Chapter Ten

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The ride home was silent (Glimmer didn't know if that made her feel better or not) before she finally arrived at her house, thankful that her Christmas break started the next day so she'd have some time before she was due to see Catra again. (She tried not to feel her heart break remembering the way the brunette had dramatically whined and complained that Glimmer wasn't accompanying her for her mothers' large and festive Hanukkah party, *another* thing that would start sometime that week.)

She sighed and began walking towards the porch, only to be stopped by a hand on her shoulder. Looking back, Glimmer saw her mom wearing a tight-lipped smile, her eyes full of confusion and sadness that only added to the girl's heartbreak.

"I won't pry for details, but just know that I'm here, Glimmer, if you need someone to talk to." Angella said softly.

Glimmer smiled back weakly- tiredly- and nodded before walking the remaining steps up the little wooden stairs of the porch and over to her front door, opening it with a deep breath of relief. She was finally home, where she could relax and have time to forget about her worries.

"Well someone sure looks happy to see me." A *distinctly* familiar voice called sarcastically from inside the house. Glimmer looked around before spotting none other than Bow and the other Fletchers sitting on the couch, grinning at her.

"Bow!" She said, her pain and heartache pushed to the back of her mind for now as she dropped her bags and raced forward so fast it felt like jumping through time and space to tackle her best friend in a hug so strong the couch nearly toppled over.

"Glimmer!" The boy echoed in a strained voice as the girl crushed him with her embrace. George and Lance laughed as they attempted to pull Glimmer away before she finally relented and gave Bow the air he needed.

"What are you doing here? I thought you weren't supposed to fly in until Christmas Eve!" She said, resting her hands on his hips as she essentially sat in his lap to maintain closeness.

Bow chuckled and ruffled her hair with a grin. "I heard you were going on a trip and thought I'd surprise you by coming home early!" He explained.

"When did you get here?"

"Last night."

"How long were you waiting for me to come home?"

"Only a couple of hours."

"Did you do something new with your hair?"

"Glimmer!" The boy laughed. "Can you interrogate me *later* you tell me about your trip?"

"Only if you tell me all about campus life!" She compromised, standing from the couch as she began excitedly tugging his hand to get Bow to stand with her. "We'll be in my room!" She called, already racing up the stairs with her friend stumbling along behind her to keep up.

She heard the sound of their parents' laughter from the living room, the smell of peppermint and pine in the air, and finally felt like her world had returned to normal.

---

That night, Glimmer sat cuddled up next to her best friend in the world, watching cheesy Christmas movies without a care in the

world.

Only, that was a lie. She had a *lot* of cares in the world, namely her newfound heartbreak and her torn feelings of betrayal and jealousy over Adora kissing Catra.

It must have shown on her face, because suddenly Bow was facing her, eyes full of concern and mirrored heartache.

"You okay?" He whispered, fumbling in his shirt pocket for one of his (dorky) handkerchiefs without tearing his eyes away from her face.

Glimmer took a deep breath and shook her head before falling forward into the boy's arms, crying into his chest as he gently pulled her closer and rocked them back and forth, shushing her quiet sobs soothingly.

"What happened? Do you wanna talk about it? Can you?" He asked softly, patiently, and his kindness only made the tears fall harder because she had *missed* this boy with her whole heart.

"Just hold me." She asked, her voice a broken whisper as she hiccuped and sobbed silently against him.

"You got it. I've got you." Bow said, pressing a gentle kiss to the top of her head as Glimmer cried and cried.

Until there were no tears left to give.

---

Bow tried endlessly to cheer Glimmer up all through the week leading to Christmas, telling her stories about college life (which made her jealous she was still in highschool, truly), talking about his new friends (who Glimmer did *not* want to meet, actually), making cookies and cupcakes together (Glimmer's area of expertise, but not something her heart was in, currently), even making snow angels (which filled Glimmer with paranoia that Adora could be watching from across the street at all times)!

Glimmer was just not feeling very festive, to put it lightly.

The pair sat stiffly on the couch the night before Christmas, watching some old Christmas movie made before either of them were born while their parents laughed and drank eggnog in the kitchen. The atmosphere was warm and inviting, but Glimmer just *couldn't* enjoy any of the fun her family was having. Not even sitting beside her best friend (a boy she had missed *terribly*) could help to ease the pain of heartbreak.

It felt like she had broken her heart *twice* that day: first with Adora's betrayal at kissing Catra, and then at Catra for not telling her about it. Didn't they care about her feelings? Was that their way of telling her they were both fine without her, that they preferred each other over her?

He wrapped an arm around her waist as if sensing her thoughts darkening again, moving the girl's head onto his shoulder to brush his fingers gently through her hair. (If one thing in this world could calm Glimmer down no matter what, it was an unprompted, much needed hug from her best friend.)

Glimmer closed her eyes, counting each stroke Bow's hand made through her hair until she dozed off in his arms. (She was only free from her pain when she slept, so she'd been doing that much more often these days.)

---

A week had never passed so slowly in the pink haired girl's life. No test week or final school day before summer break had ever moved at such a snail's pace. She could practically *feel* the clock ticking each and every moment of the day from the moment she woke to the moment she slept, which was a strange contrast to how her memories seemed to blur together of the day's events each time.

"Glimmer, aren't you going to set your presents under the tree? You've been talking about how proud you were of this year's gifts for

months."Angella called with a light knock to her door .

Glimmer sighed and rolled herself out of bed, fussing with her pajama shirt and bottoms so it looked like she had just woken up rather than stayed awake for the past four hours staring at a single crack in her ceiling.

She opened her door and pretended not to notice the gasp and look of pity her mother flashed her, taking a deep breath to speak. "Yeah, sure. Five minutes."She said, turning to close the heavy piece of wood between them before the taller woman caught it with her heel-clad foot.

Angella gently pushed the door back open and stepped inside before lightly clicking it shut again as the two stood in silence for a while, not quite looking at each other but not pointedly looking away either .

Her mother stepped closer and hesitantly rested a hand on the girl's shoulder, giving it what could barely count as a squeeze. "I can tell something's been on your mind. I can.I'm here if.Maybe we could."Glimmer's interest was piqued, having never seen this self-assured, confident woman stutter before. "Let's talk, shall we?"

Glimmer forced a tight-lipped smile and nod as her mother steered her back to her bed, not even protesting when the woman began fixing her disheveled appearance like she usually would.

"What happened?" An innocent enough question.

"Nothing." A blatant lie.

"Glimmer ." A warning scold.

"We had a fight, it's fine." A less blatant, still outright lie.

"Glimmer Moonbright." Her mother crossed her arms, suddenly making aware that she meant business.

Glimmer sighed, not having the strength or energy to protest or play into their usual banter that would escalate into an argument on a good day and a fight on a bad day. "We broke up." She muttered, as close to the truth as she could get.

Angella's face turned from cold to soft faster than Glimmer had ever seen before, resting a hand on her daughter's cheek to rub her thumb gently just beneath the teen's eye. "Oh, dear ." She whispered.

Glimmer lightly shrugged the hand off to look down at her lap. It felt so wrong for her mother to comfort her over a *lie* . Catra was never hers, never had been. They had used each other, only Glimmer was dumb enough to get her heart broken because of it. She had known

it wouldn't last, but she still let herself believe Catra could care about her. Could want her. Could *choose* her.

How stupid, utterly stupid.

"It's fine." Glimmer lied again, feeling her throat burn as she knew she'd start crying at any moment. "It was never going to last, it's stupid for me to get so upset over it." She shrugged again, trying desperately to play it off like it wasn't the worst loss she had ever experienced in her life.

She nearly broke down when her mother pulled her into her arms, rubbing soothing circles into her back as Glimmer took deep, slow breaths to seem as normal as possible.

"It's alright, it's going to be alright." The woman whispered, and that was the final act needed to completely shatter Glimmer's illusion of being okay about all of this. She cried, hands cupping her face as Angella pulled her into her lap like she was a child again having a nightmare.

Only this wasn't a nightmare, this was all *painfully* real.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry it's been a while, I've been hit with a bad case of writer's block and struggled to advance the story. I hope this can kind of make up for my absence, at least a bit!

# Chapter E even

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

If there were two people she didn't expect (or want) to see over the holiday break, Adora Ryder ranked as a tied first place on that list.

"I brought my mom's potato salad!" The blonde girl said with obvious amounts of forced cheer, her fingers pale white from the cold as she held a large ceramic bowl covered by plastic wrap in her hands. "I-I figured we weren't invited for Christmas dinner this year for, um, obvious reasons, but we know how much your parents and Bow love this stuff, so." She awkwardly held her hands out for her neighbor to take while Glimmer continued to stand in the doorway, just as stunned as she had been when first opening it.

"Moonbeam, you're letting in the cold!" Her dad called from the kitchen with a lighthearted chuckle.

Glimmer swallowed the dry, itchy lump in her throat and stepped forward onto the porch, closing the door behind her to leave her alone with Adora, only a few steps and a bowl of potatoes between them.

Adora drummed her fingers against the sides of the bowl (for her nerves or to maintain feeling in the frozen appendages, Glimmer wasn't sure) as she gazed at Glimmer so softly, so openly, that the

other girl wanted to scream. "Uh, do- Do you not want the salad? I can tell my mom, she-"

"No, no, we want it." The shorter girl said, moving her arms almost robotically to get them to grab the bowl and cradle it close so it wouldn't fall. "Is that all?" She asked, letting a bit of hope leak into her tone accidentally.

Adora sighed, sticking her cold fingers into her pockets (Glimmer pushed away a particular thought about letting Adora's hands rest in her hair as they kissed with music swelling all around) as she looked down at her shoes instead. (Fuzzy horse-printed socks, cute.)

"I wanted to apologise." She said, glancing up for half a second to gauge the other girl's reaction before returning her gaze to her feet instead. "I know I hurt you, and what I did was so stupid. It wasn't worth losing my best friend over."

Glimmer's heart (betrayingly) skipped a beat. Adora's *best friend* Had she ever really deserved that title?

"But it didn't happen how you might think." The blonde's voice brought her back from her thoughts as she blinked at the athlete in surprise. "*She* kissed *me*, Glimmer. I didn't mean to betray you, I promise, it just- It felt, for a moment, like we were still together," (Glimmer's heart clenched at the softness in her tone) "like we had never broken up. W-Which I know doesn't make it any better, I *knew* you two were together, and I still just *let it happen*. I totally

understand if you never want to be my friend again or never come to my games or want me out of your life or never invite me over to your house or-"

"*Adora*," Glimmer called to stop the girl's anxious spiralling, resisting every urge she had to drop the bowl and use her warm hands to brush away the tears in her eyes. "She.. Catra kissed you?" She echoed, feeling embarrassed by how much her voice cracked and saddened by how Adora visibly flinched when she spoke.

The blonde nodded slowly as she took a slow, shaky breath to calm down. "We were taking the lift up one of the mountains, the day before we had to leave the lodge. I.. I asked her if she ever thought about *us*- nothing serious, just out of curiosity!- and she said yes and leaned in and- We kissed. Just for a second or two, I swear. I would never intentionally hurt you, Glimmer. I'm so sorry."

Glimmer's head swirled as she processed this new information, her grip faltering on the bowl as Adora lunged forward to save it. Glimmer shivered as she felt the girl's cold fingers pressed against her own and looked up, suddenly trapped in those eyes she'd avoided for so long for at *least* a few minutes of stillness.

"I- I'm still mad, *very* mad, but I.. forgive you, Adora." She eventually said after much internal debate, so softly she wondered for a moment if the taller girl could hear her before a small smile graced her perfect lips.

"Y ou- You do?" Adora asked just as soft, sounding a bit breathless.

Glimmer nodded, still unable to look anywhere that wasn't her lovely gray-blue eyes. "I know you didn't mean it. That you aren't that kind of girl. You wouldn't steal someone's" *f a* "girlfriend like that." She said.

Adora looked like she was either going to laugh or cry, and Glimmer wasn't sure which seemed more likely until the girl let out a mixture of both, a strangled sound of relief caught in her throat. "Thank you. *Tha k* you." She whispered, her hands trembling slightly over Glimmer's own.

Glimmer finally managed to look up and saw some of the fake ornamental mistletoe they'd set up on the front porch, heart stalling when Adora noticed it too.

"W e don't have to-"

"Only if you want to-"

The two blinked at each other after speaking in sync, letting out a shared chuckle before Adora craned her neck down to meet her lips in a minty kiss. (Adora *did* have a weak spot for peppermint treats.)

"Does this mean I can still come over for dinner tomorrow?" Adora asked slowly.

Glimmer kissed her again in reply, feeling more happy and free than she had all week. She knew it was a fleeting moment of joy, that soon enough *she* would enter her thoughts again and ruin her good mood, but if a week's worth of heartbreak could be momentarily cured by Adora Ryder's kiss? She figured that was a trade she could be happy with.

---

Christmas was a bit easier for Glimmer to handle. It was a day of joy and laughter, wasn't it? She owed it to not only herself, but to her family to have a good day. She even got everything she wanted! Well, *almost* everything she wanted. She tried to ignore the dull ache as she shifted all of her attention to the various new clothes or makeup sets she had been gifted, the beginner cook books and customized shoes, even the knitted sweater her aunt sent her every year she treated like something priceless and valuable.

Anything she could do to keep her mind occupied, she did to her best ability. Though, some things proved to be harder than others to keep un-Catra-fied. Like, for instance, the pink leather jacket her mother had bought her only made her imagine how pretty the brunette would look in comparison with it on, or the eyeshadow palette that looked suspiciously like the same colors the heterochromic girl wore somewhere in her attire on a daily basis. Or the fact that her *ex-girlfriend* was sitting on her floor, where Glimmer

could feel her gaze burning into her no matter where she stood or sat.

She tried her best to ignore the confused or downright concerned looks from those around her as she passed out a few presents each for all three Fletchers as well as her parents, Adora, and Adora's mom Mara, painfully aware of the small stack of presents still lying around her bedroom closet with no one to open them.

It felt like coming back into her body when her father rested a hand on her shoulder, guiding her up off of the couch with a gentle nudge towards the door.

He looked her in the eyes and held her lightly by the shoulders. "Catra's at the door . Do you want me to ask her to leave?" He asked so softly it made Glimmer's heart clench.

She took a deep breath and shook her head, straightening her spine to appear taller, more confident than she felt. "No. I want to know why she's here." She answered, casting a momentary glance to make sure the blonde was still distracted with her gifts.

Micah gave her arm a light squeeze of support before stepping back for her to open the door. "I'll stay close by if you need anything." He said, patting her back before closing the door after her.

Glimmer summoned all of her courage to look up from the porch to see Catra standing in her yard holding a flat, round box with a badly-wrapped lump on top, smiling nervously at soon as their eyes met.

"Hey , Moonbright." Catra said quietly , gripping the box a bit tighter in her glove-clad hands.

Glimmer sighed and shook her head. She didn't want smalltalk, she wanted answers . "Why are you here, Catra?" She asked, surprising herself by how tired she sounded.

The brunette faltered at her tone slightly, (something Glimmer relished she could take pride in) clearing her throat as she blinked and looked down at the items in her hands rather than the girl before her. "I- I wanted to give you your gifts. I know we never really agreed to give them to each other, so I don't expect anything back, but… Here." She said, holding out the stack with big, glossy eyes.

Glimmer looked down at the presents and then at Catra's face as she took a few steps forward to step onto the lawn as well. Did she really expect to be forgiven just because she got her some gifts?

"Go home, Catra. Don't you have a party or something to get back to?" She said more bitterly then intended, unable to keep the hurt out of her voice.

"Sparkles-"

"Don't 'Sparkles' me, Felina. Go home." Glimmer said again more sternly. She could feel the eyes of everyone in the house watching from the window and felt an incoming panic that they were about to watch her be humiliated yet again by this girl she gave her heart to.

Catra let out a frustrated huff as she gripped the box so tight Glimmer wondered if she would crush it. "Can you just hear me out? I'm not asking for forgiveness, Moonbright. I just want to give you some presents on Christmas. That's all I want!"

"What about what *I* want, huh?" Glimmer surprised even herself by how much her voice raised. "Have you ever stopped to think that maybe I don't want to be around you anymore!?"

She heard the door click then slam shut before heavy footfalls approached from her house, a strong, familiar hand clamping onto her arm.

"Go home, Catra. She said she doesn't want to be around you, so go!" Adora said sternly , standing half a step behind Glimmer yet close enough to feel the blonde's warmth.

"I can handle this, Adora, go back inside." Glimmer said through clenched teeth, trying not to raise her voice again.

Catra glanced between the two, so many emotions passing over her face so quickly that Glimmer couldn't tell what she was really feeling. She let out an unstable chuckle, shifting to hold the items with one arm as she ran a hand through her hair to knock the maroon beanie off of her head. "Oh, *this* is just *perfect*." She hissed, tears quickly welling in her eyes as her face turned red with what Glimmer could only assume was rage (though her continuous laughter made it hard to tell for certain). "No, really, this is just rich! You two? Together? Oh man, and here I thought you were over her, Moonbright. Was this your plan all along? Use me to make her want you? Wow, and here I thought it was the other way around."

Adora's grip slacked and then tightened again, stepping a bit closer. "What's *that* supposed to mean?" She spat.

"I just find it so funny that my *real* ex and my <u>fake</u> ex are all cute and cuddly now that you've both decided to ignore my texts and calls." Catra scoffed. "Of *course*."

"Real- Fake- What are you *talking* about?" Adora asked, and Glimmer paled through her welling tears at what Catra was hinting about.

"Well, the contract's been broken so I guess it's fine to tell you, isn't that right *Sea Hawk*?" The brunette continued without giving her a chance to respond. "You see, Glimmer here was only 'dating' me so we could both- what's a good word for it? that's it, *deceive* you. She played my cute and innocent little girlfriend so I could get back at you while *she* used *me* as her big tough bodyguard to throw off the fact

that she had it *bad* for you. But by the looks of it, she *still* has it bad for you. So much for cute and innocent."

The glare Catra sent her way chilled Glimmer to her core much harder than the air around them ever could. She felt the tears in her eyes start to fall, matching Catra's own as she stared into her red-rimmed, puffy eyes.

Adora's hand dropped from her shoulder as she heard her footsteps retreat slightly, glancing over to see that the girl had backed away from Glimmer with a look of hurt on her face. "Glimmer? Is that- Is this true?" She asked, her voice wavering and her lips trembling as she tried not to join the other girls in crying.

"Believe it, babe." Catra cooed just to spite them.

Adora's head snapped off of Glimmer to glare at the uninvited guest. "*Don't* call me that." She warned, voice like ice.

"Or what, you'll talk about lacrosse drills to me? Make me listen while you read from your scheduling binders? Watch a horse documentary with me? Face it, blondie, for being so strong and tough, you're about as intimidating as a hamster. And about as *annoying* as a stuck-up, goodie-two-shoes, controlling perfectionist. Oh, wait, that's already what you are."

"At least I know how to apologise when I mess up, Catra! At least *I* own up to my mistakes! Have you ever said 'I'm sorry' to Glimmer? *That* would be shocking. Especially considering you've *never* even apologised to *me*! We've been broken up for how long now, Catra? Six, seven months? Where's *my* apology for everything you put me through!?"

Glimmer clamped her hands over her ears as the two girls she loved more than anything in the world practically *screamed* at each other in her front yard, not even five steps away from her.

"Stop it! Just *stop*!" She cried out desperately as both girls instantly quieted. Her eyes stayed tightly shut, but she could only imagine what kinds of looks she must have received. "Yes, Adora, I admit it. I was dating Catra so you wouldn't find out how I feel. But *you*," She opened her eyes to glare at the startled brunette through her wet, cloudy vision, "hurt *both* of us. You hurt *me*, Catra." Her voice softened as she lowered her hands to dangle at her sides. "Just when I thought you might actually care about me, you *shattered* my heart."

Catra stared at her as Glimmer glared right back, neither backing down or backing off. Finally, the heterochromic girl let out a muffled sound of frustration as she slammed the box down onto the ground. "Merry Christmas." She rasped, wiping her tears on her sleeve as she turned to her car and sped off down the road until the sound of her car faded into the distance.

Glimmer didn't know what she expected to happen next, but it certainly wasn't to be hugged by the girl she played like a pawn.

Adora wrapped her arms tightly around her shoulders from the side, rubbing her arm up and down slowly as Glimmer could only blankly stare ahead at where Catra once stood.

"Aren't you- You should *hate* me." She finally managed to whisper, her throat feeling tight and red-hot like something was clawing at it from deep inside. "How can you even touch me right now?"

Adora sighed, removing one hand as Glimmer noticed the blonde was crying now, too. "I could *never* hate you, Glimmer." She whispered, sounding so small and defeated that Glimmer felt like kicking herself and jumping head-first into shark-infested waters.

"Glimmer." The girl spun around quickly to notice that her *entire* family had been watching from the porch for who *knows* how long. Bow stepped closer and cupped her cheeks, brushing her tears away as Adora stepped back to let him take over, wrapping her arms around her own chest tightly. "Is that true? You *lied* about your letters? To *both* of them?" He asked, his voice somewhere between shocked and betrayed despite his face only showing worry for his friend.

Glimmer felt a sob wrack her body as she nodded and fell forward into his arms. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm so sorry." She whispered over and over again until she was out of breath, shaking in his arms.

He gently pushed her shoulders and held them tightly as he frowned while looking at her face. "*I'm* not the one who needs an apology

right now."He reminded, turning Glimmer to the side to look over at Adora, crouched in the snow to find the presents Catra dropped.

She rushed over the instant she had noticed Adora's fingers turn bright red from the cold, guiding the girl's hands into her insulated pockets for warmth. She stared into those gray-blue eyes she adored and watched how dull they looked, how they couldn't even look her way.

"Adora, I'm so sorry . I'll never be sorry enough. It's been eating me inside not to tell you, I'm so sorry you got dragged into this."She whispered, silently begging for the girl to look her way, just for a moment.

"You lied to me, Glimmer. I thought we agreed to be honest with each other, didn't we? Why didn't you tell me? Why did you do *any* of this?"Adora asked, closing her eyes as more tears fell and stained her rosy cheeks.

Glimmer felt her heart still to nothingness at her questions, taking a breath so deep her chest aches before letting it out slowly. "It wasn't supposed to go on for this long. It was just supposed to last a couple of weeks, just until you forgot about the letter or something. I- I never meant for it to go this far, I never meant to *hurt* you like this."

"I'm more hurt that you *lied* to me than that you *tricked* me."Adora sighed, shaking her head. "Why her? Why Catra?"She asked,

pulling Glimmer closer a step by her pockets. "Out of *anyone* at school, why did it have to be her?"

Glimmer tried to think of a reason, something that would sound less awful than the truth, her mouth opening and closing like a fish out of water.

"Catra got a letter , too." Bow answered for her , stepping over to pick up the nearly-forgotten gifts as he brushed the snow and sleet off of them to hold in his arms. "Glimmer loved both of you. She still does." He said, ignoring the wide-eyed look of horror on his best friend's face.

Adora blinked, glancing back at the shorter girl. "Y ou lied because… you love me?" She whispered. "And you and Catra- The two of you- Because you also-?"

Glimmer sighed, running both hands through her hair. "It's true. No more lies. I hurt you because I love you and I've never known how to say it. I agreed to be with Catra because I love her. And I *ruined* any chances for you two to get along ever again because I was stupid and childish And couldn't even gather the courage to tell either of you that I-"

"I love you, Glimmer ."

The pink haired girl froze, lifting her gaze back up to look at Adora with a stunned-stupid expression. "You what?"

"Glimmer, I've been in love with you since, like, grade four." Adora said, shaking her head. "So you mean to tell me this whole awful, painful mess could've been avoided if we just- If we *talked about our feelings*?" She gave a laugh of disbelief as the shorter girl could only stare blankly at her, jaw dropped and spine stiff.

"Huh?" She said eloquently.

Adora sighed and removed her hands from the girl's pockets to cradle Glimmer's face in her hands, leaning closer. "We were both *such* idiots." She muttered before leaning in to kiss her so hard Glimmer nearly lost balance if not for Adora's strength and reflexes keeping them both upright.

Glimmer kissed back as much as she could, but she couldn't *begin* to compete with Adora when it came to kissing, she was *insanely* good at it. (Why was everyone better at kissing than she was?) When the blonde finally pulled away, her lips felt tingly and warm compared to the crisp, cold wind blowing against them.

She glanced around to notice Bow and the rest of their families had gone back inside, probably to give the two some privacy, leaving her alone with Adora Ryder yet again.

"So are you still mad at me?" Glimmer asked slowly with a nervous grin. Adora laughed and chased her lips for a longer, gentler kiss than before.

"Oh, I'm *furious*." She replied with a big smile. "But you can start to make it up to me by buying me a milkshake at the diner this Friday."

Glimmer smiled back widely (if she were a cartoon character, she'd *definitely* have heart-shaped eyes or a wagging tail) before allowing Adora to kiss her again and again, warming her up despite the frigid weather around them.

If Adora was like *that* when she was angry, then Glimmer wouldn't mind working towards her forgiveness one bit.

Chapter End Notes

Back from a quite long hiatus to drop this chapter!
Working on some more for this after a while of being unable to put pencil to paper for it, but I can't make any promises for when the next chapter will be out.
Thanks to anyone who stuck around this long, I love you!

# Chapter Twelve

Chapter Notes

> I've been trying to write this chapter for way too long and it just wouldn't turn out right, so I've decided to just turn it into a filler chapter of sorts. Sorry if you were looking forward to a really good or long update, maybe next time!

Six days and ten hours later and Glimmer was back at school once again, despite her whines and pleas to take the rest of the year off. (She'd tried everything! Virtual school, having Adora send her homework she'd miss, *anything* that would mean not being in the same building as Catra for nine hours a day, five days a week.)

At least she had Adora by her side, which helped keep Glimmer calm when she started to feel stressed or anxious. Adora always seemed to know just how to cheer her up, no matter how temporary the comfort could be.

A hand in hers, an arm around her shoulders, kisses pressed to her cheeks and forehead. Adora was always affectionate with her friends, Glimmer had always known this and always secretly loved it, but it felt like being Adora's *girlfriend* made the blonde even more eager to touch her.

Glimmer loved every moment of it.

Though, more often than not those lovely distractions were short lived, especially during lunch when Adora ate with her teammates to go over drills and the classes they didn't share together. Especially during classes shared with Catra.

Though the brunette never actively approached her, Glimmer could always feel Catra looking at her whenever she could, made even more obvious when Adora was there to send an obvious glare her way in response until Glimmer knew she had to have looked away.

She almost felt sorry for the other girl, catching glimpses of her sad expression when their eyes occasionally met or watching the way she could hardly crack a smile with her friends during lunch, until the ever-lingering pain she'd caused took over and trampled over whatever pity she could have felt for her former contract mate.

~

Scorpia was standing beside Glimmer's locker when she finally pushed through the crowd of students eager to get home or to their clubs, a nervous but friendly grin on her face as she offered an energetic wave with one hand.

(Glimmer shoved aside the hurt she felt instinctually, scolding herself for only thinking of Scorpia as Catra's friend. Scorpia was her friend, too. She was perfectly allowed to talk to Scorpia, because they were friends.)

Walking over with a smile of her own, Glimmer held up a hand to wave Adora goodbye as she saw the girl rushing to get to practice on time from the other end of the building. "Hey , Scorpia. What's up?" She asked, tilting her head up to look at the taller girl.

Scorpia shifted on her feet and chuckled, a habit she'd come to recognise as the girl feeling anxious. "Hey , Glimmer. Just uh, just stopped by to give you a late gift. Since I didn't really see you all break." She said, slowly bringing two boxes out from behind her back. One was a small cardboard box kept shut with some crab printed duct tape, the other a shoebox tied closed with a thick maroon ribbon.

Glimmer carefully took the offered boxes with a smile, glancing down at them before smiling up at her friend. "Thanks, Scorpia! I'll open them when I get home. And I actually got you and Entrapta gifts, too! I'll bring them with me tomorrow."

"Oh, that's nice of you. I wasn't really expecting anything in return." Scorpia giggled.

"Of course! We're friends, after all." Glimmer shrugged, opening her locker to pull her bag out so she could attempt to tuck her presents inside.

"Uh, what are those?" Scorpia asked over her shoulder as Glimmer struggled between shoving the boxes inside and trying not to drop them, gesturing a hand towards the bottom of the girl's locker.

Glimmer grimaced as she glanced down, instantly recognising the folded paper slips littering the bottom of her locker as she eyed them with anger. It felt like every time she tried to have a nice moment without thinking about Catra, the girl found a way to worm into her mind one way or another.

"Nothing."She snapped, instantly feeling bad for the harshness in her voice. "Sorry , I- They're from Catra."She corrected herself with a sigh, frowning as she gave up on putting her boxes in her backpack as she slung the still-open bag onto her shoulder and moved the gifts to one hand so she could slam the metal door shut so hard it rattled and echoed inside.

Scorpia looked conflicted, eyes glancing between Glimmer and the floor a few times with her lips pressed tightly. "She- She still talks about you, like, all the time."She finally said, her voice barely audible as she looked anywhere but at the shorter girl in front of her.

Glimmer tensed, breath stilling in her lungs as she suddenly felt the hot pinch of approaching tears from her nose and eyes, forcing a deep breath to control herself. "I'm dating Adora."She said, unsure how to respond any other way at the moment.

Scorpia smiled sadly and nodded. "I know , you two are cute together. I'm happy for you."She said, reaching out to give Glimmer's upper arm a supportive squeeze that made the girl wince slightly at the former jock's immense strength.

Glimmer smiled back and turned to leave, wanting to catch some of Adora's practice before they'd take the club bus home together.

She waited until she was alone on the bleachers, sitting higher than usual and further out of anyone's line of sight while the girls ran around in their jackets to protect themselves from the cold, and finally let the tears that had been building up behind her eyes fall.

~

Adora Ryder was an *amazing* kisser, Glimmer was sure she'd think that for the rest of her life.

The two sat on Glimmer's bed, getting distracted for the third time that hour from studying for an upcoming test they had at the end of the week. They finally broke apart in a fit of happy giggles after a few minutes, hands casually resting on arms and knees and cheeks or wherever they had managed to move in their efforts to lean into the kiss even more.

"Okay , okay. Back to the books."Adora said with a huf fed laugh, cheeks dusted pink from the kiss and embarrassment as Glimmer stared at her yet again like she was the most beautiful girl alive.

Glimmer whined and let her head fall back, staring up at her ceiling while Adora flicked her elbow. "We've been here *forever*, can we *please* do something else?" She begged.

"We *keep* doing 'something else', unless you consider *me* to count as studying." Adora flirted, chuckling when Glimmer's cheeks lit up with blush.

"I don't know, you *are* pretty much a walking textbook." Glimmer teased back, sticking her tongue out childishly.

"Why you little-!" Adora scoffed, only pretending to be offended (Glimmer could tell, Adora was *still* a terrible actor, even after all this time) before lunging for the other girl as Glimmer squealed and tried in vain to escape before she felt fingers digging into her sides.

"Ador- Dor- Adora! Stop!" She begged between fits of laughter, struggling and squirming as the other girl tickled her relentlessly.

"Hmm," the blonde drawled, seemingly thinking it over much to Glimmer's torture. "Fine." She agreed, suddenly stopping altogether as Glimmer took a gulp of air and tried to calm herself after laughing so hard.

"You're evil." She finally said, glaring playfully at her girlfriend.

"Evil? No way, I'm at *least* chaotic good." Adora said with a goofy grin that Glimmer couldn't resist kissing off of her.

"I'm gonna get something to drink, nerd. Want anything?" She asked, standing from the bed and stretching after hunching over a textbook for the worse part (the "better" part being getting to kiss Adora, of course) of an hour.

"Just water, thanks." Adora agreed, already back to mumbling her notes before the other even left the room.

Glimmer rolled her eyes fondly from the hall, unable to fight the smile tugging at her lips as she practically skipped down the stairs and into the kitchen for some water and iced tea.

"Someone looks smitten." Her mother teased without even looking up from the screen in front of her, smirking as she typed out some lawyer talk for one of her colleagues.

"Mom." Glimmer said warningly as her mom just chuckled in response, glancing her way as the teen nudged the fridge shut with her foot.

"What, am I not allowed to tease my daughter about her pretty girlfriend?" The older woman said, raising a brow knowingly as Glimmer flushed and quickly turned to leave the room.

"Just don't do anything you wouldn't want to be caught doing, Glimmer. I know how to pick locks, remember?" Her mother called as she approached the stairs.

"*Thanks*, mom!" Glimmer said through grit teeth, feeling ready to die of shame whenever the universe would be kind enough to smite her down (or something equally dramatic and tragic).

She made it back to her room and sighed in relief that her mother's onslaught of teasing was over, opening the door with a smile as she set the glasses down on her dresser to shut *and lock* her door.

"Hey, Glim?" Adora asked from the other side of the room.

"Yeah?" She called back, cups already in hand again to offer to the blonde.

"What is this?" Her girlfriend asked, brows furrowed as she held up a sheet of paper Glimmer instantly recognised with a pang of hurt, feeling like she was going to be sick at the sight.

There, in Adora's hand, was the contract she and Catra had signed.

# Chapter Thirteen

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for the long break, but I've written a few chapters that I'll release periodically while working on the end of this story! Nearly there now (:

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer pushed through an explanation of everything, leaving nothing out as she put it in words for the first time. The letters, the arrangement, the contract, the movie nights she and Catra shared, the few (incredibly embarrassing and counterproductive and not worth mentioning, thank you) driving lessons she'd had with her "ex" (which definitely proved to both of them that Glimmer would *not* be the driver in the "relationship"), the almost kisses, the *actual* kisses, shared lunches and after school drives and weekends spent at Catra's or Scorpia's or her own house, absolutely everything.

Adora listened with full attention, piece of paper still in her hand that Glimmer's eyes kept flickering back to.

"I..." Adora said once Glimmer had finally gone quiet and finished her long-winded rambling. "That's...something."

Glimmer stayed silent, one foot lifting the curled edge of a fuzzy blue rug on the floor nervously.

"Like, I think by now I'm not *mad* at any of this, but," Adora shook her head. "I just didn't realise how *much* there was, I guess."

She looked up, then, meeting Glimmer's gaze. "Are you okay?" She asked, catching Glimmer off-guard.

"Am- Are you asking *me* if I'm okay?" Glimmer stuttered, confused.

Adora nodded and shifted slightly where she sat on the bed. "Yeah, I guess I am." She shrugged.

Glimmer let the question sink in for a second, feeling her throat tighten as she thought back on all the times she wished she and Catra were real, and all the times after where she wished it never was. All the times they'd laugh and joke together and make fun of each other's movies good-naturedly, or sang along to the radio terribly in the car, or she'd catch Catra sneaking one of her "notes" into her pocket or locker, or the times they'd just talk. Talk for hours, through texts or through calls or in person, just talking about the most mundane things.

She didn't even realise she'd started crying until Adora was holding a tissue beneath her eye, a worried look on her face, one hand cradling her cheek.

"I'll take that as a 'no', then." Adora attempted to joke, earning a weak smile and nod from the shorter girl before Glimmer hiccuped

and her tears started flowing harder.

---

Talking to Adora had taken a huge weight off of Glimmer's shoulders, *and* her heart. After that, seeing Catra around school wasn't so painful.

It still *hurt*, but she'd take the win where she could. She'd rather be able to look at Catra and feel like her lungs were being crushed, than be too heartbroken to look at her at all.

Baby steps.

She started to feel somewhat normal around Scorpia and her other friends again, too, though she knew there was an unspoken truce from everyone to avoid bringing up Catra in conversation or invite her along when Glimmer was around. It was awkward, but they all managed just fine.

The best part about telling Adora, though, was that it brought them closer together. Now that everything was out in the open, they weren't treading eggshells around each other anymore. The trust that had been there in their friendship was back in their relationship.

She could kiss Adora without feeling guilty, without feeling like it could all disappear at any moment.

"I'll see you after class." Adora said with a smile, kissing Glimmer against her locker for a bit longer than she should have if she wanted to make it across the building in time to avoid being late.

"Bye." Glimmer giggled, waving as Adora jogged away, feeling bubbly and giddy with joy and love.

She jumped as she heard a locker slam down the hall, turning around to see Catra at the end of the hall, looking *foul*. Her hair was messy (not in a cute way), her eyes had dark rings beneath them, and they looked puffy, like she'd been crying.

And she had just seen her practically making out with Adora. Great.

"Hey." Glimmer said, throat suddenly dry.

Catra blinked at her for a moment, as if she didn't think Glimmer was really talking to her. "Hi."

An uncomfortably awkward silence settled between them, the air thick and suffocating with unspoken words.

"How is she?" Catra asked, clearing her throat when her voice came out scratchy. "How are- How are you?"

"Good." Glimmer answered maybe a bit too quick. "We're good." She added with a nod, bobbing her head up and down in a way that probably looked really funny from another person's perspective.

Catra hummed and crossed her arms before fidgeting and sticking them in the pockets of her jeans instead. "That's good, that's good."

More silence.

The bell sounded overhead, interrupting their almost-conversation as Glimmer breathed a silent sigh of relief.

"See you around?" Glimmer waved stiffly, the statement sounding more like a question when it left her half smiling lips.

Catra nodded and lifted a corner of her lips in an attempted smile. "See you around, Sparkles." She said back before walking as fast as humanly possible down the hall and around a corner before Glimmer heard her feet pounding against the ground in a run.

---

"I talked to Catra today ."Glimmer said as she sat in Adora's room, her back leaning against the side of her girlfriend's bed while the blonde was lying on her stomach playing with pink hair.

Fingers stilled on her head and Glimmer glanced up to see Adora snapping herself out of a moment of surprise.

"What did she say?"Adora asked, trying way too hard to sound casual. (Terrible acting skills at work.)

Adora and Catra had started talking again recently, managing to work through *enough* of their problems to have a conversation without it ending in yelling or storming off again, at least. But this was the first time Glimmer and Catra had spoken to each other in weeks, so she could understand Adora's curiosity.

Glimmer shrugged. "She just asked how we were doing. I said we were good."She answered.

"Is that all?"Adora asked, brows furrowed.

"Yeah, pretty much."

Adora bit the inside of her cheek before resuming her combs through Glimmer's hair. "Okay ."She hummed.

"Okay?"Glimmer raised a brow .

"Okay ."Adora confirmed.

Chapter End Notes

This is just a sort of filler chapter , next update will be longer , I promise!

# Chapter Fourteen

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Adora, can I open my eyes yet?" Glimmer asked with a smile as Adora led her around by the hand. She'd been asked to "close her eyes and trust her girlfriend, please", so that's exactly what she was doing. Fighting the urge to peek knowing Adora was probably watching for her to do just that, if the amount of stumbles and accidental bumps were any indicators.

"Not yet. Almost, I promise." Adora said, smiling audibly as she spoke. Judging by how tight her girlfriend had been holding her hand, Adora was really excited by whatever she was leading her to.

This continued for a few more steps until Adora finally told Glimmer to open her eyes, revealing the lacrosse field, still damp from raining earlier in the day.

"Adora, if you're going to ask me to run drills with you because there's no practice this week, you obviously overestimate my stamina and endurance." Glimmer joked.

Adora rolled her eyes and smiled. "This is only *part* of what I wanted to show you. Just wait here, I promise it's gonna be good." She said, kissing her cheek before running off towards the bleachers.

Just as Glimmer turned around to see what the other girl was doing, she heard music gradually getting louder.

Adora stood at the top of the bleachers, which- now that Glimmer was actually looking at them- seemed suspiciously dry for how hard it rained that morning, holding a-

"Why do you have a microphone?" Glimmer tried to shout, but Adora just grinned and gave her a thumbs up as she finally recognised the song that was playing.

"Oh my god. Are you really gonna *Things Id About You* me right now?" Glimmer shouted, though it was drowned out as Adora burst into song.

"*I love you baby, and if it's quite alright, I need you baby, too on the lonely nights*!" Adora sang into the mic, running and dancing along the bleacher stands until the end of the second verse, where at that point Sea Hawk appeared from behind the bleachers to take the microphone from Adora's hands and give her what was apparently the source of the music.

A giant, rectangular boom box, straight out of the 1980s.

"Oh my *god*." Glimmer said when the song seamlessly transitioned into the one from *Anything…* . "What are you even doing?" She shouted again.

Adora grinned and shouted back, but her voice couldn't carry over the boombox above her head. Sea Hawk helpfully stumbled up the steps two at a time and held the mic to her lips. "Glimmer Moonbright, will you go to the Valentine's Dance with me?" She asked.

Glimmer laughed, a mixture of joy and disbelief, as she nodded and took off in a run towards the bleachers.

Adora set down the device just in time to catch Glimmer in a hug, grinning down at her. "Was that a good 'grand gesture'?" She asked once Sea Hawk had turned off the boombox and started to carry it away to give them some space.

"It was good, but it didn't abide by cheesy romcom rules, so I'll have to deduct points. 8/10." Glimmer giggled and smiled back, arms still slung around her girlfriend's neck.

"What? Come on, I did two in one!" Adora scoffed, pinching her side playfully as she joined Glimmer's giggling.

"Yes, but everyone *knows* the 'grand gesture' comes after the 'big fight'. It's simple math." Glimmer said, shaking her head in fake

disappointment like this was something everyone should know.

"Okay , let's argue over something and I'll try again. I want those full points."Adora joked back.

"Kiss me and I'll reconsider my scoring."Glimmer challenged, and Adora eagerly accepted the offer, lifting Glimmer onto a higher step so they were standing level for a kiss.

"Hmm, fine. Full marks."Glimmer said after pretending to think it over.

"Yes!"Adora said, pumping her fist in the air like in *The Breakfast Club* as Glimmer burst into laughter so hard there were tears in her eyes.

~

Glimmer whined as her mom snapped yet another picture once she stepped out of the dressing room, wearing the sixth dress they'd found that didn't immediately make Glimmer roll her eyes to look at like most of the store's selection.

"Do you have to do that *every* time?"Glimmer asked with a pout while her mother chuckled and glanced at her phone screen with that

universally known mom smile that said "my baby is all grown up and I'm so proud I could cry, but we're in public so I'll save it for later."

"Hush, I'm having a *mom*-ent." Angella said and Glimmer groaned at the extremely rare and unwelcomed dad-joke she'd learned, though from one of the Fletchers or her own dad Glimmer wasn't sure. (Important note, never have three dads with terrible humor if given the choice.)

Glimmer sighed as she looked herself over in the full length mirror, ignoring her mother muttering about how she needed to tell her father about her new joke." The dress looked okay, but Glimmer wanted *magical*. Like, *Pretty in Pink* magical.

She felt her phone buzz from the pocket of her jacket, slung over a nearby chair. She pulled it out to see that Adora had texted her about finding the perfect thing for the dance. When Glimmer clicked on the picture, her heart skipped a beat. Adora looked *so good* in her dress, arm muscles on full display in a sleeveless white dress with gold hems that made her eyes shine.

She sent back a few hearts and blushing faces and set her phone down, cheeks pink and heart beating faster knowing she'd see Adora wearing that dress in person soon. She looked so perfect, so beautiful.

Glimmer really stepped up her dress-finding game after that, combing through the entire store for a dress that wouldn't make her

look totally lame beside Adora. She wanted to look like she *belonged* at Adora's side, so if Adora was going to show up to the dance looking like an actual *goddess*, she needed to look *really* good to match.

When she finally found it- her own *Pretty in Pink* dress- Glimmer almost couldn't believe it was really there when she looked in the mirror. It was a thin, stretchy, mid-thigh sky blue dress that clung to her body, layered up with lavender and pink tulle. There was a pink ribbon that tied around her waist to seperate the skirt covered in shimmering sequins. The whole dress looked poofy and sparkly and straight out of an 80s movie prom scene.

"That looks," her mother paused, "unique."

"This is the one." Glimmer spun around, eyes wide and pleading with her best "mommy's favorite little girl" look.

"Put that quivering lip away, it's *your* decision, after all. If you want this one, we'll get this one." Angella chuckled.

"Thank you thank you thank you!" Glimmer squealed and hugged her mother tight.

This dance was gonna be amazing.

~

"My baby girl, all grown up!" Micah mimed at wiping a tear away .

"Ø ."Glimmer said warningly as she stood beside Adora for some mandatory-parent-pictures, with her mother, Mara, and Lance all taking pictures.

"Bow's gonna cry when he sees these."Lance said thoughtfully as he looked through the ones he'd taken while Angella and Mara muttered to each other about angles and how adorable their daughters were. (Embarrassing. So embarrassing.)

"Okay , bye parents, we're going!" Glimmer called, looping her arm through Adora's and heading for the door.

"Be safe!" Micah called.

"Back by midnight!" Mara reminded.

"Hands above the hips, both of you!" George teased.

Glimmer slammed the door shut after them.

~

Riding the bus had been a bit awkward, being pretty much the only non-fifteen-or-eighty year olds to do so, but Glimmer was too nervous and excited to care. She was going to the dance with Adora Ryder, and it was going to be the most incredible night of her life (until something *even better* happened, probably).

They arrived at the school with a few minutes to spare before the doors would open for the dance, which Adora was adorably relieved about. She hated being late to things, so she almost always arrived early just in case. They strolled hand-in-hand into the gymnasium, where a few members of the school band were setting up to provide music for the dance and teachers were finishing preparing the refreshments table hurriedly- obviously trying to get out safely before getting stuck with chaperone duty for a bunch of teenagers.

"Want something to drink?" Adora asked with a smile, nodding over to where a teacher was hastily setting stacks of paper cups onto a long table beside a punch bowl and juice dispenser full of lemonade.

"Sure." Glimmer smiled, letting Adora lead her over and taking the offered cup of lemonade.

They talked for a few minutes before watching cat videos on Adora's phone while waiting for the other students to arrive so the dance

would actually begin, laughing and cooing at the different cats on screen.

When the lights finally dimmed and the band started up an actual song (as opposed to the sound of tuning instruments into microphones they'd had to endure until then), Adora grinned and set her cup down on the table.

"May I have this dance?" She asked, even though it was something upbeat meant to bounce and move around to.

"Of course." Glimmer smiled, and let herself be dragged onto the dance floor excitedly.

She held both of Adora's hands as they moved together with the other people in the crowd, twirling each other and laughing as they made up silly dance moves that would probably be super embarrassing if everyone else wasn't doing something similar. Besides, Glimmer didn't care if it was embarrassing, because it made Adora laugh.

Eventually the music quieted down and a slow song began to play, with Glimmer resting her head against Adora's shoulder (Okay, maybe it was her upper arm. It wasn't her fault Adora decided to wear heels while Glimmer was wearing flats) as they swayed together to the beat.

Nearly three slow songs (and a few kisses) later, Glimmer excused herself to get another lemonade. She made her way towards the refreshments but froze before she could make it there, hearing a voice she knew too well nearby. She glanced over to the wall behind the table, where Catra was talking to Scorpia (who had the best smoky eye Glimmer had ever seen that matched her maroon dress perfectly, but she could ask for makeup tips another time preferably when Catra wasn't literally right there).

As much as her chest ached to notice, Catra looked gorgeous. Hair slicked back and curls wild, wearing a burgundy suit left intentionally open to show a wine red blouse and a maroon tie left undone around her neck.

It didn't seem like Catra had noticed her yet, but Scorpia clearly had, since the taller girl looked right at her before quickly returning to her conversation with Catra before the other girl could notice.

The universe was not so kind to Glimmer.

Catra turned slightly, freezing up when her eyes locked on Glimmer. She watched Catra's eyes roam over her, taking in her dress like how she'd taken in Catra's suit moments ago. She ran a hand through her hair, making it somehow look even more perfect.

Distantly, Glimmer could hear Adora calling out to her, probably trying to find her in the crowd when she didn't return. She couldn't move, couldn't breathe.

She moved one foot, then another, forcing herself over to the table.

If the universe wanted her to talk to Catra so badly, she'd do it. No more putting it off.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for another cliffhanger but this chapter was just getting too long-

Also shout out to 80s romcoms (yes I know 10 Things isn't an 80s movie but you get it) for being the best movie genre ever invented and no I am not biased

# Chapter Fifteen

Glimmer stood at the refreshments table, pouring herself some lemonade when Catra finally walked over to her, standing a bit further away in front of a large tray of red and pink heart shaped treats to fit the theme.

She watched Catra idly pick one up and take a bite, breaking the heart in half.

Talk about irony.

"Y ou look, um, really nice."Catra said after swallowing, still looking down at the half heart in her hand instead of Glimmer.

"Thanks. So do you."Glimmer said back and took a sip.

Why was there always uncomfortable pauses whenever they talked to each other?

Glimmer sighed and set down her cup. "Okay , this keeps being weird. Can we just, talk to each other like real people?"She asked.

Catra sighed and smiled slightly. "I'm so glad it's not just me."She chuckled. "Yeah, we can do that."She answered with a nod.

"Good."Glimmer nodded back, smiling back faintly .

~

Glimmer wasn't sure how long she spent talking to Catra, but it couldn't have been more than ten minutes before Adora walked over and noticed the two of them talking. She looked at Catra first, then sent a questioning look to her girlfriend, a silent "are you alright"?

Glimmer smiled back softly to show everything was okay, and Adora walked over, taking her hand at their sides as she grabbed herself some fruit punch and let them carry on with their conversation while she stood nearby like a loyal guard dog.

Two cups of punch later, Adora kissed Glimmer's cheek and said she was going to the bathroom for a minute, though Glimmer was pretty sure she just felt awkward standing there with a cup in her hand and wanted to talk to one of her teammates who'd shown up to the dance too.

Glimmer smiled and kissed her cheek back before she left, feeling a little embarrassed with Catra watching.

"So, you and Adora."Catra said, not like a question, but like she was just saying a fact. "Uh, I really am happy for you guys."She said, surprising Glimmer quite a bit. "I know it probably doesn't seem like it, especially with how I kind of yelled at you on Christmas."She chuckled awkwardly. "But Adora's really sweet when she wants to be, and puppy-dog loyal, and super protective, so I'm glad you have her. And you're- Well, I mean- You're you, so she's all set, too."

Glimmer pushed down the flutter in her chest, dousing the butterflies with pest spray. "Thanks, Catra."She said, instead of anything she actually wanted to say just then.

Catra smiled softly and finished off her second heart of the conversation. "No problem."She paused for a beat, smile wavering before returning a bit more strained than before. "I'm sorry, by the way."She coughed into her hand. "For uh, Christmas. And, y'know, what happened with me and Adora on the ski trip."

Glimmer felt a lump form in her throat but swallowed it down and shook her head. "Apology accepted."She said, trying to sound more mature than she felt in that moment. "I'm sorry, too."

Catra blinked and furrowed her brows. "For what?"She wondered.

Glimmer shrugged and looked down at the yellow liquid in her cup. "For avoiding you, mostly. But I also kind of yelled at you on Christmas, so that too. And for being too lame to give you a present in person."She elaborated, remembering how anxious she felt

handing Catra's present to Scorpia when giving the girl her and Entrapta's presents, hoping and silently pleading that Scorpia wouldn't question or mention the third box in her arms.

Catra smiled slightly and reached into her suit jacket's pocket, pulling out the sunglasses she'd gotten Catra for Christmas along with some fingerless leather gloves she'd seen her eyeing at the mall. She'd never seen her wear either, so it surprised Glimmer to see the glasses being carried with her, even without being worn.

"I feel like some bad-boy character in one of your movies when I wear the gloves with them, so I normally just wear one or the other ." Catra explained.

Glimmer found herself giggling, and let a natural smile slip onto her lips. "That was kind of the point. You could totally pull it off and you know it."

Catra smirked and slid the glasses on, peeking over the top of them like the poster for *Ferris Bueller*. Glimmer chuckled and Catra joined in. "You got me addicted to those awful things, I hope you know." Catra accused.

"Good. I've cultured you at last." Glimmer joked.

"I don't want to hear that from you when *I* had to show you the *real* classics." Catra bantered back.

"I seriously doubt anything you've ever recommended to me could be considered *classic*," Glimmer teased.

Catra scoffed and nudged her shoulder lightly. Glimmer set her cup down and nudged her back. They laughed and shared a small smile and for the first time in a while, it felt like things *might* have been normal between them.

~

Adora and Glimmer sat in the back seat of Catra's car after the dance, Scorpia in the front seat adjusting the radio trying to find a station playing something good.

The suggestion had seemed a bit strange at first, but Adora said she didn't mind and Glimmer agreed, so they'd taken Catra up on her offer to drive them home, though none of them had said more than a few words the entire time.

Glimmer couldn't stop discreetly looking at Catra through the side mirror, being seated just behind her. Her hand was in Adora's, which was probably the only reason she hadn't exploded from how quiet the car was other than the crackling static coming from the stereo. (No, she wasn't being dramatic at all.)

At least she'd gotten one last slow dance with Adora before they left. She could tell Catra wanted to leave before they started up again, but she let them stay until she and Adora finished, which Glimmer was grateful for, even if it felt a bit strange knowing Catra was standing in the hall outside while she was dancing with Adora.

She danced with Catra, too, oddly enough. Not to a slow song or anything, but it still wasn't something she'd expected to be doing when she first entered the dance. They danced to an upbeat song together with Adora and Scorpia and one of Adora's friends from the team, the kind of music you're probably meant to use your arms a lot for. Their group did, at least.

Catra pulled to a stop in front of Glimmer's house and glanced at both her and Adora from the rearview mirror. She followed Adora out and waved goodnight to Scorpia and Catra, watching Catra smile tightly before pulling away and down the street.

She kissed Adora's cheek after being walked to her door, waiting until her girlfriend was across the street at her own door before walking inside, walking straight past her parents trying to ask about her night. She was exhausted from dancing and grown up conversations, and ready to sleep.

As she headed up the stairs, she pretended not to hear her dad asking her mom, "Wasn't that Catra's car?"

# Chapter Sixteen

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With the end of February came more classwork and homework than Glimmer thought should be legal. It was her last year of school, which meant teachers were really cracking down on everyone to decide what they wanted to do with their lives after summer was over.

She already knew Adora was set with a scholarship for a school nearby, and Scorpia was going to study to be a physical therapist at some school across the country, coincidentally to a school near Bow's. Maybe they'd be friends too, they seemed like they could be. (Glimmer admittedly didn't know what she wanted to be, but she still did her best to study so she'd be able to graduate with everyone else at the end of the school year.)

Catra was going to an art school a few towns over, only an hour away. (Not that she looked it up or anything. That would be stalker-ish and weird to do to a kind-of-exObviously .)

Anyway.

With school being more demanding, and Adora having more intense team practices (she tended to push herself when she was nervous, which Glimmer guessed was about the end-of-year game), Glimmer

was beyond relieved that she and Catra made up because riding a bus full of shouting and laughing high-schoolers after a stressful school day was *not* good for her spotless criminal record and kept her from committing murder. (Okay, maybe she was overreacting, but it was still very unpleasant and overwhelming.)

Besides, she missed riding with Catra and talking on the way home from school. In a totally normal, friendship kind of way.

They'd been talking more in the halls, too. Catra and Adora, too. It felt like the three of them were starting to become friends, and things might actually end on a good note before their high school lives ended.

"Alright, everyone. Let's get those lockers cleaned out."A teacher said, poorly trying to motivate everyone. Apparently there had been a rumor that some of the kids in Glimmer's year were going to rig all of the lockers with glitter bombs, so to avoid the school being made to pay for cleaning bills or repairs on things like phones or laptops, they'd decided to punish everyone by making them clean their lockers so nothing could risk being glittered.

Thanks so much, whoever started that rumor. Or whoever was actually planning on putting glitter bombs in people's lockers. Now everyone had to waste study hall making their lockers spotless just for them to potentially be filled with sparkly sand (or whatever glitter was actually made of. Glimmer still had no idea).

She glanced down at the bottom of her locker at the folded slips of paper, taking a deep breath before lifting them all in heaps from the locker floor to a small beat up shoebox the school provided her with for the cleanup process. She closed it up and stuffed it into her backpack, even though it would be hard to fit everything else in now.

Because no, she couldn't just dump the fake notes into the bottom of her bag, that would crumple them. Not that *that* was the point, the *point* was that her bag would get cluttered and she'd never find anything if she did that. That's why. Whatever.

She (mostly) ignored the shoebox the rest of the day, and managed to put it away in her room once she got home. (She totally didn't spend ten minutes deciding where it could go that would gather the least amount of dust or anything.)

~

"Where are you taking me?" Adora asked, standing on the back of her girlfriend's bike, arms wrapped snugly around her waist, while Glimmer pedaled along a faded trail. It was a rare day where Glimmer managed to finish her schoolwork relatively quickly and Adora didn't have practice, which made for the perfect conditions for a date.

"You'll see." Glimmer glanced back with a smile before focusing again on riding. "We're almost there now."

She eventually slowed to a stop beside a large grass field, having veered from the trail to make the final turn, obscured by the foliage of the forest they'd been riding through.

"We're here." She said, swiveling off and offering Adora her hand to get down even though all she had to do was take a step.

"And 'here' is?" Adora wondered, visibly confused.

Glimmer giggled. "Hang on." She said, tugging the blonde by the hand through the field of grass so tall it reached their shins. She led Adora further into the field until she could see it, a sloped cliffside covered in small white flowers just starting to bloom.

She sat down and let her legs dangle over the edge, not bothered by the drop since it wasn't dangerously high or steep. Glimmer smiled and patted the ground beside her, watching Adora as she grinned and sat down next to her, one knee hugged to her chest while the other dangled and knocked gently against Glimmer's.

"This is so cool." Adora said quietly, despite the fact that they were the only people around.

"Thought you'd like it. I found this place a few years ago while I was out biking with Bow and his dads. It's my quiet spot." Glimmer said, leaning back on her hands.

Adora looked at her and chuckled. "I thought that diner near our houses was your quiet spot."She said.

"Nah, that's my hungry spot. Their food is dangerously good. Dangerous because I'll probably have a heart attack at some point from eating it so often."Glimmer giggled and Adora joined in, the sound making her smile wider.

"Why haven't I been here before?"Adora wondered.

Glimmer shrugged. "I don't know , it just kind of felt like my thing, and I wanted it to be *just* mine. But then I thought, maybe it would be nice to share it with someone. So I brought you."She bumped her foot into Adora's with a smile.

She looked up at the sky, watching the clouds move for a second. "I haven't been here since Bow left."She admitted.

"Why not?"

"I found this place with him, it felt weird going when I knew he wouldn't be around to sneak up on me or tell me when it was time to go home for the day. I knew I'd miss it too much, and then I'd miss him, and then I'd get all sad and stuff."

Adora looked at her for a few moments before leaning in to kiss her. Not that Glimmer minded, of course, kissing her back with a smile.

"I'm glad you brought me here. Maybe the three of us can come here when Bow comes back for the summer, before me and you have to join him and become university people."Adora suggested.

"Ugh, do *not* remind me that I'll have to do *more* school after I finish *this* school."Glimmer groaned, though she couldn't help smiling at the idea of Adora and Bow sitting with her on a hot summer day, just the three of them. Just like when they were kids. Before Glimmer realised Adora considered her a friend, back when she thought Adora was just Bow's super cute friend who hung out with Glimmer too because they were neighbors and that's what super cute neighbors do when they're children.

Things were different now, obviously. If Adora's barrage of ticklish kisses across Glimmer's face were anything to go off of.

"You're amazing."Glimmer sighed happily after the twentieth or so kiss.

"I know."Adora smirked in the dorkiest way possible and kissed her again.

Yup, her life was actually perfect right now.

~

Okay, maybe sitting in a diner booth across from their ex-girlfriend was a bit weird, but neither Adora nor Glimmer would be the type to comment on that. They'd agreed to meet Catra after school when the brunette had texted Adora during practice, somehow guessing that Glimmer was with her.

"So, not that I hate free food, but why did you invite us out?" Adora finally asked after they'd all sat quietly until their food and drinks arrived.

Catra smiled slightly and reached beside her in the seat for her backpack, moving it slightly to reveal two wrapped lumps sitting beneath it. "Well, I figured that it's better late than never, so I thought we could have a little birthday thing for the two of you. You know, 'two birds with one stone' or whatever." She said with a shrug, though Glimmer could tell she was nervous.

Adora smiled and chuckled. "Aww, you *remembered*? Sap." She joked as Catra scoffed and rolled her eyes.

"Want your gift or not, dork?" Catra said, crossing her arms as if there was even a *chance* she'd withhold Adora's present from her.

"I want it." Adora said quietly with a pout, looking like a sulking child being told to behave.

Glimmer smiled and gave her hand a squeeze under the table, earning one back.

"Alright, then." Catra chuckled and passed the bigger lump of wrapping paper over. Whatever it was was hidden by red and gold shiny paper that Adora tore into greedily.

"Catra, you did not." Adora said in disbelief, eyeing the jacket inside. It was one of those team jackets Glimmer had seen in countless high school movies, the kind with the puffy sleeves and names printed across the back. She could make out some of the letters for *Archer* along the back, and a big red 'A' on the front.

"I did." Catra shrugged with a smirk like it was no big deal.

"How did you even *afford* this? The good ones are always crazy expensive!" Adora said, rubbing her thumbs against the material of some of the letters like she couldn't believe she was actually holding it.

"I know , which is super dumb, so I made my own for a third of the price." Catra explained, and Adora's head snapped back up to look

at her with wide eyes.

"You *made* me this?" She asked, her voice soft but still full of shock.

Catra flushed when Glimmer joined Adora in looking at her, ducking her head to the side as she tried to hide it with her hair. "Yeah, I made it. I DIYd. I can work a sewing machine, you know. Not that hard." She said, trying to play it off like it wasn't a big deal but it seemed like Adora would absolutely not let it go undervalued.

"Catra, I am literally never going to take this off. I'll shower in the thing, it's my new favorite article of clothing. Thank you." Adora said very seriously, causing Glimmer to giggle at her excitement. She couldn't help it, it was contagious.

"Yeah, yeah. You're welcome. Glimmer's turn." Catra said, failing to hide how eager she was to move on as she tried in vain to contain her blush.

Glimmer held out her hands and made grabbing motions like an impatient child as the other girls chuckled at her behavior. It wasn't her fault Adora's present had given her high expectations.

Catra handed over a much smaller and somehow lumpier gift, covered in sparkly purple paper that left glittery residue on Catra's hand and Glimmer's when she took it. She ripped it off into her lap

and stared at her gift in awe. It was a small glazed statue, painted to near-perfection, of Glimmer, Scorpia, and Mermista.

Glimmer remembered the day this was from, one of the rare days where Mermista ate lunch with everyone else and had sat at Glimmer's side, with Scorpia flanked on the other side of her. She remembered the way Scorpia had playfully lifted Glimmer into her arms, just to prove she could, and Mermista had stood with her arms crossed beside them, smirking at Glimmer's attempts to squirm away. Catra had taken some pictures, and Glimmer scolded her not to post them anywhere or print them out. Apparently, this was her alternative to that.

Glimmer shook out of the memory as she gently ran her finger against the smooth, fragile side of her statued head, where the pink hair had been freckled with white spots like sparkles. Of course.

"Do you like it?" Catra asked, rubbing her neck when Glimmer said nothing.

Glimmer nodded instantly, clutching her gift to her chest like Adora had as she looked the brunette in her heterochromic eyes. "I love it." She answered in a whisper.

Catra's eyes flickered between the couple across from her and she smiled tensely before grabbing her bag and sliding out from the booth, taking her chicken sandwich with her. Adora stood up instantly, hands clutching her jacket visibly tight.

"You're going already?" Adora asked softly, sounding confused.

Catra hid her face. "Uh, yeah. You two enjoy your gifts. And your food. I've- I've got some homework to do, so I'm gonna head out." She said, glancing over her shoulder to wave before walking quickly out of the diner with a chime of the overhead bell.

Adora sat back down, staring at her fruit salad blankly with a look that Glimmer couldn't place at first. Then it hit her, it was a look she'd seen on Adora plenty of times lately when the blonde thought she wasn't looking.

Adora was in love.

With Catra. After all this time.

And as much as Glimmer hated to admit it to herself, so was she.

Chapter End Notes

I am proud to say that I have officially written up to the end of this fic and (if I can actually stick to the remaining upload schedule I've decided on and don't get impatient for you all to see it sooner) the final chapter should be out by July 7th! (Which may or may not happen to have been decided by my taste in musical artists)

Hope you enþyed the chapter (:

# Chapter Seventeen

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They didn't bring it up, but Glimmer could tell that every time Adora looked at her jacket, she thought about Catra. She got the feeling that Adora knew when Glimmer was thinking about her, too. It was like they were both ignoring that conversation for some reason, even though Glimmer knew in her heart that neither of them would be angry or upset to hear it.

It was a constant, lingering feeling that had taken root for who knows how long, always there when Adora and Glimmer were together, and- at least for Glimmer- when they were alone.

Glimmer wasn't sure what was worse, knowing she'd never get over Catra, or knowing *Adora* would never get over her. Probably both, both seems like the right answer.

Or, maybe it was the fact that neither of them could find it in themselves to say it out loud, when it was painfully obvious they both felt the same.

~

"Did you get your letter yet?" Adora asked, resting her legs against the wall as she laid back on Glimmer's bed, looking upside-down at her girlfriend over the edge of the bed. Glimmer didn't have to ask to know what she was asking about, considering Adora had been asking the same thing all week.

"Not yet." Glimmer shrugged. She'd applied to go to the same school as Adora right at the end of application season, when they'd first started going out. She thought that even if they somehow stopped dating, it would be nice to go to school with a friend. "But I'm sure I'll get in." She added to ease Adora's worries. The team captain was a lot more nervous than Glimmer was about this, honestly. Glimmer had only applied to local schools, so she'd be nearby no matter what come autumn, but Adora seemed to have her heart set on them being room-mates

Glimmer continued to look over Adora's flash cards, reviewing for the exams she wasn't so confident about even after looking through the notebook of everything they'd learned this year Entrapta had let her borrow.

"You're right, I know you can do it." Adora sighed. "I'm just being anxious."

"Well, just turn the anxiety off." Glimmer joked, lightly tugging her girlfriend's earlobe. "There, I pressed the off switch for you. You're welcome."

"Of course, why didn't I think of that?" Adora rolled her eyes and kissed her cheek, nose hitting Glimmer's chin from being the other way around.

Glimmer giggled and turned her head, kissing Adora like they were in a Spiderman movie. Their eyes locked and they both grinned, kissing again until Adora tried to lean forward and fell off the bed on her back.

"Ow . I'm fine." She groaned, rubbing her head with a weak chuckle.

"Hang on, I'll get something cold for your head." Glimmer laughed, kissing her girlfriend's nose. "Don't fall again until I come back."

"Ha ha." Adora rolled her eyes with a smile.

Glimmer left the room and quickly found an ice pack, bringing it with her back to give to Adora. She opened the door to see her girlfriend staring off into the corner of the room and giggled, walking over to rest the pack on her head as Adora made a startled noise at the sudden cold sensation.

"What are you staring at?" Glimmer wondered, kissing the blonde's cheek and ignoring the glare she was being given.

Adora moved the ice pack to the base of her spine where she'd fallen and turned her head back to the corner of the room. "I was just wondering what that box was. It wasn't here a few days ago." She said, pointing to a shelf on Glimmer's wall where she'd put the box of Catra's notes.

She swallowed down some butterflies and walked over, stretching to pull it down. "It's just some fake notes Catra gave me when we were." she trailed of f, handing the box over instead of finishing her sentence.

Adora nodded in understanding as she smiled fondly down at the box. "Y ou know, she used to give me notes, too. Probably where she got the idea." She chuckled, glancing at Glimmer for permission before lifting the lid. "W oah, there's a lot in here." She said, shaking the box side to side a bit to show how full it was.

She pulled one of the slips out and chuckled. "*Your shirt's cute today* ." She read aloud. "Are they all this poetic?" She asked sarcastically.

Glimmer's brows furrowed as she took the note from Adora's hand while the blonde started to look through them some more. "I don't know, I thought they were all blank or something." She said, taking a seat on the bed beside her girlfriend to pull a few more out as she realised they were, in fact, *not* blank.

Every single slip of paper, creased down the middle perfectly, had a note of some kind on it, some long and some short, with some being only a few words long or small sketches and doodles.

*Get a movie at night, I never admit it out bud though*

*Your hair looks really pretty swept to the side like that*

*Do you think I should get a motorbike for my bad boy image?*

Glimmer felt her chest tighten and her heart skip several beats as she read through note after note, pausing when she got to a longer that looked hastily written.

*If feel like I'm maybe reading things wrong but maybe we should chat it quits with this contract and try , like, reading? If you don't respond I just take it as a "had a never have to think about it again, okay" pressure*

Glimmer's breath stilled in her lungs as she read the note over and over again, trying to figure out when it could have been written. Was it during the ski trip? A bit before that? Or had Catra written this ages ago, and thought Glimmer rejected her offer? She and Catra had kissed a few times (okay, maybe more than a few times) during the trip, but they were never *official* or anything.

Adora glanced over before looking at her girlfriend with wide eyes, looking as stunned as Glimmer felt. "When was this?" She asked quietly.

"I don't know." Glimmer swallowed dryly and slowly shook her head. "I never actually read any of these when she gave them to me. It could have been at any time." She let out a slow, shaky breath. "She could have given me this at *any* time, and I had no idea."

Adora began gently rubbing her back as they both stared down at the note before looking up and locking eyes.

"What do we do about this?" Adora wondered.

"I- I don't know." Glimmer said, unable to use much of her brain at the moment.

"Well, what's your answer?" Adora asked instead.

Glimmer blinked in confusion. "My answer?" She echoed.

"I think Catra asked you a question. So, what's your answer?" Adora elaborated, eyes flickering towards the note before meeting Glimmer's again.

Glimmer sat quietly for a minute, trying to figure out an answer, when Adora sighed and carefully took the paper out of her girlfriend's hand.

"Do you still love her?" Adora asked, though her voice told Glimmer that she already knew the answer to that.

Nodding slowly, Glimmer whispered back. "Do you?"

Adora took a deep breath and smiled softly. "Yeah, I do."

"Do you still love *me*?" Glimmer asked next, just to make sure.

"Of course. And you still love me, right?" Adora waited for her nod before continuing. "So, I'm gonna ask again: What's your answer?"

Glimmer let the question sink in, weighing her thoughts while biting her lip. "What if she changed her mind?"

"You won't know unless you try."

Chapter End Notes

Just one more chapter to go (:

# Chapter E ghteen

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Are you ready?" Glimmer asked Adora as she handed her a water bottle on the day of her big game.

"Born ready ." Adora grinned, already sweating from the heat and warming up earlier. "What about you? Are you ready?" She asked back.

Glimmer nodded nervously and Adora kissed her cheek to ease the stress. They'd both decided that whether the team won or lost that Glimmer and Adora would tell Catra how they felt once the match ended. No big deal, it's not like they were both scared out of their minds to do so.

"Good luck." She said with a small grin and kissed her girlfriend's cheek back.

"Y ou too." Adora nodded before being called over by one of her teammates, waving as she jogged over to join the other girls.

They could do this. They *had* to do this. For Catra.

~

The game stayed pretty even throughout, both teams giving it their all to come out on top. But in the end, Adora earned her team the final shot and took the game.

Glimmer cheered loudly with the rest of the crowd as the girls shook hands on the field, glancing over to see Catra in the stands too, like Adora said she promised to be, clapping and grinning widely. Her eyes were definitely locked on Adora.

She waited by the edge of the bleachers while everyone filed out and the crowd dwindled away to nothing until only a handful of people were left. Glimmer noticed her girlfriend walking her way and ran over to hug her with a smile.

"Y ou did great."She whispered in her arms.

"W e're not done yet, though."Adora mumbled back and squeezed Glimmer just a bit tighter to her chest.

They broke apart and held each other's hand firmly as they looked up to the row of seating behind them, where Catra quickly looked away once they noticed her. Sharing a look, the couple nodded and Glimmer let go of Adora's hand to climb the steps up to her.

"Hey ."She greeted, ignoring how her heart rate tripled once she moved closer to the other girl.

"Hi."Catra said back with a smile, her hair tied back in a messy ponytail from how hot it was outside.

After a few moments of Glimmer totally not staring at Catra's freckles, she cleared her throat and spoke. "So, uh, good game, right?"She chuckled weakly .

Catra smirked at her while Glimmer's cheeks flushed. "I thought we were gonna talk to each other like real people."She teased.

Glimmer forced out a laugh and took a deep breath while she nodded. "I- Y eah, we did say that."She agreed, looking down at her feet. "Which is why I have something to say to you. That I want you to hear. Without laughing."She said, practically pushing the words out. Why was this so difficult?

"Uh, sure."Catra agreed, putting her phone in her pocket and turning towards her to show she was listening. "No laughing, listening. Got it."She said with a nod, smiling at Glimmer in confusion.

Glimmer took a deep breath and reached into her pocket, grabbing out two pieces of paper, one folded in half once and the other folded a few times to fit in her jeans. She unfurled the larger piece and cleared her throat to start reading.

"*Dear Catra,*

*I need you to know that*

Okay, sorry, can you maybe turn around or something? This is super embarrassing." Glimmer interrupted herself with a nervous grin.

Catra smiled and turned, her back facing the other girl.

"Thanks." Glimmer exhaled.

"*Dear Catra,*

*I need you to know that my first letter to you was totally meant every word, and maybe if I'd written it later the age of thirteen it wouldn't have been so dorky, but knowing me, it probably still would be.*" Pause. Breathe. "*I agreed to be your fake girlfriend because I thought it would be my only chance in the world to get close to you, to get to be around you in a more meaningful way than our normal greetings in the hall or pencil borrowing in class. I did something that I knew was wrong, because I didn't think I'd ever have something real like that with you in our fake relationship. I never thought I'd be someone's real girlfriend, especially yours or Adora's. Obviously, my thoughts on that have changed a bit now, but that's besides the point.*"

"Where's this going?" Catra wondered, chuckling when Glimmer shushed her for interrupting.

"Getting there." Glimmer huffed. "*I release now that I can be someone's girlfriend. Maybe even yours. Call me to answer a note you gave me now, if you let me.*" She finished reading and held out the slip of paper as Catra turned around, confused for a second before her eyes widened with recognition of what Glimmer was holding.

"Catra Felina, I like you. I always have. It didn't stop when we pretended to date and it didn't stop after that. I'd *love* to try dating you for real, if you'll have me." Glimmer said, looking her in the eyes.

Catra glanced between Glimmer's face and the paper before slowly reaching out to take it, glancing over it to confirm it really was what she thought it was. "I- Y ou- What about Adora?" She stuttered.

"Adora thinks it's a great idea, thanks." Adora said as if her name summoned her there a few rows of seats below them, grinning smugly with her arms crossed.

Catra looked between the two girls for a bit, shoulders tense and eyes unblinking. If Glimmer wasn't so terrified, she'd probably think it was funny.

"So you're just, what, totally fine with me and Glimmer?" Catra asked, pointing a few times between herself and the girl closer to her while she looked down at the blonde.

Adora rubbed her neck and shrugged. "I was kind of hoping this could be a me-and-you thing too, if I haven't totally blown my chances at that. I mean, you were right, our last breakup was more or less my fault, after all." She giggled anxiously.

"Me and- You and- Us three?" Catra squeaked as she looked back and forth from Glimmer to Adora before her eyes finally settled on the girl in front of her, eyes pleading for this to be real.

"Yeah. Us three." Glimmer said and took a step further with more confidence than she felt she had. "Me and you, you and her, her and me. Together."

Adora took big steps to reach them, standing behind her girlfriend as they both faced the brunette. "If you want that. And if you don't, we're totally fine staying friends. We promise." Glimmer nodded in agreement.

They both held out a hand to Catra, who stared down before slowly reaching out both hands to take them. "I want that." She admitted quietly. With a gentle tug, they pulled her closer and awkwardly tried to attempt a three-person hug.

"This is nice, but I'd like to kiss my girlfriends now." Catra joked after being squeezed from both sides for a bit.

Adora laughed and eagerly leaned in to kiss her, and for once, Glimmer didn't feel like a jealous outsider. She felt like she was part of this, and she was. Catra turned to her next, and smiled nervously as she leaned in hesitantly. Her hand came up to rest on Glimmer's cheek, and Glimmer let her hand find Catra's other one to lace their fingers together as their lips came together in their first kiss as girlfriends.

"Why aren't you that sweet when you kiss me?" Adora pouted after the other two had parted, poking Catra's cheek.

"Look at this face, 'Dora." Catra grabbed Glimmer's face with her free hand so her cheeks squished and her lips puckered. "How can I be anything but sweet?" She asked, voice dripping with sarcasm and smile teasing. "Your face doesn't look like that."

Adora scoffed and turned around dramatically to cross her arms. "Fine, enjoy your kisses, then. I'm leaving this relationship." She said, although her voice was uneven in her tell-tale sign that she was lying.

"Fine, fine. Come here, dork." Catra chuckled, grabbing Adora's wrist to turn her as she leaned in more slowly this time to kiss her in a softer way. "How's that?" She asked with a smirk.

"Uh, better." Adora said, cheeks red. Glimmer and Catra laughed until Adora started attacking their faces with kisses of her own,

ending with a lingering one to Glimmer's lips. "*Much* better."She commented.

When Glimmer's face flushed, Adora joined Catra in laughing this time.

Chapter End Notes

Well everyone, we've finally made it to the end of this love story

Only kidding, I've got an epilogue for ya before we're through with these three lovebirds' tale (;

# Epilogue

Chapter Notes

Hard to believe we've really reached the end...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After dozens of rounds of graduation pictures, Glimmer was finally released from her parents' suffocating hugs and tears to find her friends. She hugged Scorpia and other members from their friend group, and even managed a half hug from Mermista ("you better not get used to this," she'd said) before she went off to find the two people she *really* wanted to see.

"Glim!" Adora called, rushing through a crowd of their peers and parents before scooping her girlfriend up in a hug. "Catra and I have been looking everywhere for you, where have you been?" She asked, looking up at the girl in her arms.

Glimmer laughed and rested her hands on her shoulders. "Mom and Dad wanted the 'perfect picture'. That, and they wouldn't stop crying and it would be awkward to leave them like that."

Adora chuckled. "Y up, that checks out. My mom was pretty much the same way, but luckily she got caught up talking with another parent so I could escape."

"Where's Catra?" Glimmer asked, glancing around from her new, higher vantage point.

"Out by the car. Something about all the crying and hugging making her uneasy." Adora rolled her eyes fondly. "As if she doesn't do the same thing around us."

Glimmer snickered and kissed the blonde's cheek as she was lowered back onto her feet. "Let's go find her so we can go on a celebratory diner date. How much do you wanna bet she'll say 'you guys kept me waiting!' when we get there?" She joked.

"I'm not taking that bet, since I *know* it's gonna happen." Adora said with a smug grin as they exited the crowded school lawn and headed towards Catra's usual parking spot.

"There you are! You guys kept me waiting!" Catra said when they finally arrived, looking confused when Glimmer and Adora burst into laughter.

~

"Is that the last of them yet?" Catra asked after loading an overstuffed duffel bag into her car.

"Almost!" Glimmer said with a smile, quickly jogging over to hand her girlfriend the final bag of her stuff. She'd waited until the last second to pack for her new dorm room, with her first classes starting in just a few days.

After a summer of romance straight out of a teen coming of age movie and fun with her friends, university was just about to start for Glimmer and her girlfriends. She'd managed to get accepted into a school right between Catra and Adora's, meaning she'd be only half an hour away from being with either of them at any given time.

"You know you don't have to bring your entire room with you, right?" Adora giggled as she leaned against the car door.

Glimmer smiled sheepishly and offered a shrug. So what if she was indecisive about what she needed to bring?

"Be honest with me. How many of these are full of movies or hair dye?" Catra teased, earning a playful smack on the arm that made her laugh.

"Only two!" Glimmer defended herself, crossing her arms.

"And how many are full of your *clothes*?" Adora raised a brow.

Glimmer pouted and sent her a glare. "Five." She muttered.

"What was that?"

"*Five*."

Catra and Adora shared a laugh at their girlfriend's expense as Glimmer scoffed and gave each of their shoulders a shove.

"Come on, let's tell your parents we're ready for dinner if that's the last of your junk. We'll head out after we eat." Catra ruffled her hair as she passed, dodging a swat at her arm.

"It's *not* junk!" Glimmer whined.

Adora slung her arm around her shorter girlfriend's shoulders and kissed her head as they walked. "You know she just teases to get a rise out of you. Ignore her terrible jokes and she'll stop." She said with a chuckle.

"I can hear you, and I refuse to stop being the funniest person in this relationship or embarrassing either of you at any given opportunity." Catra called from a few steps ahead of them.

"Oh no, I'm dating my *dad*." Glimmer gasped dramatically before pretending to faint in Adora's arms. "I heard it was possible, but to think it would happen to me? I never saw it coming."

Catra turned around midstep to stick her tongue out at the pair while Glimmer giggled and copied her. "Not my fault your dad *also* has a killer sense of humor."

"He really doesn't." Glimmer and Adora said simultaneously. Catra frowned.

"Hate us if you ain't us." Catra shrugged and opened the door for them.

"Sure, babe." Adora smirked, kissing her cheek before stepping inside.

Glimmer hung back with Catra while Adora stepped in and started talking to her mom, Mara. "I think you're funny. *Occasionally*." She whispered.

"Occasionally? I think you mean *always*." Catra corrected with a smug grin before leaning in for a slow, loving kiss.

Smiling, Glimmer took her girlfriend's hand and tugged her inside for their last family dinner for a while now that she'd be busy with classes (*again*).

Looking at either side of her, sitting between either of the girls she'd loved for years, then at her parents (all four of them, counting George and Lance), and thought that, maybe, she could get used to this.

"What are you looking at?" Catra asked, ever-present smirk on her lips and heterochromic eyes soft as she looked at her.

Glimmer smiled back and shook her head. "Nothing. Just one of the prettiest girls in the world." She answered back casually , grinning widely when Catra's cheeks reddened.

Adora bumped their knees together gently beneath the table, and when Glimmer turned to face her, she was met with an open, loving look on her face.

Maybe she *could* get used to this.

~

Glimmer hugged her girlfriends goodbye after unloading all of her bags in the room she'd be staying until Christmas, standing under a lamppost that made her girls look even *more* angelic than normal.

"I guess I'll see you guys this weekend, right?" She asked for the tenth time since the drive over.

"Of course." Adora said, kissing both of her cheeks and her nose. "I'll count the hours if you want, so we won't be late."

"Don't make her little jock brain do that much math, Sparkles." Catra teased, even though they all knew Adora had the highest grades of any of them in high school (which already felt so far away).

Glimmer giggled and wiped away another stray tear, cursing herself for crying over something as small as being away from her girlfriends for a few days. "You don't have to do that, Adora. I know you'll remember." She said, then sighed. "I should probably go, though, so you two can get back in time for curfew."

Catra and Adora exchanged a look that carried an entire conversation, the type Glimmer was jealous of despite having her own with each of them. Adora nodded with a smile and Catra reached into her pocket.

"Actually," she pulled out a crumpled sheet of paper, "We worked on a little something for you. Been working all summer, really. You made

it look way too easy."She chuckled weakly .

Glimmer furrowed her brows as Catra and Adora both took hold of a side of the paper to look down at it, confused until they started speaking and it finally clicked.

A letter. For her.

"*Dear Glimmer* ,"Catra began.

"*We're really not poets like you, but we're gonna do our best* ." Adora continued, each of them taking a turn to read another line.

"*I remember the first day we met, it was the first day of my new school and you were the only kid with their hair dyed in those thin pink and purple strips, and it was the coolest thing I'd ever seen.* " Catra glanced at her with a smile before her gaze returned to the paper.

"*You hid behind your dad's leg when me and my mom came over to introduce ourselves, then we were just kids, and then I waved to you, you just grinned and gave this shy little wave back* ."

"*You've always been so cool, even when you didn't think you were, you always have been the coolest person I've ever met.* "

"*And you're so beautiful, inside and out, from your hair and your eyes and your smile to your personality and love of all things pink and sense of humor, every single part of you is so beautiful, Glimmer*."Adora didn't look at the paper to read that line, and Glimmer felt like sobbing just hearing it.

"*We're really trying to say here is* ,"Catra glanced at Adora to continue.

"*We love you, Glimmer. We love you so much, every single thing about you*."Adora finished.

"*And we will*."Catra nodded, then chuckled. "*You'll never get rid of us now that you made us feel for you so hard, even if you tried*."

They both looked up at their stunned girlfriend as the paper fell away at Adora's side in her hand.

"*Love, Catra*."

"*Love, Adora*."

Glimmer couldn't take it anymore, she lunged forward in a crushing hug, crying hard into their chests as they held her back just as tightly.

"Did you like it?" Adora asked despite knowing the answer.

"You better have, it took us ages to write. You made it look a lot easier than it actually is, you know." Catra added.

"I loved it! Give it to me, I'm framing it for my wall." Glimmer answered through a hiccuping sob.

Catra pulled away first, holding her cheeks as she wiped Glimmer's tears away with her thumbs even when they refused to stop pouring. Adora continued to rub Glimmer's back soothingly, both working to calm their girlfriend until Glimmer finally stopped crying.

"Can we make it Thursday instead of Friday? I don't know how I can last a full week without you guys." She asked, wiping away the last of her tears.

Catra smiled softly and nodded. "You got it."

Adora kissed her head and combed pink hair back from her face. "We'll be here whenever you want, for any reason."

Glimmer held them and kissed them until it was well past all of their dorm curfews (which they made a collective promise to not make a habit of), finally letting them go as she watched them drive away.

They'd be back before she knew it, and they'd never really leave.

Funny how it works like that when you're in love, isn't it?

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much for everyone who's been here for this journey, whether you joined early or late (or even if you're reading this months or years after publishing). Every hit, kudos, and comment on this fic fueled me to push through even when I felt like I had zero ideas for this story, I couldn't have done it without you all. Each and every one of you.

Hope you enjoyed, and thank you from the bottom of my heart for reading.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!